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EARLY LANDFALL

Rain batters A.P., Odisha on edge

Flights, trains cancelled, more than a lakh evacuated as 'very severe' Cyclone Arnab moves closer to coast

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SC questions Centre over medicine prices

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'BALANCING ACT'

India risks eroding Russia's trust

Performative diplomacy could undermine ties

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ABHISHEK, SOORYAVANSHI SHINE

India seals series win with a sizzling chase

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INSIDE



Jordanian forces kill 20 'jihadis' in retaliatory strikes

DAMASCUS
Syria on Tuesday condemned air strikes 'done without coordination' on the country's south that Jordan said killed more than 20 'jihadists' as retaliation for a gun attack on a church. The Monday night strikes came after gunmen last week killed nine people at a Greek Orthodox church in Jordan's Karak. » PAGE 14

Rape-murder accused shot in attempt to flee

KOLKATA
A 23-year-old man accused of raping and murdering a Class 11 student was shot dead by the police in North 24 Parganas district of West Bengal in the early hours of Tuesday. This is the second such incident in the State in four months, since the BJP came to power. The police said the accused snatched a police officer's firearm and opened fire. » PAGE 2

Pakistan Minister invited for SCO meeting in Delhi

NEW DELHI
The Indian government has invited Pakistan's Minister for National Heritage and Culture Aurangzeb Khan Khichi for the first "Civilisational Dialogue Forum" of the 10-nation Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) grouping, that includes Pakistan, from November 20-22 in Delhi, sources confirmed to *The Hindu*. » PAGE 4

Cheetah cub dies of gunshot injuries in M.P.

BHOPAL
A male cheetah cub that was found with gunshot injuries outside the boundaries of the Kuno National Park in Madhya Pradesh died on Tuesday during treatment in Jabalpur. A special task force has been formed to probe the killing of the cub, KNG22, after a human angle was confirmed with the recovery of five firearm pellets from the body. » PAGE 6

Opposition upset by Arlekar's KPSC move in Keralam

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM
Leader of the Opposition in Keralam Assembly Pinarayi Vijayan has said the Opposition will demand a discussion in the Assembly on former Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar's recommendation to remove the Kerala Public Service Commission chairperson and members. He urged the government not to accept the action. » PAGE 3

Will 'examine everything' in SIR case: SC

- Petitioners demand safeguarding of ECI 'records and decisions' concerning the voter roll revision
- Court lists case for mid-November hearing, issues notice on the appeal against tampering of Form 6
- CEC and ECs had said SIR decisions were lawful, and any attempts to restrain the CEC were illegal

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday said it will "examine everything" after a group of petitioners sought to safeguard records concerning the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise.

The petitioners, including Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, sought a direction from the top court to the Election Commission of India (ECI) to either preserve or file before the court the "complete records and decisions" concerning the voter roll revision.

The demand was made by senior advocate Abhishek Manu Singhvi, who represents Mr. Gandhi along with advocate S. Prasanna, before a Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant. "We will examine everything," THE Chief Justice responded to Mr. Singhvi, listing the case for mid-November.

Petitioners' demand

The rescheduling of the case happened after senior advocate Vikas Singh, appearing for lead petitioner Rakesh Kumar Singh, along with other petitioners like Shailendra Mani Tripathi, sought time to respond to an ECI affidavit to their petitions filed on Monday.

"The affidavit talks about decisions, consultations, whether unanimous decisions were taken, etc... Whereas we have only an innocuous, non-invasive demand... To file the records before Your Lordships or pass a direction to preserve the files," Mr. Singhvi submitted.

> They (ECI) issued a press note that the Supreme Court judgment in the Bihar SIR authorised the tampering of Form 6... Please see the audacity of this institution, which is justifying the tampering of Form 6
>
> **MENAKA GURUSWAMY**
> Counsel for a petitioner



The court separately issued notice on a petition filed by Mamata Trinamool Congress leader Dola Sen, represented by senior advocate Menaka Guruswamy, against the functioning of the ECI and the "tampering" of Form 6.

"They (ECI) issued a press note that the Supreme Court judgment in the Bihar SIR authorised the tampering of Form 6... Please see the audacity of this institution, which is justifying the tampering of Form 6," Ms. Guruswamy submitted. She said the ECI affidavit "accepts many of the charges we are making."

The affidavit was in response to a legal challenge which began with protests on the streets of the national capital for the removal of Mr. Kumar. The agitations had graduated into the filing of multiple petitions, ranging from ordinary individuals and activists to Opposition leaders led by Mr. Gandhi, in the Supreme Court.

The ECI said a CEC cannot be removed, except in accordance with the procedure and grounds for the ouster of a Supreme Court judge.

The affidavit saw the ECI put up a united face, with Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi speaking in one voice that their SIR decisions were in line with the law, and that any attempt to restrain the functioning of the CEC was illegal.

Media reports preceding the public protests had alleged friction within the ECI, with both Election Commissioners complaining about procedural irregularities, coupled with the unilateral and authoritarian conduct of the CEC during the mammoth SIR exercise. The SIR has excluded approximately 13 crore voters from the electoral rolls.

The affidavit has denied charges that Form 6 was changed. It has justified that the additional declaration form provided alongside Form 6 was not a "part" of the statutory form. Voters whose names were deleted from the electoral roll during the SIR exercise have to fill up their Form 6, as well as "map" their previous electoral roll entries to those of their parents and grandparents in the additional declaration form.

The affidavit also submitted that officials with the West Bengal Chief Electoral Officer had filed appeals against the inclusion of deleted voters. Petitioners have contended that these appeals, numbering over 16 lakh in West Bengal, were choking the Appellate Tribunals.

"There is a lot to be said on this affidavit," Mr. Vikas Singh submitted.

Senior advocate Maninder Singh appeared for the ECI and questioned the petitioners' request to the court. Mr. Maninder Singh said the submission made on behalf of Ms. Sen's petition was "rhetoric meant for some other purpose," even as Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, representing the Union government, said the court should not be made into a political forum.

The court gave the ECI liberty to file any supplementary affidavit, if necessary.

Golden glow



Colourful celebration: A fireworks display is held over the illuminated Golden Temple on the birth anniversary of the fourth Guru of the Sikhs, Sri Guru Ramdas Ji, in Amritsar, Punjab, on Tuesday. ANI

Over 99 lakh names deleted from the final electoral list in Karnataka after SIR exercise

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

A whopping 99.32 lakh names have been struck off from the electoral rolls in Karnataka following the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise. The number of voters in the final list published on Tuesday came down from 5,54,32,314 before the exercise began, to 4,55,00,011, including 44,322 Service electors.

The constituency-wise electoral rolls can be accessed on the website of the Karnataka Chief Electoral Officer (CEO).

At the draft stage, the electorate had shrunk to 4.46 crore, with more than1.07 crore names deleted. The final roll has seen a net addition of 8.19 lakh names compared with the draft roll. However, the net additions have barely offset the deletions, knocking off nearly one crore names from the pre-SIR electorate.

The net addition figures given by the CEO's office does not indicate how many people who were wrongly excluded have managed to get back on the rolls. Nor does the figure provide a separate break-up of young or first-time voters added during the exercise, making it difficult to ascertain how many of those deleted have been reinstated.

More additions

Those who applied for inclusion in the rolls through Form 6 during the claims and objections period, which ended on September 23, would have had their names included in the final roll if their applications were accepted. Those who applied after the deadline will be included in supplementary lists, which will be published every quarter after the SIR.

Karnataka CEO V. Anbu Kumar said that the population-to-electors ratio should ideally be between 60 and 70, and that of the State stood at 66.11.

"Karnataka has more than 6.87 crore total population (projected as on the proposed publication year 2026), as per the Population Projections for India and States 2011-2036 published by National Commission on Population Ministry of Health and Family Welfare and 4.54 crore (general electors) in the number of electors in the final roll," the CEO said.

However, Mr. Kumar did not explain how a gap of about 2.33 crore between the projected population and the electorate is accounted for, including how much of it comprises people below 18 years, non-voter residents and eligible voters who may have been left out.

The final electorate comprises more than 2.25 crore male voters, 2.29 crore female voters and 2,841 third-gender voters. It also includes more than 6.83 lakh young voters in the 18-19 age group and more than 3.92 lakh voters aged above 85, besides 44,322 service electors.

The largest pool of electors, 1,02,57,680, belongs to the 30-39 age group, followed by 94,17,853 voters aged between 40 and 49.

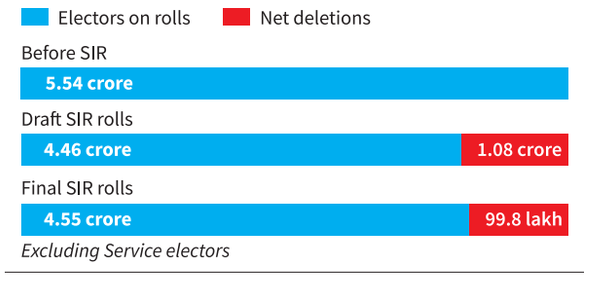
Form 6 applications

Between June 16 and September 23, the last date for claims and objections, over 7.87 lakh Form 6 applications were received. Of these, 76,231 were rejected and 3,193 remained pending, while 7.08 lakh were accepted, as *The Hindu* previously reported. The CEO's office said that over one lakh Form 6 applications submitted after the claims period were also processed to ensure maximum additions.

Till October 26, a total of 10.62 lakh Form 6 applications had been received (since June 16), of which 83,806 were rejected on grounds including applicants having applied unknowingly though already registered elsewhere, failure to submit documents and other reasons. The CEO's office said instructions had been issued to all District Electoral Officers (DEOs) to reach out to applicants whose applications were rejected and include their names if they could be contacted and found eligible.

Sharp drop

The electorate shrunk by 18% even after a net addition of 8.2 lakh voters during SIR claims and objections phase



Excluding Service electors

Record turnout as Israelis cast votes in polls centred around Netanyahu

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, fighting for his political life, scrambled to bring out his base on Tuesday as Israelis voted in record numbers in the country's first election since the October 7, 2023 attack.

After casting his vote in Jerusalem, Mr. Netanyahu expressed worry over high voting among Israel's Arab minority and warned of attempts to "steal the election".

Nationwide turnout as of 6:00 p.m. was 66.7%, the highest at that point in the day since such statistics were first recorded in 1973, the Central Elections Committee said.



Benjamin Netanyahu

The vote comes as Israel looks increasingly isolated on the world stage, driven by the war in Iran and the devastating military campaign in Gaza, and violence in the occupied West Bank.

Tight contest

The last opinion polls showed Mr. Netanyahu, Israel's longest-serving Prime Minister, running neck and neck with his main rival Gadi Eisenkot, a former military chief.

Mr. Eisenkot's Yashar party on Tuesday warned that Mr. Netanyahu was "laying the groundwork to challenge election results".

Speaking at a polling station, Mr. Eisenkot called on Israelis to ignore distractions and vote to replace "the worst government since the state was established".

Some 7.3 million people are eligible to vote, with tens of thousands of Israelis estimated to have flown in from abroad for the election.

Mr. Netanyahu has pointed to Arab-Israeli parties throughout the election to stoke fears of a Palestinian state. "We cannot leave this battle here in the hands of the left and the Arab parties that want to bring an end to the Jewish state," Mr. Netanyahu said, urging Israelis to vote for his right-wing Likud party.

United Arab List head Mansour Abbas, who could emerge as a kingmaker in a close election, accused Mr. Netanyahu of "lying and inciting" to mobilise his voters.

Polling will close at 10 p.m. Final results could take days to trickle in and it is highly unlikely that any single party will get the 61 seats needed for a majority in the 120-member Parliament.

INBRIEF



U.P. approves robotics park and AI hub in Greater Noida

The Uttar Pradesh Cabinet on Tuesday approved the establishment of a robotics and artificial intelligence (AI) park in Greater Noida spread over 69.52 acres, estimated to generate more than 1 lakh jobs and add ₹2,000 crore annually to the State's economy. "In a major step towards establishing Uttar Pradesh as a leading hub for advanced technology, industrial innovation and robotics manufacturing, the Cabinet, chaired by Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, on Tuesday approved a proposal to set up the PRAGATI (Platform for Robotics and AI Growth Through Technology and Innovation) Park.

Prohibitory orders imposed in Himachal's Nahan town

Prohibitory orders restricting the assembly of people have been imposed till October 29 in certain parts of Nahan town in Himachal Pradesh's Sirmaur district, where a dispute between two communities had turned violent, officials said on Tuesday. District Magistrate, Sirmaur, Priyanka Verma, imposed the orders late Monday night following reports that people belonging to the Sikh and Valmiki communities from Himachal Pradesh, Haryana, and Punjab are expected to arrive at the Valmiki Chowk to hold a protest in favour of their communities. On Friday, a dispute arose between two groups over the installation of a 'welcome gate' by the Sikhs. PTI

Rape-murder accused shot dead in Bengal; second 'police encounter' in three months

Police say they opened fire in self-defence after accused 'snatched' an officer's service revolver and fired at them; security beefed up after residents' protest, leading to tension in the neighbourhood

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA



On July 8, a similar 'encounter' took place in Baruipur when the police took the prime accused in a rape and murder case to reconstruct the crime scene. FILE PHOTO

A 23-year-old man arrested for the alleged rape and murder of a Class 11 student was shot dead in a "police encounter" in West Bengal's Bongaon police district in the early hours of Tuesday, officials said. This is the second such incident in the State in the last three months since the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government came to power in May this year.

The accused, Prahlad Das, allegedly snatched a police officer's service revolver during the reconstruction of the crime scene in Bongaon between 3 a.m. and 3.30 a.m., fired at police personnel and jumped into a pond in an attempt to escape, according to police sources.

The police opened fire in self-defence, the sources added. Das was rushed to a local hospital, where he was declared dead.

The accused's death came two days after the 17-year-old girl's body was found behind her neighbour's house on Sunday, a day after she went missing from her home. Das was arrested the same day, and a court sent him to 10 days of police custody. A Special Investigation Team was formed to investigate the case.

Additional police personnel were deployed in the area after local residents started protesting against the incident, leading to tension in the neighbourhood. Forensic teams visited the encounter site later on Tuesday to collect samples. The victim's father said, "It is good that the police 'encountered' him. But will this bring back my daughter?"

On July 8, a similar encounter took place in Baruipur, South 24 Parganas district, when police took Prabhas Mondal, the prime accused in the rape and murder of a minor girl, to reconstruct the crime scene.

BJP State president Samik Bhattacharya said the death of two rape-murder accused in alleged gunfight with the police in two districts cannot be called "encounters". "In many situations, police may have to open fire, especially when they are attacked," he said.

Oppn. attacks govt.

Communist Party of India (Marxist) State secretary Mohammad Salim criticised the government, saying instead of relying on the rule of law, people are taking the law into their own hands. On Monday, the Mamata All India Trinamool Congress raised concerns over women's safety in the State.

T.N. jailbreak: 17 prisoners escape; 13 of them caught

L. Srikrishna
THENI



A police team searching for prisoners who escaped from the Thekkampatti sub-jail on Tuesday. G. KARTHIKEYAN

In a coordinated escape attempt, 17 remand prisoners broke out of the Thekkampatti sub-jail near Andipatti in Theni district of Tamil Nadu around 11 p.m. on Monday after attacking prison warders. As of 5 p.m. on Tuesday, 13 of them were apprehended by special police teams.

Following the incident, the district police sounded an alert and deployed a large number of police personnel at checkpoints across Tamil Nadu and on borders with Keralam.

Inspector-General of Police (South Zone) Vijayendra Bidari rushed to the spot and held an inquiry with Theni Superintendent of Police Praveen Gowtham and others. As many as 17 special teams were formed and plainclothesmen had been deployed to different locations since 3 a.m.

The police conducted search operations with three high-definition drones in the forest areas of the district.

Preliminary inquiries revealed that on Monday night, 17 accused, who were all remand prisoners aged 20-25 years, escaped after assaulting the jail staffers, who opened the gates of the cell following claims that an inmate was having epileptic fits. Soon, all the inmates walked towards the main gate in small groups. At the main gate, they assaulted the armed guard, took the gate keys, and fled. With the terrain around the jail being mountainous, the prisoners escaped deep into the forests.

A police officer monitoring the combing operation in Theni said within a few hours, they secured one of the escapees from a forest area. In the next few hours, three others were nabbed. The fifth person to be caught was a person with disabilities. Eight other escapees were secured in the evening.

Arunachal Pradesh Minister meets 'dam-affected' people

Press Trust of India
ITANAGAR



A drone view shows the settlements that are believed to be at risk of submersion from the proposed project in Siang. FILE PHOTO

Arunachal Pradesh Minister Ojing Tasing on Tuesday held discussions with a delegation of the East Siang Downstream Dam Affected People's Forum (ESDDAPF) on the concerns surrounding the proposed Siang Upper Multipurpose Project.

The forum was led by its president Oni Tamuk and general secretary Jobomchang Mengu, and represents communities spanning 72 villages that could be affected by the project.

In a post on X, Mr. Tasing, the Rural Development and Panchayati Raj Minister, said the interaction provided a platform to discuss the project and its prefeasibility report (PFR), address apprehensions and clarify misconceptions about its potential implications for downstream communities in East Siang district. Emphasising the need to balance national priorities with local interests, Mr. Tasing, who represents the Pangin Assembly constituency in Siang district, said a project of such significance must advance with the trust and confidence of the people.

The proposed project is a hydropower and water-storage initiative, with a planned capacity of around 11,200 MW. The project is being examined for its potential to strengthen India's energy and water security, and facilitate flood moderation. Its strategic significance has also been linked to concerns over possible upstream interventions in the Brahmaputra basin.

The project, however, has generated concerns over its potential social and environmental consequences, including the implications for downstream communities.

Chief Minister Pema Khandu said in September that the PFR was necessary to establish the project's technical viability and that the government did not intend to rush beyond the feasibility stage.

Majhi urges Patnaik not to politicise Kotia dispute, reiterates Odisha's territorial claim

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR



Both Odisha and Andhra Pradesh claim 21 villages under Kotia gram panchayat to be under their jurisdiction since 1955. FILE PHOTO

Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi on Tuesday urged his predecessor Naveen Patnaik to offer suggestions for resolving the dispute over the Kotia group of villages, instead of viewing the sensitive issue through a political prism.

In response to Mr. Patnaik's October 19 letter over the issue, Mr. Majhi said, "The Kotia group of villages has been an integral part of Odisha since the formation of a separate State of Odisha in 1936. The State government remains firmly committed to safeguarding the territorial integrity and legitimate interests of Odisha."

In his October 19 letter, Mr. Patnaik had flagged the issue of elections announced by Andhra Pradesh in Kotia in Odisha's Koraput district.

Both Odisha and Andhra Pradesh claim 21 villages under Kotia gram panchayat to be under their jurisdiction since 1955.

"Despite Odisha having a so-called 'double-engine' government, it is deeply concerning that Andhra Pradesh has proceeded to announce elections in Kotia. What happened to the Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) assurances that Kotia belongs to Odisha?" the former Chief Minister had said.

Mr. Manji said, "I am constrained to observe that the contents of your letter appear to approach this sensitive issue from a political standpoint rather than advance constructive and legally tenable solutions for its resolution."

Stating that government consistently upheld the State's territorial interests through constitutional means, the Chief Minister said, "The State has accorded priority to the development of Kotia and the adjoining areas, with the objective of ensuring inclusive growth, improving the delivery of public services, and enhancing the well-being of the local population."

He added that Revenue and Disaster Management Minister Suresh Pujari, who is heading a committee on Kotia, has made several visits to the region to facilitate coordinated action for the holistic development of the area.

In his letter, Mr. Patnaik had also raised questions over the BJP's political dependence on the Telugu Desam Party (TDP), which governs Andhra Pradesh. "What makes this even more troubling is that the TDP is a crucial ally of the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance government and is much needed to maintain its majority at the Centre. Is political dependence the reason for the Odisha BJP government's silence and its willingness to compromise Odisha's interests and territorial integrity?"

Meanwhile, Mr. Pujari has sought the cooperation of all political parties to protect the State's territorial integrity.

HC quashes FIR against Pune student for digital post

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

The Bombay High Court on Tuesday quashed a criminal case registered against a 20-year-old engineering student for reposting a controversial comment on 'Operation Sindoor', observing that the post was an isolated act followed by voluntary deletion and remorse.

A chance is required to be given in such cases, a single Bench of Justice Milind Jadhav said, noting that the student has already suffered custody. "That in itself for a young student is a scar which cannot be erased easily," Justice Jadhav said.

The female student from a private college in Pune was arrested on May 9, 2025, over the Instagram repost related to India-Pakistan tensions following Operation Sindoor.

A Delhi event reveals fault lines in Dalit-OBC formulation of Samajwadi Party politics

NEWS ANALYSIS

Anuj Kumar
GHAZIABAD

In the high-stakes arena of Uttar Pradesh elections, the line between social representation and competitive polarisation is razor-thin. Samajwadi Party (SP) spokesperson Rajkumar Bhati discovered it last week when he faced trolls from the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and a reprimand from the party's top leadership after participating in a Buddhist Dhamma Diksha ceremony in Delhi.

During the annual ceremony, Mr. Bhati, a prominent OBC leader of SP in western U.P., participated in the mass recitation of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar's 22 vows. The viral video recorded him explicitly repeating the controversial opening segments of the pledge, which include the statements: "I will not consider Brahma, Vishnu, and Mahesh as gods, nor will I worship them. I will not consider Rama and Krishna as gods, nor will I worship them." He was also filmed repeating the vow to refuse any religious rituals performed by Brahmin priests.

The 22 vows, which Ambedkar took with his followers on October 14, 1956, stem from his formulation of Navayana Buddhism. He drafted the vows as an explicit checklist to guarantee a complete, irreversible psychological break from the Hindu social order.

A Gurjar by birth, Mr. Bhati organised a massive rally for party president Akhilesh Yadav in March this year. His Dalit push seemed in line with the party's Lohiate policy of numerical aggregation, uniting everyone outside the so-called upper-caste hegemony to capture state power. Ram Manohar Lohia's "Socialisto *ne bandhi ganth, pichhde paavein sau mein saat*", referring to roughly 40% OBC and 20% SC vote in the State, still echoes in the air. He also put forward the idea of *roti-beti* for intermingling of castes. SP founder Mulayam Singh Yadav put the slogan into action by joining hands with Bahujan Samaj Party founder Kanshi Ram in 1993, captured by the popular slogan, '*Mile* Mulayam-Kanshi Ram, *hawa mein ud gaye* Jai Shri Ram' - but the caste barriers remained. Now Mr. Akhilesh seeks to revive Lohia's logic through his comprehensive PDA (Pichhda, Dalit, Alpsankhyak) formula.



SP chief Akhilesh Yadav paying tribute to Dr. B.R. Ambedkar on his birth anniversary, in Lucknow on April 14 this year. ANI

Ambedkar's 22 vows

However, his uncles, Ram Gopal Yadav and Shivpal Yadav, reacted to Mr. Bhati's overtures, reviving Ambedkar's fears about numerical aggregation. While Mr. Ram Gopal threatened to strip Mr. Bhati of his post in the party, Mr. Shivpal said, "*Hum Ishwarwadi hain*." Political observers feel the Yadav leadership can't separate its cultural ties to Lord Krishna. A Shiva temple has come up in the Yadav stronghold of Saifai, whose trust is headed by Mr. Akhilesh.

Facing an FIR, Mr. Bhati clarified that he repeated the words out of respect for the organisers and Ambedkar, without intending to change his religion. But he also underlined that Ambedkarites would understand the spirit of his stance and respond to his right-wing trolls.

The Bhati episode mirrors previous political flashpoints, demonstrating that while mainstream parties actively engage in competitive adulation of Ambedkar, their leadership quickly distances itself the moment a politician explicitly recites the radical, anti-scriptural elements of his 22 vows.

In 2022, Rajendra Pal Gautam, a prominent Dalit leader and senior Minister in Arvind Kejriwal's Delhi Cabinet, took the same vows at the same event and faced similar pressure from the BJP and its *parivar* ahead of Gujarat polls. Mr. Gautam resigned and subsequently joined the Congress in 2024. Today, he is the All India Congress Committee in-charge for U.P. and is seen as the central leadership's eyes and ears.

Whether Mr. Bhati is on a similar trajectory and sees a space in an idea-rich, cadre-thin Congress if SP gives in, only time will tell. Rumblings in the INDIA bloc suggest the SP leadership wants Congress to bring in a share of the mature Dalit vote.

When Ajay Rai was replaced and the State Congress presidency was split between Mona Misra and Imran Masood, a senior SP insider told this journalist that if the Congress really wants to turn the clock back, instead of focusing on Brahmins and Muslims, it should try to win back 40-plus Dalit voters from Mayawati's hold. "The rest we will manage," he said. This is the voter Mr. Bhati was addressing.

Vote bank in sight

For now, Mr. Akhilesh, who has often cited an incident where a temple was cleaned with 'Ganga jal' after his visit, hasn't taken a stance on Mr. Bhati's vows. Political observers feel the BJP seeks to appropriate Ambedkar the same way Brahminical scholars appropriated Gautam Buddha as part of the Hindu pantheon, but the Hindutva ecosystem doesn't want to extend reservation benefits to those who openly negate the presence of Brahma, Vishnu, and Mahesh, and herein the Opposition sees a vote bank.

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INBRIEF



Keralam private bus operators begin indefinite hunger strike

Private bus operators in Keralam began an indefinite hunger strike in front of the Secretariat in the capital on Tuesday, seeking steps to protect the sector, which is in crisis following the introduction of the Priyadarshini free bus travel scheme for women. Seeking an increase in bus fares and timely permit renewal, the Bus and Car Operators Confederation of India said the free travel scheme had dented their income. The rise in fuel prices had added to the misery, it said.

Jumbo calf dies after slipping down steep slope in Wayanad

A female elephant calf died after slipping down a slope at Muthumari in Wayanad, Keralam. The incident occurred on a privately-owned plantation on Sunday. CCTV footage shows the calf, around one-and-a-half years old, tumble down as its herd trumpet loudly and desperately try to rescue it. The incident was accidental and no case has been registered, an official said. On Monday, Forest officials retrieved the carcass. "It was buried after post-mortem," the official said.

South Central Railway cancels express trains towards Vizag

The South Central Railway on Tuesday announced the cancellation of popular daily express trains towards Visakhapatnam – including Godavari, Gautami, Visakha, Falaknuma, Narsapur, Garib Rath and a few others – in view of Cyclone Arnab. Officials urged passengers to plan their journeys carefully as the cyclone is likely to cross the Andhra Pradesh coast between Bapatla and Visakhapatnam, near Yanam, early on Wednesday.

NDA ahead in Karnataka MLC polls, Congress trails

NDA bags two seats and was leading in the remaining two where counting was under way past midnight; JD(S)'s Ranganath wrests Bengaluru Teachers' constituency from Congress by 908 votes

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU/ HUBBALLI/ KALABURGI



Supporters of NDA candidate for Bengaluru Teachers' Constituency A.P. Ranganath celebrate his victory on Tuesday. J. ALLEN EGENUSE

The ruling Congress could be staring at an embarrassing loss in the Karnataka Legislative Council elections where the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) has won in two seats and is leading in the other two where counting was still under way at the time of going to press.

The biggest upset for the Congress came from the Bengaluru Teachers' constituency where five-time MLC and former Deputy Chairman Puttanna lost to NDA candidate A.P. Ranganath [of the JD(S)] by 908 votes.

Of the four constituencies that went into polls on October 23, three constituencies were held by the BJP and the Bengaluru Teachers' constituency was held by the Congress.

"..This is an indication for the 2028 elections," Union Minister H.D. Kumaraswamy said on X.

The BJP's Shashil Namoshi will enter the Legislative Council for his fifth term after defeating the Congress' candidate Sharanappa Mattur by 3,297 votes in the North-East Teachers' Constituency.

At the time of going to press, the BJP candidate and sitting member S.V. Sankanur was leading against his Congress rival Mohan Limbikai, a former MLC, by a margin of 3,529 votes after second round of counting in Karnataka West Graduates' Constituency.

In Karnataka South East Graduates' Constituency, the BJP candidate K.M. Suresha, who has secured 6,296 votes, was leading against Congress candidate Shashi Hulkuntemutt, who secured 5,174 votes at the first round of counting.

Pinarayi to seek Assembly discussion on Arlekar's move to remove PSC members

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Leader of the Opposition in the Keralam Assembly Pinarayi Vijayan said the Opposition will demand a discussion in the Assembly on former Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar's "unilateral" recommendation to remove the Kerala Public Service Commission (PSC) chairperson and members.

The CPI(M) veteran cited reports which claimed that the recommendation had been made to the President for the first time in the State's history.

The Governor had allegedly exercised excessive powers even before the report of the probe by the State government into the PSC's functioning had been completed. The ongoing Crime Branch probe has not found lapses on the part of the PSC chairperson or members thus far, he said in a statement.

Mr. Vijayan urged the government not to accept the action, and cautioned against supporting the purported legal violations being done by the BJP-led Centre through Governors.

'Probe progressing'

Meanwhile, the State informed the High Court that the investigation was "vigorously" progressing into the alleged irregularities in the Planning Board exam conducted by the KPSC.

Justice A. Badharudeen granted time to the de facto complainant, V.S. Jayalal, to file objections. It apprised the court that the commission had suspended two persons over the alleged irregularities. The State sought to know how the commission could seek to quash the FIR, if it was taking action on the allegations. The KPSC had approached the court seeking to quash the sanction granted by the government to prosecute commission's employees and the FIR registered in connection.

ED attaches assets worth ₹23.35 crore in Veerendra case

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU



The ED said its investigation has uncovered a network of illegal online betting platforms.

The Directorate of Enforcement (ED) has provisionally attached movable and immovable properties worth ₹23.35 crore belonging to Congress MLA from Chitradurga K.C. Veerendra and his associates in connection with an illegal online betting and money-laundering racket.

The attachment includes movable assets valued at ₹13.76 crore and immovable properties worth ₹9.18 crore, taking the total to ₹23.35 crore. The attachment was made under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, through a Provisional Attachment Order dated October 23, 2026.

According to the ED, its investigation has uncovered a nationwide network of illegal online betting platforms, including King 567, a betting app operated through payment gateways, shell companies and mule bank accounts. Players were allegedly induced to deposit money into these platforms and subsequently cheated through manipulated betting operations and blocked withdrawals.

The agency has traced suspected proceeds of the crime exceeding ₹2,300 crore. The funds were allegedly routed through multiple bank accounts, hawala channels, and offshore entities before being used to acquire luxury assets, make business investments, transfer money abroad and meet personal expenses.

The ED alleged that Veerendra and his associates concealed, possessed and projected the proceeds of crime as untainted property, attracting the provisions of Section 3 of the PMLA.

Investigators also found that Fonepaisa Payment Solutions Private Limited, beneficially owned by Gulshan Khattar, had received proceeds of crime as compensation for providing payment gateway and financial intermediary services to the alleged betting network.

Assets worth approximately ₹30 crore had previously been attached in connection with the company through an attachment order dated January 29, 2026.

The investigation further revealed that SunTech IT Solutions Private Limited had received credits from identified mule bank accounts linked to King 567. Neha Tandon, a director of the company, allegedly had no active role in its management, according to the ED.

Hyderabad Police launch dedicated wing to probe serious crimes

Abhinay Deshpande
HYDERABAD

Hyderabad City Police on Tuesday launched a Zonal Investigation Branch in the Golconda Zone as a pilot project to separate crime investigation from routine law and order duties.

Hyderabad Police Commissioner V.C. Sajjanar inaugurated the branch at the Golconda Zone Deputy Commissioner of Police office in Mehdipatnam.

The new wing will investigate serious and complex cases registered at police stations across the zone, allowing local police personnel to focus on maintaining law and order and preventing crime.

According to the police, investigations are often affected as station staff have to handle criminal cases alongside routine duties. The dedicated branch is expected to reduce their workload and improve the quality of probes.

The team will comprise two detective inspectors, one sub-inspector, one head constable and 10 constables. It will coordinate with the Health department, Forensic Science Laboratory, and prosecution officials to collect scientific evidence and file charge sheets within the prescribed timelines.

They would work with the Investigation Monitoring Cell to monitor the progress of investigations into serious crimes.

Mr. Sajjanar said similar branches would be established in other zones of the Commissionerate based on the outcome of the pilot project in the Golconda Zone.

Red salute



Flames that endure: CPI(M) leader and former Keralam Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, and other leaders attend a function to mark the 80th anniversary of the 1946 Punnapra-Vayalar peasant revolt against the princely state of Travancore, in Alappuzha on Tuesday. SURESH ALLEPPEY

Sugar mills, growers move closer to price settlement

The Hindu Bureau
HUBBALLI

CM Shivakumar mediated between the two sides for nearly 10 hours in Belagavi on Sunday

A prolonged deadlock between sugar cane growers and sugar mill owners in Karnataka moved closer to resolution after Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar mediated between the two sides for nearly 10 hours in Belagavi on Sunday.

The two sides have agreed in principle to determine the price sugar factories should pay farmers after the Centre fixes the minimum selling price (MSP) of sugar, Mr. Shivakumar said. Representatives of farmers and sugar mills are expected to announce their final decision within two days.

The negotiations were held at the Suvarna Vidhana Soudha and the Circuit House, beginning around 11 a.m. and continuing until midnight. Five rounds of talks were conducted, involving farmers' representatives, sugar mill owners, nine Ministers and around 70 legislators. Representatives of 79 of the 80 sugar factories participated.

Speaking to reporters later, Mr. Shivakumar said, the mill owners had agreed to the proposed approach of linking the price payable to growers to the Centre's decision on minimum selthe MSP of sugar. The farmers, however, had sought two days to discuss the proposal among themselves before arriving at a final decision.

Final decision awaited

He said the government would support both farmers and mill owners in reaching a settlement, and continue engaging with the Centre. The farmers had already held talks with a Union Minister and received assurances, he added.

The understanding reached during the talks on October 25 is yet to receive the final endorsement from farmers. Their representatives will discuss among themselves over the next two days before announcing their decision.

4 police officers suspended for mishandling Kochi crash case

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Keralam government on Tuesday suspended four police officers attached to the Cheranalloor police station on the charge of mishandling the case relating to the death of a 55-year-old man allegedly knocked down by a speeding luxury car driven by the 17-year-old son of an additional judge.

The action followed a report submitted to the Home department by ADGP P. Vijayan.

The officers suspended are Sub-Inspector and Station House Officer Viswajith V.S., Circle Inspector Syam Kumar K.S., Grade Assistant Sub-Inspector Manoj K.T., and Senior Civil Police Officer Arun Joshy.



ADGP P. Vijayan visits the site where the fatal accident took place in Cheranalloor.

The Cheranalloor police have come under criticism amid allegations that officers were rude to the victim's family, invoked relatively minor charges against the accused, and delayed action against the judge, the father of the accused teenager. It was also alleged that Mr. Joshy forcibly took away a mobile phone from the victim's family and deleted photographs of the accused they had taken.

The arrest of the father-son duo, suspension of the judge, and action against the police officers were the three major demands raised by the victim's son and daughter, who staged a protest in front of the police station for hours on Monday before calling it off following assurances from Mr. Chennithala.

In a Facebook post, the Chief Minister assured that the family would be provided all necessary legal assistance.

NDA reaches consensus on seat-sharing for Andhra Pradesh local body election

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

The National Democratic Alliance (NDA) partners in Andhra Pradesh have reached a consensus on seat-sharing arrangements for local body elections.

However, the alliance leaders differed on how the outcome of the local body elections should be interpreted. While Telugu Desam Party (TDP) president and Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu described the polls as a "mid-term appraisal" of the NDA government in the State, Jana Sena Party (JSP) president and Deputy Chief Minister Pawan Kalyan said they were "not a referendum" on the alliance.



Chandrababu Naidu, Pawan Kalyan, and P.V.N. Madhav at the press meet at Chief Minister's camp office in Amaravati on Tuesday. ANI

Mr. Naidu, Mr. Kalyan and BJP State president P.V.N. Madhav addressed a press conference at the Chief Minister's Office near Vijayawada on Tuesday. Describing the seat-sharing negotiations as unprecedented in his political career, Mr. Naidu said he had never witnessed such detailed discussions on local body elections in his 50 years in politics.

'Churning of the ocean'

Mr. Kalyan said that while seat-sharing for Assembly and Lok Sabha elections could be handled more straightforwardly, reaching an understanding for local body elections posed a major challenge. Describing the negotiations as a "churning of the ocean", Mr. Madhav said the discussions had ultimately helped the three parties arrive at a consensus and work together.

Mr. Naidu urged alliance leaders and workers to support only those candidates who had been officially allotted B-forms. He said the alliance would ensure that those who had filed nominations but were not selected would also be treated fairly. "We have given opportunities to educated candidates, youth and people with integrity. The scrutiny and effort we have put into candidate selection this time is greater than what we did even during the general polls."

SC Collegium recommends 4 judges as HC Chief Justices

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court Collegium has recommended four judges for appointment as Chief Justices of the High Courts of Gujarat, Delhi, Telangana and Uttarakhand.

Justice Manash Ranjan Pathak, who is currently serving as a judge in the Gujarat High Court, has been recommended for appointment as its Chief Justice in a Supreme Court Collegium resolution of October 26.

Justice Pathak's parent High Court is Gauhati.

Justice P. Sam Koshy, whose parent High Court is Chhattisgarh and is currently serving on the Bench of the Telangana High Court, has been proposed for the Delhi High Court Chief Justiceship.

Justices Tapabrata Chakraborty of Calcutta High Court and Sudhir Singh of Patna High Courts have been recommended for appointments as Chief Justices of Telangana and Uttarakhand High Courts, respectively.

The Supreme Court Collegium has approved the proposal for appointment of Ajay Sharma, Judicial Member, CESTAT, Mumbai, and advocate Vaibhav Anant Sugdare as judges of the Bombay High Court.

Science successful only when society benefits from it: Modi

PM stresses on importance of taking science from laboratory to land; he says India is no longer playing catch up and emerged as leader in scientific, technological developments in 21st century

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday said science succeeds only when it travels from the laboratory to the land and improves people's lives.

Addressing the Emerging Science, Technology and Innovation Conclave (ESTIC), he said it must not become "merely a forum for discussion" but should deliver measurable outcomes.


Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the Emerging Science, Technology and Innovation Conclave 2026 in New Delhi on Tuesday. PTI

Mr. Modi said India's science and technology story has long been one of catching up with other countries, but in the 21st century the country has emerged as a leader in scientific and technological developments. He said, "The discovery of zero showed that India has a culture of discovery. Chandrayaan's landing near the lunar south pole, Mangalyaan's success on the first attempt, and the vaccines developed during the COVID-19 pandemic are examples of this."

The audience at the conclave comprised three Nobel Laureates, top technocrats of India's scientific establishment, startup founders and scientists from both India and abroad.

Focus on research

Mr. Modi said a country's technological capabilities depend on its research. He said efforts to "speed up" the Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF) work are underway. Referring to research funding, he cited a commitment of ₹1 lakh crore, including ₹12,000 crore for taking research from the laboratory to the market, with private investors partnering equally. He also referred to new commitments of ₹24,000 crore.

The number of patents filed in India had risen from about 50,000 to 1.5 lakh, Mr. Modi said, describing this as evidence of a strengthening culture of innovation rather than merely an increase in number.

Science in the age of AI

On artificial intelligence (AI), he posed what he called an "important question" about how to exercise scientific judgement in the age of AI.

"Science works by questioning paradigms and looking at problems with fresh eyes," he said. "AI can perform routine tasks quickly and raise productivity, but should not limit scientists' thinking or independent thought, and its answers must meet the accuracy standards of scientists."

Referring to the birth anniversary of nuclear scientist Homi J. Bhabha on October 30, Mr. Modi said a developed India will need large quantities of nuclear energy. He noted that the 500 MW Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor (PFBR) has reached first criticality, strengthening the country's long-term energy position.

He also pointed to Indian space start-ups, a rocket made in India that placed a satellite in orbit on its first attempt, and the country's satellite docking capability. Indian-made AI chips are reaching other countries, an AI model has been built domestically, and work is underway on battery technology based on Indian raw materials, he said. The needs of sectors ranging from nuclear energy to space to AI and semiconductors differ, he said, but India's emerging technologies are rising together.

Describing India as a young country with vision and imagination, Mr. Modi said it needs a generation capable of leading in technology. He summed up the guiding principle as: "We will do it."

Nobel winner backs GM crop innovation in India

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

Richard J. Roberts, the 1993 Nobel laureate in Physiology or Medicine, on Tuesday dismissed as "nonsense" the idea that Indians adopting genetically modified crops would become dependent on foreign companies.

The work can be done in, and owned by, Indian laboratories, he said.

Dr. Roberts was delivering a plenary address at the second Emerging Science, Technology and Innovation Conclave (ESTIC) at Bharat Mandapam.

In his address, he rejected the term 'genetically modified' as "very misleading" and referred to such crops throughout as "biotechnologically modified," or BM, arguing that "every life form on this planet has been genetically modified by evolution."

Asked about fears that an American corporation such as Monsanto (whose operations were subsumed into that of agrochemicals giant Bayer) could control the seed supply and erode the country's independence, Dr. Roberts replied: "I think it's nonsense. You can do improved agriculture here in the labs in India and own everything here in India. You don't have to go to America or Europe or anywhere else


Richard J. Roberts

to make CRISPR-modified plants. Anybody can do it. You go to a lab, learn how to do it – maybe it takes you six to eight weeks – and then you can do it. It's really very straightforward because we've come a long way in knowing how to improve crops. But you can own it here in India. "

CRISPR is a gene-editing tool in which a guide RNA steers the Cas9 enzyme to a chosen spot in an organism's DNA, where it cuts, letting scientists alter or insert genes at that site. The foundational CRISPR-Cas9 patents, however, are embroiled in an intellectual property dispute.

A divisive saga

GM food crops have a contested history in India. In 2010, then Environment Minister Jairam Ramesh imposed an indefinite moratorium on Bt brinjal, a genetically modified variant of the vegetable. In July 2024, the Supreme Court delivered a split verdict on GM mustard's environmental release, but unanimously asked the Centre to frame a national policy on GM crops. Golden Rice, engineered in 1999 by Ingo Potrykus and Peter Beyer to carry a vitamin A precursor in its grain, has also proved divisive.

Indian researchers reported in the peer-reviewed PLOS One journal in 2017 that backcrossing one Golden Rice transgene event into an Indian variety had yielded stunted, low-yielding plants, unfit for cultivation despite their high provitamin A content.

Asked whether Golden Rice could disturb India's agricultural systems, citing the invasive spread of eucalyptus, Dr. Roberts said he was not an expert in agriculture, underlining that there are people out there who truly are experts who can answer the questions much better than he can.

India permits Bt cotton for commercial cultivation, but no GM food crop.Kavitha Kuruganti, who leads the Coalition for a GM-Free India, has previously argued that the yield claims for GM mustard, which was cleared by a technical body but whose release subsequently stalled, are not supported by the developers' own data.

Jaishankar to travel to U.S. for G20 Foreign Ministers' meet

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

A week after United States Secretary of State Marco Rubio's visit to India, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar will travel to the U.S. city of Atlanta to attend the meeting of G20 Foreign Ministers hosted by Mr. Rubio. The three-day visit from October 29 to 31 will include meetings with his counterparts from other G20 countries amidst a series of global developments and the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) has not announced the visit thus far, but diplomatic sources confirmed that his engagements will include the Quad Foreign Ministers' meeting with Australian Foreign Minister Penny Wong and Japanese Foreign Minister Motegi Toshimitsu.


S. Jaishankar

The Quad Ministers earlier met in Delhi in May this year but could not schedule a summit of the leaders in India, whose turn it has been to host the summit since 2024. Instead, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, U.S. President Donald Trump, Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi and Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese will hold a Quad leaders' meeting in Manila, on the sidelines of the ASEAN-East Asian Summits, that they are all attending in mid-November.

The decision to hold the Quad leaders' summit in the Philippines, a first in a non-Quad country, indicates the difficulties the grouping has had in scheduling the summit in the past few years.

Four new faces join Omar Abdullah's Cabinet

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

The government led by Chief Minister Omar Abdullah in Jammu and Kashmir on Tuesday inducted four new faces into the Council of Ministers, including an old hand from Srinagar, Ali Muhammad Sagar, and a female face, Shameema Firdous, taking the total strength of the Cabinet to nine in the Union Territory.

Lieutenant-Governor Manoj Sinha administered the oath of office and secrecy to Mr. Sagar, Ms. Firdous, Mir Saifullah, and Altaf Kaloo at the Lok Bhavan in Srinagar.

Satish Sharma, an Independent legislator from Jammu province, was dropped from the Cabinet.


Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah and Lieutenant-Governor Manoj Sinha along with the newly inducted Cabinet ministers and officials in Srinagar on Tuesday. ANI

He was holding the portfolios of Food, Civil Supplies and Consumer Affairs; Information Technology; Youth Services and Sports; and Transport, Science and Technology.

The Congress, an ally of the ruling National Conference (NC), has decided to stay away "till Statehood is restored". Mr. Sagar, 68, a seven-time legislator who represents the Khanyar Assembly constituency in Srinagar, is a party veteran and former Minister. Mr. Sagar and his son Salman Sagar managed to win two seats from Srinagar district for the party in the 2024 elections.

Ms. Firdous, a party loyalist who represents Srinagar's Habba Kadal constituency, is the second woman Minister in the Cabinet after Sakin Itoo from south Kashmir's Kulgam. The NC had won seven out of eight seats from Srinagar district in the 2024 elections.

The induction of Mr. Kaloo, a legislator from Pahalgam, gives additional representation to south Kashmir, while Mr. Saifullah, a legislator from Trehgam constituency, is aimed at strengthening the party's stronghold in north Kashmir.

Under Section 53 of the Jammu and Kashmir Reorganisation Act, 2019, the Council of Ministers in the Union Territory cannot exceed 10% of the 90-member Assembly. For the past two years, Mr. Abdullah had only five Ministers in his Cabinet – two from the Kashmir division and three from the Jammu division.

Deputy Chief Minister Surinder Choudhary, who has been retained, remains the sole Hindu face in the Cabinet.

SC issues notice to Centre over *Vande Mataram* petitions

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday sought a response from the Union government on two separate petitions filed by a Phule-Ambedkarite and a former Kerala bureaucrat challenging government orders imposing the six-stanza *Vande Mataram* on the people.

A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant issued notice to the Centre on petitions filed by B.D. Borkar and former IAS officer Balakrishnan Sathyabhama Mavoji, both of whom have termed the six-stanza *Vande Mataram* a 'divisive religious war song' and a step towards theocracy.

The petitions argued that government orders had imposed a "sectarian prayer to particular goddesses of one particular religion as the National Song" which violated fundamental rights of religion and attracted the criminal law.

The petitions, represented by jurist and advocate Mohan Gopal, said a State compulsion expressed through two successive government orders on January 28 and July 9 would lead to the "unstated but undeniable consequence of irreversibly deepening communal division and conflict in India by outraging the religious and spiritual feelings of minority religions".

Mr. Borkar has argued that the six-stanza version introduced by Bankim Chandra Chatterjee in his novel 'Anandamath' would promote enmity and conflict between different communities by advancing the supremacy of a dominant community. The fabric of unity and harmony would be mutilated forever, he has said.

Delhi invites Pakistan Minister for SCO Civilisational Dialogue debut

Suhasini Haidar
Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

India will hold the first "Civilisational Dialogue Forum" of the 10-nation Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) grouping, that includes Pakistan, from November 20-22 in Delhi, sources confirmed to *The Hindu*.

The dialogue, which will be organised by the Ministry of Culture and the Ministry of External Affairs, was proposed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the SCO leaders' Summit in Tianjin last year and adopted by the SCO Council.

According to the sources, the government has invited Pakistan's Minister for National Heritage and Culture Aurangzeb Khan Khichi, for the event. Culture Ministers from the 10 member states, including China, Russia, Iran, Belarus and Central Asian states, 15 Dialogue partners and observer countries


Aurangzeb Khan Khichi

have been invited.

The event, which will be inaugurated by Mr. Modi, will be held at Delhi's iconic Purana Quila (Old Fort), a 16th Century fort built by Emperor Humayun. The fort is also the site of many excavations showcasing India's ancient past spanning nearly 3,000 years, from the Pre-Mauryan, Mauryan, Shunga, Kushana, Gupta, Post-Gupta period to medieval-era Rajput, Sultanate and Mughal periods, officials said, explaining its importance.

According to diplomatic sources, Pakistan has not so far confirmed who will lead its delegation to the dialogue forum. If Mr. Khichi attends, this will be the first time India will host a Minister from Pakistan since the 2023 SCO Foreign Ministers meeting, when the then Pakistan FM Bilawal Bhutto had travelled to Goa, and the first since the four-day conflict between India and Pakistan in May 2025.

While India has refused to take part in meetings of South Asia Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) in Islamabad due to differences with Pakistan since 2016, it has joined SCO meetings there in the past, including SCO-Regional Anti-Terror Structure (RATS). In September, India sent SCO National Coordinator Alok Dimri to Islamabad to attend the first coordination meeting for Pakistan's SCO Presidency and events leading up to the leader's Summit in Pakistan, scheduled for August 2027. In November 2024, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar had represented India at the SCO Heads of Government (HoG) Meeting, and all eyes will be on who will represent India at the SCO Heads of State Summit next year.

"India deals with SCO as an entity, as an important organisation," MEA Secretary (West) Sibi George said in response to a question from *The Hindu* at a briefing on August 27 about whether PM Modi would travel to Pakistan for the summit. "As far as our engagement with individual countries is concerned, a decision will be taken by the appropriate authority at the appropriate time and our appropriate level of participation will be decided accordingly," he added.

For the forum, each participating State has been invited to nominate a delegation comprising the Minister responsible for Culture and up to four government representatives.

Chief of Army Staff reviews readiness in Garhwal sector

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Chief of the Army Staff (COAS) General Dhiraj Seth on Tuesday visited Mana and Joshimath in the Garhwal Sector to review the Army's operational preparedness and assess initiatives aimed at developing border areas and empowering local communities.

During the visit, General Seth was briefed on operational readiness, combat preparedness and ongoing infrastructure development projects in the sector. Interacting with troops, he commended their professionalism, dedication and resilience in safeguarding the country's frontiers.

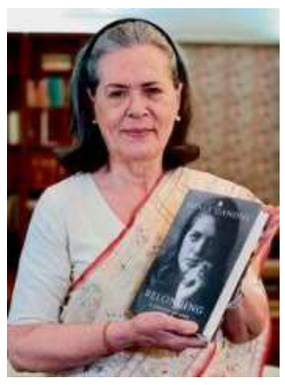
The Army Chief called for greater integration of technology, continuous capability enhancement and sustained operational vigilance.

As part of the Army's efforts to strengthen border


General Dhiraj Seth

communities and promote sustainable livelihoods, General Seth also visited Mana, recognised as India's First Village. He appreciated the efforts of Army personnel and local residents in promoting tourism, preserving the region's cultural heritage and creating opportunities for socio-economic development.

The visit underscored the Army's dual focus on maintaining operational readiness along the borders and contributing to the development of remote border villages.



Sonia says her memoir will create '*tamasha*'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The publication of her memoir is bound to create some "*tamasha*" (sensation), but it will allow her to set the record straight and tell her story, Congress Parliamentary Party Chairperson Sonia Gandhi said on Tuesday.

"There's bound to be some *tamasha* when this book comes out. After all, others have spent decades telling my 'story', now it's my turn," Ms. Gandhi said in a post on X on Tuesday, sharing a video offering a glimpse of her memoir, *Belonging: A Journey of Love*, scheduled for release on November 10.

In the 1.28-minute video, along with the post, Ms. Gandhi is seen going through the pages and reflecting on whether she should tell her entire story.

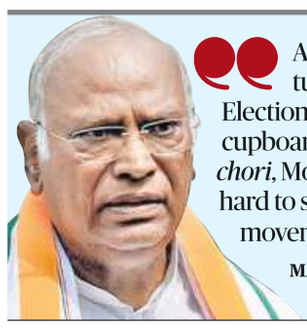
"I don't know if I should tell the whole story," she says, before recalling the time her late husband, former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi, was asked to become Prime Minister. "When my husband was asked to become the Prime Minister, which I was totally against....," she said, as the video moves on.

"Well, I felt that since a lot had been written about me and a lot of it was not quite correct. It was either invented or exaggerated. So, it gave me a feel of being able to now put down my story and describe facts and things as they really were," she added.

Cong. calls poll panel affidavit on SIR 'deceitful, duplicitous'

Congress chief lists alleged irregularities in SIR across 12 States, one Union Territory; asks why PM, Shah are protecting the CEC; Congress flags ECI's changing statements on the additions to Form 6

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



> As more skeletons tumble out of the Election Commission's cupboard, exposing vote *chori*, Modi-Shah are trying hard to suppress the people's movement!
>
> **MALLIKARJUN KHARGE**
> Congress president

Doubling down on its attack against the Election Commission of India's special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls on Tuesday, the Congress said the Commission's affidavit in the Supreme Court was "deceitful and duplicitous".

Party president Mallikarjun Kharge listed instances of alleged irregularities in the SIR exercise in 12 States and one Union Territory, accusing Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah of trying to suppress the movement against "vote *chori*".

Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh described the ECI's 248-page counter-affidavit as "deceptive, deceitful and duplicitous", adding that it was "extremely damaging" to the Commission itself. The ECI has sought the dismissal of petitions challenging its decisions on the SIR, maintaining that the exercise was authorised by law and that the relevant orders had been approved unanimously by all three members.

Form 6 changes

Mr. Ramesh alleged that the Commission had engaged in "patent deception and word games" over Form 6, which is used for voter registration. He said the ECI had earlier claimed that a new declaration attached to the form had been upheld by the Supreme Court, but was now arguing that the declaration was separate and that Form 6 itself had not been amended.

He maintained that the declaration was made mandatory for online submission and accused the ECI of violating the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960. He also alleged that the ECINET platform had been used to centralise control over electoral rolls and override electoral registration officers, who are the statutory authorities.

Mr. Ramesh said allegations of mass deletions and other irregularities continued to emerge from States conducting the SIR.

"Once a person starts lying, they get entangled in their own web of deceit. And when this pattern continues for a long time, eventually their lies begin to surface in one way or another," Mr. Ramesh said.

In a separate post on X, Mr. Kharge said the Opposition INDIA bloc would continue its democratic struggle to protect every citizen's vote and the Constitution.

"As more skeletons tumble out of the Election Commission's cupboard, exposing Vote Chori, Modi-Shah are trying hard to suppress the people's movement! Why are they protecting CEC Gyanesh Kumar?" Mr. Kharge said in a post on X.

SC issues notice to Centre on plea by news publishers against data privacy law

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Digital News Publishers Association (DNPA), a group of 21 publishers from across the media spectrum, including ones owned by the Ambani and Adani groups, said the Union government's new privacy law will "shut down news rooms and usher in an era of censorship".

The DNPA, which represents 22 media publishers, including The Hindu Group Publishing Private Ltd., urged a Bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant to issue notice to the Union government on their plea for a stay of the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 and the Digital Personal Data Protection Rules, 2025. The Supreme Court issued notice to the Centre and listed the case for detailed hearing on November 17. "We cannot pass *ex parte* orders of stay," CJI Kant said.

Senior advocate Madhavi Divan and advocate Anuj Tiwari, appearing for the DNPA, said the association was not asking for a stay but wanted the Centre to address the court on their plea for an interim stay of the privacy law.

Contravention with law

"If I (publishers) am left to the mercy of the data principal [the individual to whom the personal data relates to], who is also empowered to exercise control over the personal data, it will close down news rooms... They are changing the very concept of news," Ms. Divan submitted.

The CJI welcomed suggestions from the DNPA on how to balance the rights of innocent citizens against the misuse of Press freedom by the media while protecting the latter's right to disseminate information to the public.

"You (DNPA) are the best person to tell us... How do we ensure that a balance is struck?" the CJI addressed Ms. Divan.

The senior counsel said the privacy law was not meant for journalists at all. The very objectives of the law did not intend to fetter journalistic freedom exercised by traditional and recognised media houses, who were already regulated by bodies like the Press Council of India.

"If we report inaccurately, we will suffer... Now they are saying we have to ask them before publishing?" Ms. Divan challenged.

The DNPA has argued that the law was completely in contravention with the law laid down by the Supreme Court in its privacy judgment, which held the right inviolable and fundamental to human dignity and life.

"They impermissibly restrict the fundamental right to information and freedom of speech and expression," the petition said.

Govt. creating hurdles for protest, says Cong.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Tuesday accused the Narendra Modi government of obstructing the INDIA bloc's proposed "public impeachment" of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar on October 30, alleging that permission to hold the event at two venues had been denied following police intervention. The Delhi Police, however, said they had received no request for permission to hold the proposed mock impeachment event.

"The government-run Ashok Hotel had initially granted permission for the event but withdrew it following police intervention," Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal told reporters earlier in the day.

Twenty-one INDIA bloc parties had planned the mock impeachment as a curtain-raiser to the November 1 rally against alleged electoral irregularities and the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, Mr. Venugopal said.

After the Ashok Hotel event was obstructed, the Congress decided to shift it to Ramlila Maidan since the party had booked the venue from October 25 to November 3, he said.



K.C. Venugopal

"The day before yesterday, when our people came to set up infrastructure, the police didn't allow. This means it is not the Delhi Police's decision. It is the decision of Prime Minister [Narendra] Modi and [Home Minister] Amit Shah and they are protecting their pet Gyanesh Kumar," Mr. Venugopal alleged.

"Let it be very clear, come what may, we will not rest until Modi-Shah's puppet Gyanesh Kumar is removed. If they stop us here, we will go to Amit Shah's house, PM Modi's house, and stage a massive dharna there. But we will fight to the finish, until our mission is accomplished," the Congress leader said.

The Congress had sought permission only for a rally at Ramlila Maidan on November 1, which was granted, subject to several conditions, Deputy Commissioner of Police (Central) Rohit Rajbir Singh told *The Hindu*. No separate request for a mock impeachment had been received, he said.

According to the permission letter issued by the Central district police, seen by *The Hindu*, the rally is scheduled to be held from 10 a.m. to 5 p.m. on November 1. The police have provided a no-objection from the perspective of law and order, subject to the organisers obtaining prior permission from the land-owning authority.

The police have imposed conditions on CCTV surveillance, security arrangements, water and toilet facilities, traffic management, and crowd control. The organisers have been directed to ensure that the rally remains peaceful and concludes by 5 p.m.

CPI forms human chain demanding CEC's resignation

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Communist Party of India (CPI) on Tuesday organised a human chain from its party headquarters Ajoy Bhavan to ITO in New Delhi, demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, alleging that the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls had led to the disenfranchisement of citizens.

Addressing the gathering, CPI general secretary D. Raja said Mr. Kumar had "lost the confidence of the people" and that his continuation as Chief Election Commissioner posed a threat to the credibility of the electoral process. The party demanded the immediate rollback of the SIR exercise. He also criticised the denotification of Jantar Mantar as a protest site and called for its reopening.

The CPI, in a statement, said democracy could not function effectively if citizens were denied both their voting rights and the right to protest.



Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, fourth from left, with dignitaries and guests during the 12th BRICS Parliamentary Forum in New Delhi on Tuesday. ANI

AI can strengthen parliamentary processes, citizen participation, says Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Artificial Intelligence (AI) can optimise parliamentary workflows and deepen citizen participation if its development and use are guided by "human values, ethics, transparency, and accountability", Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla said on Tuesday, while speaking at the concluding session of the 12th BRICS Parliamentary Forum.

Mr. Birla said Parliaments are not merely law-making bodies but "vital centres of dialogue, consensus, accountability and public trust". He stressed the need for legislatures across the world to adapt to changing times by becoming more transparent and citizen-centric.

He said AI and digital technologies could significantly improve parliamentary functioning and citizen engagement, provided they are deployed responsibly.

He noted that the Indian Parliament already uses AI to translate parliamentary speeches broadcast on Sansad TV's YouTube channel in multiple Indian languages. AI is also being used to translate parliamentary papers, helping legislators from diverse linguistic groups. The joint declaration adopted by the forum also highlighted the importance of emerging technologies like AI.

Engaging youth

Mr. Birla also reiterated the importance of engaging young people in democratic processes, a theme he had emphasised in his opening address to the forum. Referring to India's philosophy that "permanent solutions are forged in dialogue, not war", he called for a global framework based on respect for national sovereignty, peaceful resolution of disputes and equitable development opportunities.

"Global peace truly means security, respect, justice, and the assurance of a better future for everyone, especially the younger generation," he said.

Rajya Sabha Chairman C.P. Radhakrishnan, who hosted a luncheon for the Presiding Officers and Leaders of Delegations of BRICS Members, said in his address that democracy is not a new concept to Bharat, noting that history reveals democracy existed in places like Vaishali in the North, while Chola rulers adopted the *"kudavolai"* system in the South.

BRICS Forum voices deep concern over tensions in West Asia

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI

Expressing "deep concern" about the escalating tension and hostilities in West Asia, parliamentary leaders from the BRICS nations slammed "unilateral coercive measures" and "unilateral economic sanctions" imposed in the region as contrary to international law.

A joint declaration issued after deliberations led by Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, at the end of the two-day 12th BRICS Parliamentary Forum on Tuesday, also reiterated the need for a 'two-state' solution to the Israel-Palestinian conflict. "We express deep concern over the continued escalation of tensions in Middle East/West Asia and, recalling our respective national positions, call for exercising maximum restraint, as well as avoiding actions that could further aggravate the situation," it said.

The joint declaration also addressed the ongoing conflict in the Gaza Strip. "We reaffirm our unwavering support for the peaceful resolution of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict based on the two-state solution, with the two States living side by side, in peace and security, in accordance with international law and relevant United Nations resolutions, asserting the right of the Palestinian people to self-determination, freedom and an independent, sovereign state," it said.

The Forum obliquely addressed the U.S.-Israel attack on Iran and the BRICS stance against attacks on member countries. "We call for the elimination of such unlawful measures which undermine international law and the principles and purposes of the UN Charter," the joint declaration said.

Terrorism 'unjustified'

It condemned acts of terrorism as "criminal and unjustified" and condemned the April 22, 2025 terror strike in Kashmir's Pahalgam in the "strongest terms". It added: "We call for an expeditious finalisation and adoption of the Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism in the UN framework. We call for concerted actions against all UN designated terrorists and terrorist entities."

The joint declaration added that inter-parliamentary exchanges among BRICS member countries provides a channel of communication and build trust among the member states. "Support the peaceful resolution of international disputes," it said.

U.P. Chief Electoral Officer apologises for language and tone of social media posts

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) of Uttar Pradesh on Tuesday apologised over the "tone" and tenor of social media posts made by the poll body, following a row over the acerbic nature of the remarks, which pertained to erroneous voter slip entries.

The controversy began when Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) MP Sanjay Singh questioned Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar over an erroneous entry, where 'Ramhit Yadav' became 'Ram ne Yadav ko Maara' (Ram hit Yadav) in the voter list of the recent U.P. Legislative Council election.

U.P. CEO Navdeep Rinwa's office attributed the error to a translation software glitch. The software used to prepare voter lists was designed to transliterate names entered in English into Hindi, which led to 'Ramhit Yadav' being incorrectly entered as 'Ram Hit Yadav'. The software interpreted the words as a sentence and translated it to "Ram ne Yadav ko Maara" in Hindi.

Mr. Singh had questioned the CEC on whether the latter was running the agenda for a particular political party. "Gyanesh Kumar, why did Ram hit only a Yadav? Why did Ram not hit any Singh, Pathak, Asthana, Sharma, Rai or Bisht? Is your computer casteist?" the AAP leader said in a post on *X*.



Chief Electoral Officer of Uttar Pradesh Navdeep Rinwa.

In an acerbic response, Mr. Rinwa's office cited another instance of a similar error, where the name of the father of a voter, Ravi Sharma, was incorrectly recorded as "Ram ne Sharma ko Maara".

"A bizarre name, 'Ram ne Sharma ko maara', has appeared in the voter list for the recent Legislative Council elections. Computers/software are not casteist. We admit that a mistake was made, but fortunately for us, even when the mistake occurred, caste discrimination was not involved," Mr. Rinwa's office said.

This was followed by another remark by Mr. Rinwa's office, which said that had the entry read "Ram hit a minority", the authorities would have been accused of communalism too. "Thank God, Ram did not kill a member of a minority community. Otherwise, we would have been accused of being communal as well as casteist," the remark read.

The AAP MP was quick to hit back. On Monday, he held a press conference in Lucknow, alleging that the U.P. Chief Electoral Officer was responding like an "agent of the BJP". He also flagged other absurd entries in the electoral rolls, and sought strict action against Mr. Rinwa for the objectionable remarks.

On Tuesday, however, Mr. Rinwa's office issued an apology. "The tone, language and sharpness of the comments in the quoted post from this handle are not in keeping with the kind of communication expected from an official handle," the apology posted to X said.

"The genuine outrage sparked by the comments in the post has been duly noted. We sincerely apologise to those who have been shocked and angered by them. From now on, our communication will be civil and formal," Mr. Rinwa's office said.

INBRIEF



HC stays 'leave India notice' against Imran Khan till Nov. 2

The Bombay High Court on Tuesday granted interim relief to actor Imran Khan by staying the "leave India notice" issued against him by the Foreigners Regional Registration Office (FRRO), until the next hearing on November 2. The court recorded an oral assurance from Additional Solicitor-General Anil C. Singh, appearing for the Centre, that the notice would be kept in abeyance. Imran Khan, a U.S. citizen and Overseas Citizen of India (OCI) cardholder, had approached the High Court challenging the notice issued following his alleged participation in a protest against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar at August Kranti Maidan.

Centre mulls law to curb child pornography, explicit content

The Union government informed the Supreme Court on Tuesday that it is contemplating a policy framework to tackle the menace of child pornography and the circulation of non-consensual explicit content involving adults. Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta submitted before a Bench that the proposed law might extend to imposing liability on intermediaries not just to take down offensive content, but also to apprise authorities about the uploading of the content. During the hearing, senior advocate Aparna Bhat, appearing for NGO Prajwala, apprised the top court about the absence of safeguards for adults and the circulation of non-consensual content online, including sexual assault videos.

Cyclone Arnab to make early landfall; heavy rain batters A.P.

A.P. cancels several flights, trains, and brings 30,000 fishing boats ashore; Odisha shuts ghat roads, imposes transport restrictions, and begins evacuation of 48,000 people from southern districts

Nellore Sravani
Satyasundar Barik
VIJAYAWADA/ BHUBANESWAR



Tree branches cover a car in Visakhapatnam on Tuesday as Cyclone Arnab approached the coast. K.R. DEEPAK

Heavy rain pounded the northern districts of Andhra Pradesh on Tuesday, leaving one dead and a trail of destruction, while southern Odisha remained on edge as the 'very severe cyclonic storm' Arnab moved closer to the coast.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), the storm is likely to make landfall early – around 2 a.m. to 4 a.m. on Wednesday - near the Yanam-Kakinada region in Andhra Pradesh. Initially, the IMD had said that the landfall would take place around forenoon on Wednesday.

Jathara premises in Visakhapatnam rural mandal saw Tuesday's highest rainfall of 141.75 mm. Visakhapatnam district, where many places recorded rainfall above 100 mm and strong winds, bore the brunt of the cyclone. At least 200 trees got uprooted within the city limits.

Man dies

A 65-year-old man died at Mangalapalem after he came into contact with live electrical wires that had snapped and fallen into water.

Due to the severity of the storm on Tuesday, airlines cancelled at least 21 flights in Vijayawada and Visakhapatnam. At the Vijayawada airport, five flights bound for Hyderabad, Chennai, Bengaluru, Visakhapatnam and Kadapa were cancelled on Tuesday. The authorities have cancelled all flights on Wednesday as well.

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu said 290 cyclone shelters had been set up and 84,396 people evacuated to safer locations.

More than 30,000 fishing boats had been brought back from the sea, while 93 Andhra Pradesh boats and their crew were reported safe at Gopalpur in Odisha.

Odisha on alert

The Odisha government has begun evacuation of over 48,000 people from vulnerable southern districts, sources in the government said. Owing to the prospect of landslips, the government has shut several ghat roads.

The East Coast Railway said 22 express and passenger train services connecting Visakhapatnam, Secunderabad, Kirandul, Jagdalpur, Rourkela, Sambalpur, Rayagada, Howrah, Bhubaneswar and Koraput would remain cancelled or regulated on different dates between October 27 and November 5. Similarly, private bus operators have also placed restrictions on movement of their buses to southern Odisha.

Strong winds

Manorama Mohanty, Director of IMD, Bhubaneswar, said southern districts such as Malkangiri, Nabarangpur, Gajapati, Koraptut, and Rayagada could experience wind speed between 50 and 60 km per hour gusting to 70 kmph.

Thunderstorms accompanied with lightning and gusty surface wind is likely to occur at one or two places over the districts of Kalahandi, Nabarangpur, Rayagada, Koraput, Malkangiri, Gajapati, Ganjam on Wednesday, said the IMD.

"We plan to shift 48,000 people from vulnerable places to safer place in the first phase in eight districts. In Nabarangpur and Gajapati district, 11,000 each will be evacuated. In Malkangiri, 9850 people have been identified for shifting. About 6,500 in Ganjam and 5,000 in Koraput will take shelter in identified locations," said Special Relief Commissioner Rajesh Pravakar Patil.

Cheetah cub dies of gunshot injuries in M.P.; probe launched

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL



A special task force has been formed to probe the killing. REPRESENTATIVE PHOTO

A male cheetah cub that was found with gunshot injuries outside the boundaries of the Kuno National Park in Madhya Pradesh died on Tuesday during treatment in Jabalpur. This is the first such attack on a cheetah since the beginning of the reintroduction programme for the species in September 2022.

A four-member special task force has been formed to investigate the killing of the cub, KNG22, after a human angle was confirmed with the recovery of five firearm pellets from the body, Chief Wildlife Warden Samita Rajora told *The Hindu*.

The special task force, which consists of police personnel and forest officers from the region, has been deployed in the Sheopur Forest Division, where the cub was found on Sunday, along with the State Tiger Strike Force teams that were dispatched on Monday night, Ms. Rajora, a Principal Chief Conservator of Forests, said.

"We had brought the cub to Jabalpur on Monday where veterinarians led by expert surgeon Dr. Shobha Jawre performed an emergency surgery on him," she said, adding that the cub was found in an unconscious state, without any movement.

Population down to 58

Born to a female cheetah named Nirva, the 19-month-old male cub was under observation but died of injuries on Tuesday morning.

"We are probing all possibilities. Whether it is a case of poaching or someone killed the cub thinking it was a leopard, the persons responsible will be caught soon," the forest official said.

With the latest death, the country's total cheetah population is down to 58, of which 52 are at Kuno, four at the Gandhi Sagar Wildlife Sanctuary, and two at Veerangana Durgavati Tiger Reserve.

Police parade accused held for forcing 3 to walk naked

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

The Kolkata Police on Tuesday paraded three men shirtless through a locality with ropes tied around their waists. The trio had been arrested on Monday for forcing a teenage boy, his father, and a friend to walk naked through the same area after the boy met a girl from their family.

Raising concerns, Association for Protection of Democratic Rights secretary Ranajit Sur said, "The family that committed the crime must be tried under the law, but what the police did today is a bigger crime, because the police represent the state, not themselves as individuals. This is like saying an eye for an eye. This is the way to normalise revenge."

Retired PSU staff ask President to expedite pension hike rollout

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The National Confederation of Pensioners' Associations (NCPA), an organisation representing retired employees of Public Sector Undertakings (PSUs) and exempted Provident Fund Establishments, has written to President Droupadi Murmu urging her intervention to address the delay in providing higher pension based on higher wages.

The pensioners said in the letter that higher pension is no more a disputed issue as the Supreme Court has passed an order on the matter and the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) is creating unnecessary delays and bureaucratic hurdles to deny pension. The NCPA said that the President must exercise her "august moral authority" and direct the Union Ministry and the EPFO to immediately withdraw an EPFO circular dated January 18, 2025. They alleged that the circular was designed to nullify laws passed by Parliament through executive internal orders.

They have also demanded that an immediate litigation audit must be conducted to withdraw all "frivolous appeals" against settled High Court judgments. "Direct the acceptance of Joint Options for pension on higher wages without punitive interest penalties accrued solely due to EPFO's administrative delays, and the establishment of a time-bound mechanism to grant immediate relief to ageing pensioners," the organisation said in the letter.

Economic policy cannot outweigh citizens' lives: SC on medicine prices

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI



SC questioned the Centre over its approach to regulating medicine prices. FILE PHOTO

The Supreme Court on Tuesday said "economic policy" could not take precedence over the lives of citizens as it questioned the Centre over its approach to regulating the prices of essential medicines.

A Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta questioned Additional Solicitor-General Aishwarya Bhati, appearing for the Centre, over the failure of the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) to cap trade margins on essential medicines despite concerns over excessive markups. It also sought to know why such a ceiling had been imposed on certain anti-cancer drugs only after the court's intervention. Earlier this month, the NPPA, the government's drug-price regulator, capped trade margins on 137 non-scheduled anti-cancer medicines at 30% of their maximum retail price (MRP). The revised prices are set to take effect from November 9.

"For so many years, why were you silent? Suddenly, you decided to cap trade margins of cancer drugs?... Don't force us to ask harsh questions," the Bench remarked.

The oral observations came during the hearing of petitions filed by advocate Kishan Chand Jain and paediatric surgeon Sanjay Kulshrestha seeking stricter enforcement of price controls under the Drugs (Prices Control) Order, 2013, (DPCO) to curb disproportionate margins across the pharmaceutical supply chain.

Ms. Bhati, however, told the Bench that "complete government control" over essential medicines could adversely affect the market. "We want investments to also come here... We can make these interventions from time to time, but complete control is not the answer," Ms. Bhati submitted.

The Bench also questioned why the 16% retailer margin prescribed under the DPCO should not apply to all essential medicines and sought the basis for classifying drugs as scheduled or non-scheduled. While scheduled formulations are subject to government-fixed price ceilings, non-scheduled medicines remain outside this framework.

"How do you decide which medicine is essential and which is not? Why should all medicines not be essential? That is where the game is... the NPPA seems to be totally defunct," Justice Mehta remarked.

Senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi, appearing for an association of hospitals, defended the steep markups on essential medicines, including anti-cancer drugs, contending that capping such margins would make hospital operations financially unviable. The Bench, however, dismissed the contention, remarking that patients could not be subjected to "dacoity". It reserved its order in the matter and gave the parties two weeks to file their submissions.

SSB D-G Sanjay Singhal given additional charge of ITBP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Union Home Ministry has assigned the additional charge of Director-General of the Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) to Sanjay Singhal, who heads the Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB), with effect from October 31, when incumbent Shatrujeet Singh Kapoor retires.

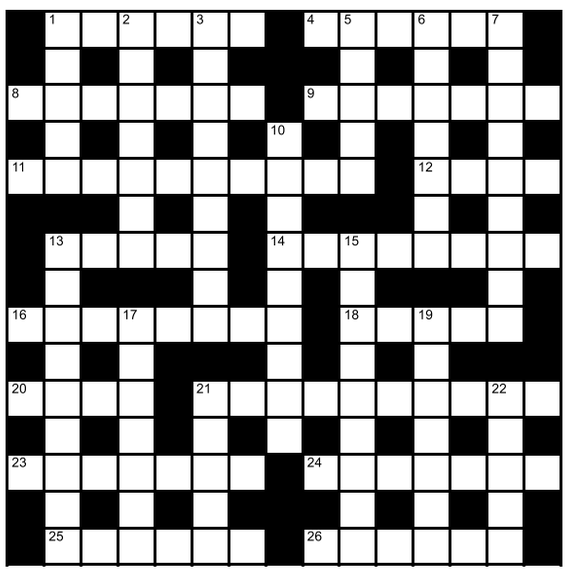
The ITBP guards the 3,488-km border with China, while the SSB guards borders with Nepal and Bhutan. On October 22, Mr. Kapoor said at an ITBP event in Rajasthan that "face-offs with Chinese troops continue at several locations in Arunachal Pradesh", leading to a political uproar and demands by the Opposition parties for clarity on the extent of Chinese incursion.

TH CROSSWORD + 14934

(set by Afterdark)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

1 Taxes a member at East Germany (6)
4 Dispense ORT after a serious shortage at the front (6)
8 Matador in Guatemala's somewhat affectionate (7)
9 Desperately needs intervention of medical examiner in the estate (7)
11 Side rattled with maiden, bowler finishes early by gut (10)
12 Expression of displeasure as purse is picked at the front (4)
13 An apparatus for breathing given to learner in South Africa (5)
14 A diversion in team performance (8)
16 A runner has society's peripheral, perhaps (8)
18 Pandemonium at church, one obliges to vacate (5)
20 Teak, Rowan, Elm, Elders roots make a big plant (4)
21 Consensus is strong, without leader its rarity (10)
23 Joined in board, rainy in the flanks but has no trace of moisture (4-3)
24 In part, husband at India interferes to constrain (7)
25 Fires drunk outside general hospital on Sunday (6)
26 Tucker Nelson's heart is at centre (6)

Down

1 Primate is seen behind ridge, hiding (5)
2 Upstart's standard very elementary, to begin with no clues essentially (7)
3 Son and first brother persist to clean a hard surface, say (9)
5 That lady will attack (5)
6 Coroner ousts a section that is demanding (7)
7 Dogged cousin ate rolls (9)
10 Sponge cake made by small women is featuring on special list (5,4)
13 Magnificent bird sighted at the biggest NFL game (5,4)
15 Reportedly clergy recruited a rogue at church leading to corruption (9)
17 A cold person's in charge at electricity board above work unit (7)
19 Fusion in raga overcoming resistance leads to charge (7)
21 Pothole on street at the parade (5)
22 Getting money at Qatar on time is testing (5)

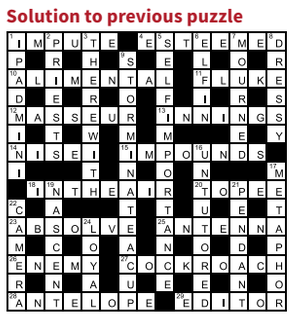
SUDOKU

4						8	1	
		2			6	9		
	1			5	4			3
		8			7			
			9	8	5			
			6			2		
2			4	9			6	
		7	5			1		
	8	1						9

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★☆

No.SS7044 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

8	9	3	6	4	1	2	5	7
4	7	6	2	5	8	9	3	1
5	2	1	9	3	7	4	6	8
1	3	5	7	2	9	6	8	4
9	4	7	3	8	6	1	2	5
6	8	2	4	1	5	3	7	9
2	1	8	5	9	3	7	4	6
7	5	4	1	6	2	8	9	3
3	6	9	8	7	4	5	1	2

FAITH

God accepts true love

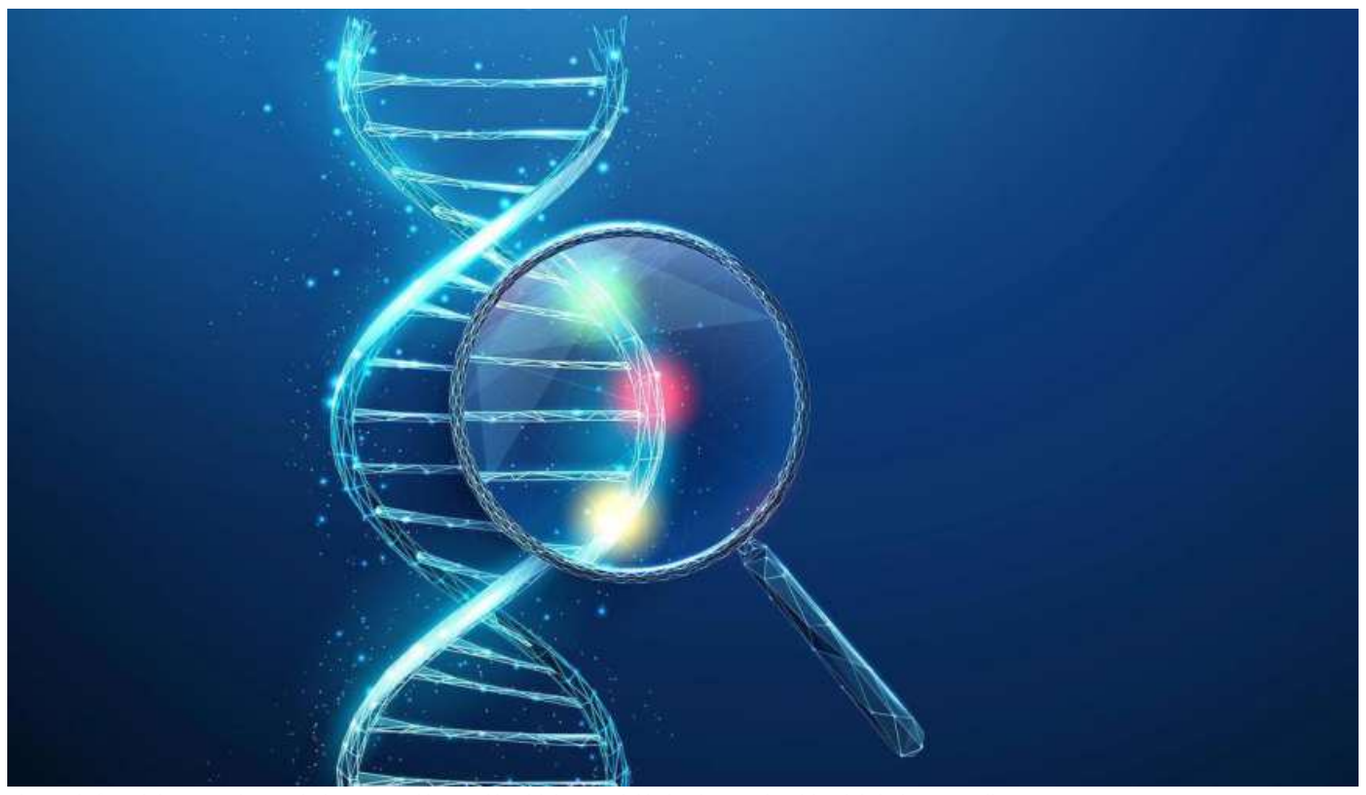
True love knows no bounds. There have lived many great saints. However, none comes anywhere close to Kannappan, one of the earliest, if not the first of 63 Saivite saints. His love for the Lord was such that he made offerings that were unconventional to say the least. None has done what he did for the love of God. His devotion is proof that God accepts what is offered with true love and raises the devotee to an exalted state, said P. Swaminathan.

Born in Kalaththi into a hunter family, he is celebrated by all, including Sambandar, Pattinatthar, Sundarar and Tirunavukkarasar. Once, after a rich hunt, Thinnappan climbed a hill and came across a naturally formed Sivalingam. A wave of devotion swept over him and he rushed to make offerings to the Lord. He skewered a few pieces of choice meat, plucked a few wildflowers and gathering stream water in his mouth, he rushed back to the Lingam. Removing the garland with his foot, he replaced them with his flowers, and spitting the water on the Lingam to cleanse it, he offered the meat with devotion and stood guard through the night. A priest, who had been making offerings to the Lingam, was stunned to see the fresh offerings, which is when Siva decided to sport. Advising the priest to hide behind Him, the Lord watched as Thinnappan appeared, and began to bleed from one eye. Horrified, Thinnappan removed his eye and placed it on the Lingam. Immediately, the other eye began to bleed. When the devotee was about to offer his other eye, and place it with his foot on the lingam, Siva appeared, saying, "Stop, Kannappa." From then on Thinnappan became Kannappan, the greatest devotee.

Your DNA says less about your personality than a short online quiz

The findings of new research reinforce a long-standing idea in genetics that there is no single 'personality gene'; the dataset the researchers used also directly challenged older theories that attempted to link traits to particular brain chemicals

Anirban Mukhopadhyay
NEW DELHI



The study found that genetic correlations extend beyond health into social behaviour and residential choices as well. GETTY IMAGES

Decades of psychology have categorised human personality into five broad buckets: openness to experience (curiosity and imagination), conscientiousness (organisation and responsibility), extraversion (sociability), agreeableness (compassion), and neuroticism (a tendency towards anxiety and volatility).

In new findings published in *Nature*, scientists have completed one of the largest-ever genetic analyses of these 'big five' traits, offering a more detailed picture of the genetic architecture of personality.

"The finding that genetic signals were broadly consistent across different contexts... supports the view that personality traits such as extraversion and neuroticism have a biological basis," Veena Kumari, professor of Experimental Psychology at Brunel University London, said. "However, like most psychological constructs, personality is a complex phenotype." She noted that human behaviour remains deeply tethered to its environment and "may not be similarly expressed, or even measured with the same precision" across different walks of life.

Inside the genome

The global team of researchers analysed data from up to 1.14 million participants across 46 study cohorts. Participants first completed validated personality questionnaires, which allowed the researchers to assign each person a score for the five traits.

The researchers then analysed the participants' DNA using a genome-wide association study (GWAS). That is, they looked across the genome for tiny genetic differences that tended to occur more often in people with higher or lower scores on each personality trait.

"The study identified some 1,250 DNA [variations] that are associated with personality traits," Mani Ramaswami, professor of neurogenetics at Trinity College Dublin, said. "It is important to note that these are tiny changes in the DNA and not the genes as a whole. Each one on its own has a minuscule effect" on human behaviour.

The goal of this exercise was not to find a single piece of DNA that determines whether someone is outgoing or anxious but to spot patterns spread across the genome in the form of genetic variants that, taken together, could be associated with small differences in personality across a large number of people.

Genes and life

The findings reinforced a long-standing idea in genetics that there is no single 'personality gene'. The dataset also directly challenged older theories that attempted to link traits to particular brain chemicals. The team found several gene variants scattered across the DNA, and tallied them up into a single number called a polygenic index – a score that combines the effects of the variants, each associated with specific traits.

The researchers then used these scores to test whether the genetic patterns associated with personality turned up in other parts of the people's lives. Specifically, by comparing these indices with large publicly available datasets on health, behaviour, and social outcomes, they found a range of genetic connections. For example, genetic patterns associated with higher conscientiousness were linked to a lower body mass index, fewer hospital visits, and lower substance use. Genetic patterns associated with neuroticism, on the other hand, showed strong associations with anxiety, depression, and other psychiatric disorders.

Seeing DNA linked to such serious health outcomes might make the index sound like a genetic crystal ball. Michel Nivard, professor of genetic epidemiology at the University of Bristol, is quick to burst that bubble.

"Look, if you want to know more about your personality, you can take a 3-5 minute online test. It will be highly predictive," Dr. Nivard said. For an individual, he said, the genetic effect "is weak, and adds no information over a 3-5 minute test at all."

Instead, the breakthrough's true value is at the macroscopic level. The genetic data is "strong enough to do new kinds of psych-, bio-, and social science of personality in larger groups," Dr. Nivard said, "where we work with averages across many individuals."

Beyond correlations

Hemant Tiwari, professor of Biostatistics at the University of Alabama at Birmingham, warned against jumping to conclusions like having a neurotic personality could cause someone to become depressed.

He noted that human biology is messy, and "shared genetic influences can affect personality, psychopathology, cognition, self-regulation, and health simultaneously."

In other words, the same genes that shape our temperament may also trigger certain health issues, rather than one causing the other. Because the data cannot reliably separate the two, Dr. Tiwari said, "whether personality itself causally drives downstream outcomes remains unresolved."

The genetic correlations extend beyond health into social behaviour and residential choices as well. The study found that by middle age, people with genetic profiles associated with higher openness to experience were more likely to have moved into cosmopolitan professional areas. Meanwhile, those with genetic profiles associated with higher conscientiousness were more likely to have moved away from cosmopolitan areas and toward affluent suburban communities.

The researchers also tried untangling nature from nurture by looking at siblings in their data. Siblings share the same upbringing but inherit slightly different combinations of DNA. By comparing them, the researchers could strip away the effects of the childhood environment and isolate the direct impact of genetics.

While parents still shape their children in complex ways, the data show the environmental transfer of personality is neither strong nor straightforward. As Dr. Nivard noted, the findings largely exclude "the possibility that extraverted parents environmentally cause their kids to be more extraverted".

Sequencing within families

Translating these insights into global clinical practice, however, faces a severe bottleneck. The genomic databases powering this research are dominated by individuals with European-like genomes. When a polygenic index built on such data is applied to populations with different genetic ancestries, prediction generally becomes less reliable.

Moving forward, Dr. Ramaswami said DNA sequencing within families exhibiting extreme behavioural variants will be far more useful than broad population studies.

An approach along these lines, he noted, is already being pioneered in India for psychiatric conditions through a joint effort by the National Centre for Biological Sciences (NCBS) and the National Institute of Mental Health and Neurosciences (NIMHANS), both in Bengaluru.

(Anirban Mukhopadhyay is a geneticist by training and science communicator from New Delhi.
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THE GIST

A recent study has offered a more detailed picture of the genetic architecture of personality

The global team of researchers analysed data from up to 1.14 million participants across 46 study cohorts

Participants first completed validated personality questionnaires, which allowed the researchers to assign scores to each person

The researchers then looked across the genome for tiny genetic differences that tended to occur more often in people with higher or lower scores on each personality trait

The study identified some 1,250 DNA variations associated with personality traits, with each one on its own having a minuscule effect on human behaviour

BIG SHOT



Vincenzo Valentini, director of the Center of Excellence for Oncology and Diagnostic Imaging at the Tiberina Island Hospital in Rome, poses in the radiotherapy department, Rome, October 6, 2026. Through large windows, the clinical space looks directly onto the archaeological remains of an ancient Roman temple, offering patients a contemplative view before their oncology treatments. AFP

WHAT IS IT?

Glaciers ending in lakes

Press Trust of India

Glaciers ending in lakes, oceans or ice shelves account for over 3% of the world's glaciers but lost 134 billion tonnes of ice annually between 2000 and 2019, contributing to more than half of all glacier ice loss, a new study has found.

Environmental scientists led by the UK's University of Birmingham and the University of Leeds found that glaciers ending in lakes are generally much larger than those ending on land, together covering more than half of the world's glacier area.

The findings, published in *Nature Communications*, also showed that lake- and ocean-ending glaciers flow on average 10% and 44% faster than those ending on land, respectively, and lake-ending glaciers lose around 57% more ice than land-ending glaciers, relative to their size.

"Glaciers ending in lakes really stand out -- they're losing ice particularly quickly. We don't yet know exactly why. It could be the lakes themselves, the size and shape of the glaciers, or a bit of both. Untangling that is the next big question, especially as glacier lakes are becoming more common in a warming climate," said author Joseph Mallalieu.

The researchers explained that lakes can affect glaciers in ways that may contribute to a higher ice loss. Lake-ending glaciers can lose large chunks of ice from the glacier front as icebergs, a process known as calving, and lake water can melt the ice below the waterline, both helping to speed up ice loss, they said.



Ice melts at the Skuta glacier near Kamnik, Slovenia. AP

Models used for projecting glacier change do not yet fully account for glaciers ending in lakes, the researchers added.

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Small fish

While carriers of narcotics are caught in the net, big sharks operate freely

Operation Trident, a multi-agency crackdown on an international syndicate operating across the India-Myanmar-Bangladesh corridor, marks a significant step-up in the government's campaign against drug trafficking. The Union Home Minister, Amit Shah, has set December 31, 2029, as the deadline to eradicate drug networks across the country. The October 23 raids, which led to 18 people being arrested, were based on NCB investigations following the arrest of an alleged Myanmar-based kingpin in Delhi this May. However, the dismantling of the entire network would require identification of all suppliers in Myanmar and their successful prosecution. The government's strategy, involving States and Union Territories, over 40 Ministries, central agencies and the pharmaceutical sector, is outlined in the Vision Document on Drug Control (2026-2029), launched by Mr. Shah at the Narco-Coordination Centre meeting on June 26, 2026. It envisages dismantling 100 major cartels and improving prosecution outcomes. The broad strategy reflects the complexity of the problem and signals a more focused approach. Data for 2025 also show an increase of over 50% in arrests and a nearly 53% rise in cases registered under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act compared with 2024.

However, the government's action-plan will depend on consistent implementation and efficient coordination among agencies, and striking at the real brains behind it all. In several cases, foreign-based key operatives still remain at large and big sharks often do not fall in the net. The 2021 Mundra port case in Gujarat, involving the seizure of about 3,000 kg of heroin, is a case in point wherein the principal Afghanistan-based suppliers have yet to be brought to book. Also, the quantity of drugs seized does not, by itself, indicate whether drug availability or consumption has declined. Punjab remains a prominent example of the continuing public health challenges associated with drug abuse. The alleged drug-related killings of anti-drug activists in Mansa and Gurdaspur, along with the alleged death by suicide of a father in Sangrur who had raised concerns about the easy availability of synthetic drugs in his locality, underscore the human cost of the problem. These incidents also raise questions about the protection of those who speak out against drug trafficking and networks. These concerns lend urgency to the objective of dismantling entire networks and apprehending the "big sharks", rather than concentrating disproportionately on individual carriers. The key is to identify the ultimate beneficiaries by meticulously following the money trail and ensuring their conviction.

Fouled waters

River pollution from industrial effluents indicates state failure

The Supreme Court has pulled up, once again, the Rajasthan government over industrial effluents flowing into the Jojari river and the deadly risk it poses for the people depending on it. The problem is decades old – public interest litigation in the Rajasthan High Court alerted State machinery to the problem in 2011 – indicating an oversight by the State bordering on the systematic. The Jojari, the Luni, and the Bandi are seasonal rivers in the State's arid western region, flowing through Jodhpur, Balotra, and Pali districts. This region has also evolved as a textile-dyeing and steelworking hub, and untreated or insufficiently treated effluents from these factories have run directly into the rivers and soil, endangering the health of around 20 lakh local residents. The region also suffers rampant illegal sand mining in riverbeds. The sewage treatment plants have been able to accommodate only around half of the sewage generated in the three urban centres, according to the State's submissions to the Court in 2025, even as the Court recorded substantial underutilisation at common effluent treatment plants. The combination is suggestive of industrial sources bypassing treatment facilities, poor connections between the sources and the facilities, and/or insufficient capacity at particular sites or in specific periods.

The Court initiated a *suo motu* writ petition in 2025 and constituted a High-level Ecosystem Oversight Committee chaired by Justice Sangeet Lodha to audit the plants and draft a plan to restore the rivers. Based on the committee's scathing status reports, Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta banned construction within 100 metres of the rivers' edges and hazardous industries within 500 m of the present path, or of the flood lines where available. The Court has also upbraided local authorities for failing to enforce pollution norms by citing the Court's own stay of a 2022 National Green Tribunal order imposing a compensation on the Rajasthan State Industrial Development and Investment Corporation and the local administration in Jodhpur and Barmer. The State regulatory apparatus has been dysfunctional: officials were aware of illegal mining operations in some areas, yet they regularised leases in those areas. Given the dereliction in play, the Court is correct to treat the possibility of collusion between State officials and industrial mafias seriously. Justice Mehta's observation that the State could be held liable under the 'polluter pays' principle is also a significant indictment of state failure, through negligence. Now, importantly, the State still has to restore the Jojari and attend to its wellbeing, which is relevant to a recent tendency by the Court to substitute itself for regulators rather than disciplining them into discharging their functions. This needs to change.

New Delhi's 'balancing act' risks eroding Russia's trust



Muqtedar Khan

Professor of International Relations at the University of Delaware and a Senior Non-Resident Fellow of the Middle East Policy Council. He hosts a YouTube show on World Affairs called 'Khanversations'

The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, on August 31-September 1, 2026, and the BRICS summit in New Delhi on September 12-13, 2026, were remarkable. Iran received considerably more attention and support from members of both the groups, far more than anticipated. More consequential, however, was the shift in India's stance on the United States-Israel war against Iran and Russia's war in Ukraine.

Traditionally, the SCO and BRICS summits have offered the three major powers – Russia, India and China – an opportunity to demonstrate their mutual solidarity. For Russia, it is a platform from which it can signal to the West that it is not isolated and still has powerful allies. The expansion of the SCO and BRICS under China's leadership showcases its growing power to the West. For India, the SCO and BRICS have been useful for demonstrating its strategic autonomy. India has sought to remain welcome in both western and non-western forums, from the G-7 to the SCO and BRICS.

A surprise pivot

At Bishkek, however, India sprang two surprises. First, it endorsed the Bishkek Declaration, which condemned the attacks on Iran as violations of international law, reaffirmed Iran's sovereignty and territorial integrity, and mourned the killing of its Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, in U.S.-Israeli air strikes on February 28, 2026.

Although the declaration did not name the U.S. or Israel, its meaning was unmistakable. India reaffirmed its opposition to military strikes on Iran by endorsing the Bishkek Declaration, which condemned the attacks and reiterated support for Iran's sovereignty and territorial integrity. Second, Prime Minister Narendra Modi made an unusually blunt appeal to Russian President Vladimir Putin to bring Russia's seemingly endless war in Ukraine to an end.

India has generally sought to avoid directly condemning the U.S. or Israel for their military actions against Iran, even though Iran, like India, is a member of both the SCO and BRICS. India had previously avoided explicitly accusing Israel of genocide in Gaza, although it had supported UN resolutions calling for a ceasefire and reaffirmed its commitment to Palestinian statehood. Indeed, New Delhi had emphatically declared that it stands with Israel, while often working in multilateral forums to soften language that is critical of Washington and Tel Aviv. But in both the Bishkek and Delhi Declarations, India signed on to very strong criticism of Israel as well as very strong affirmation of Palestinian rights and the two-state solution.

> India's performative diplomacy could undermine its longstanding friendship with Moscow

One interpretation of this pivot in policy is that India may have signed on to the declaration to avoid alienating Mr. Putin and Chinese President Xi Jinping, and thereby jeopardising their attendance at India's BRICS summit. Without the two leaders, India's presidency of BRICS this year would have been a complete failure. Since Operation Sindoor (2025), India has faced a growing perception of diplomatic marginalisation. Meanwhile, Pakistan has gained diplomatic prominence through Washington's selection of Islamabad as a mediator in the conflict with Iran, while several Gulf nations have sought defence agreements with Pakistan. Consequently, India needed a successful and high-profile BRICS summit, which it got.

Contradictory shifts

While there is a shift in India's policy, New Delhi has not abandoned Washington entirely. Mr. Modi's public appeal to Mr. Putin to end the endless war in Ukraine can therefore be read as a counter-signal to Washington. Had the message been intended only for Moscow, it could have been conveyed privately. Delivering it publicly suggested that Mr. Modi was also reassuring the West. India may have joined the SCO and BRICS consensus on Iran to secure a successful BRICS summit, but it was now leaning more toward the western position on Ukraine than before.

These apparently contradictory shifts reveal the strain on India's foreign policy. New Delhi wants to support Israel while condemning attacks on Iran; buy Russian oil while aligning more closely with the West on Ukraine; and remain central to BRICS and the SCO while assuring Washington that it is not part of an anti-American bloc. Multi-alignment is becoming an increasingly difficult exercise in this era of change and turbulence. India's balancing act is unlikely to sit comfortably with either Moscow or Beijing.

Although Mr. Modi and Mr. Xi did not meet bilaterally at the SCO summit in Bishkek, they held talks on the sidelines of the BRICS summit in New Delhi. The meeting preceded Mr. Xi's high-profile G2 summit with U.S. President Donald Trump in Washington, which was held in September 2026. Neither summit declaration mentioned the war in Ukraine, avoiding criticism of Moscow even as Mr. Modi publicly urged Mr. Putin to end the conflict. India thus endorsed two declarations accommodating Russia's position without fully embracing it.

From Mr. Putin's perspective, this was the second time that Mr. Modi had used what might be called '*jumla*' (performative) diplomacy at Russia's expense. At Samarkand on September 16, 2022, Mr. Modi told Mr. Putin that "today's era is not an era of war". External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar subsequently repeated that phrase in western capitals to demonstrate that India's purchase of discounted Russian oil did not signify political support for Russia's invasion.

The selectivity of these admonitions is difficult to ignore. Mr. Modi has not used comparable language toward Mr. Netanyahu, even as Israel has attacked several countries and territories across West Asia, many on multiple occasions, and has committed genocide in Gaza. Nor has Mr. Modi publicly directed the same admonition at Mr. Trump following American attacks on Iran. India itself attacked Pakistan during Operation Sindoor. Mr. Putin may therefore conclude that Mr. Modi's declaration that this is "not an era of war" reflects neither a consistent principle nor a universal opposition to war, but diplomatic messaging designed to reassure the West at Russia's expense.

Mr. Modi's latest appeal – that "endless war" must give way to an "end of war" – may reinforce that perception. Would Mr. Modi deliver the same message to Mr. Trump about the increasingly prolonged war with Iran – or to Mr. Netanyahu about his unending campaign of revenge in Gaza? How is Moscow interpreting this double standard?

Where ties with Russia stand

Russia, nevertheless, still needs India, at least for now, as a major purchaser of its oil and military equipment. At the same time, Moscow can see that New Delhi has steadily reduced its dependence on Russian arms by turning increasingly to France, Israel, and the U.S. The relationship remains important to both countries, but it is becoming increasingly transactional – and vulnerable to their diverging strategic priorities.

Russia is now leaning ever more toward its "trusted partner" – China, while Mr. Modi's performative diplomacy designed to stay in the good books of Washington risks undermining the long enduring Russia-India friendship.

India's next investment cycle will shape its carbon future



Amarendu Nandy

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The United Nations Environment Programme's (UNEP) recent warning that the world could cross the 1.5°C warming threshold within the next few years is likely to renew calls for faster decarbonisation. India, too, will face this pressure, but its choices are still open. Much of the housing, industrial infrastructure, power networks and urban development needed for its next phase of growth is yet to be built.

NITI Aayog estimates that 86% of the building stock that India will have in 2070 is yet to be built. Total floor space will more than double, from about 18 billion square metres in 2020 to 42 billion by 2070. India's crude-steel capacity, at about 200 million tonnes in 2024-25, is targeted to reach 300 million tonnes by 2030-31. Cement output is projected to rise from about 427 million tonnes in 2024 to 660 million tonnes by 2030.

The advantage of choice

The usual reading of these numbers is that India's infrastructure deficit makes decarbonisation harder. Demand for steel, cement and electricity will continue to rise even as India tries to reduce emissions. True, but only partly. The other side of the development deficit is that much of India's future capital stock remains a choice rather than an inheritance. Its future emissions will depend on what it chooses to build now and the technologies and standards that are embedded in that investment.

Mature economies face the opposite problem. The International Energy Agency (IEA) estimates that around 80% of the building stock that advanced economies will use in 2050 already exists. In the European Union, 85% of buildings predate 2000, around three-quarters perform poorly in terms of energy efficiency, and only about 1% are renovated each year. India has legacy problems too, but has more room to avoid creating them. It can build in efficiency from the outset and reduce the risks of stranded assets, premature retirements, or expensive retrofits later. In buildings, India need not wait for technology to catch up. The know-how is there, and so is the regulatory framework. The gap is in implementation.

> Its future emissions will depend on what it chooses to build now and the technologies and standards incorporated into those investments

The Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE)'s State Energy Efficiency Index reports that the Energy Conservation Building Code (ECBC) 2017 has been notified by 27 States, but legally incorporated in only 21. BEE has since issued the Energy Conservation and Sustainable Building Code (ECSBC) 2024 for commercial and office buildings and the Eco-Niwas Samhita (ENS) 2024 for residential buildings. States should embed these standards in building permits, occupancy certificates, and grid connections, where non-compliance can carry a cost.

The issue in the power sector

Power presents a different problem. India has added renewable generation quickly, but the network to move it has not kept pace. The IEA estimates that transmission bottlenecks have held back around 60 GW of renewable capacity. The Ministry of Power's plan envisages roughly 590 GW of generation additions between 2023 and 2032. So, an unresolved transmission gap will become more serious as generation expands. As transport, cooling and parts of industry electrify, the gains from cleaner generation will depend on whether that power can be reliably moved to where it is needed. Transmission and storage, therefore, must be planned alongside, and in some cases ahead of, new generation and demand.

In steel and cement, the low-carbon transition is harder. The Ministry of Steel acknowledges that hydrogen-based green steel is not yet viable in India, while NITI Aayog places large-scale carbon capture in cement further down the transition path. Mandating technologies could raise costs and, worse, lock firms into processes that later prove uneconomic.

Public procurement could be a better instrument. The Union and State governments, Indian Railways, the National Highways Authority of India, and other public agencies buy large quantities of steel and cement and can help create an early market for lower-emission materials.

India already has a green-steel taxonomy, and the Ministry of Steel has proposed aggregated procurement through competitive bidding. Tenders could set emissions-intensity thresholds without prescribing the production route. Competitive bidding would then reveal the green premium while rewarding producers who find the most efficient ways to meet the thresholds. As the premium narrows with economies of scale and technological advances, the thresholds could be tightened. They could also be aligned with the emissions-intensity targets under the Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (CCTS), ensuring consistent policy signals.

Costs and risks

Finance can also skew these choices. The IEA estimates that India's cost of capital for grid-scale renewables is about 80% higher than in advanced economies. Since clean infrastructure is front-loaded in cost, that gap can make an otherwise viable project uneconomic. Targeted instruments such as payment-security mechanisms, partial credit guarantees, or concessional debt can ease financing or off-taker risk. But where the technology is still unproven, cheaper public finance will simply shift more risk onto the public balance sheet.

India cannot avoid the investment required to build the economy it still needs. What matters is what kind of capital the investment leaves behind. Where technology is mature, there is little reason to build inefficiency into assets that will last for decades. Where it is still evolving, preserving flexibility has value. Getting those choices right now can spare the country costlier corrections later.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Brazil's choice

Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva's victory in Brazil's election highlights both democracy's resilience and the formidable challenges facing elected leaders (Page 1, October 27). Democracies cannot afford endless ideological battles between the right and the left while citizens struggle for employment, affordable health care and peace. Regardless of who governs, statesmanship demands confronting global economic realities rather than exploiting public anxieties for electoral gains. Victory at the ballot box is merely the beginning. Delivering dignity, security and opportunity is the true test of leadership. Political parties worldwide must introspect.

Brij B. Goyal,
Ludhiana, Punjab

The headwind turned tailwind win of Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva is a sure sign of the sturdy will of people wedded to democracy to quell the right-wing wave in South America. It is also a strong sign that the wind is blowing against the machinations of U.S. President Donald Trump in South America. Overall, the wins in Brazil and Serbia are signs of change globally.

Ayyasseri Raveendranath,
Aranmula, Keralam

Vanishing paddy fields

The debate over the decline of Keralam's paddy fields must go beyond blaming the restrictive provisions of the Kerala Conservation of Paddy Land and Wetland Act, 2008, or the bureaucracy implementing it. The large-scale conversion of agricultural land has been driven by rising land values, urbanisation, changing employment patterns and the declining viability of traditional paddy cultivation.

The State cannot escape responsibility. Restrictions on land conversion should have been accompanied by measures to make cultivation economically sustainable and protect wetlands. Rising labour costs, fragmented holdings, labour shortages and increasing demand for housing have made paddy farming less attractive. A meaningful assessment must examine the policies that permitted land conversion, who benefited and what measures were taken to protect food security, biodiversity, groundwater recharge and flood regulation. Keralam needs a balanced policy that protects farmers' livelihoods and the environment while accommodating legitimate development needs.

T. Ravindranthan,
Chennai

Fragile hill ecosystems

It is deeply shocking that the pristine Nilgiris district continues to bear the brunt of nature's fury during every monsoon (October 26 and October 27). The loss of greenery, the felling of trees and an indiscriminate construction of commercial complexes, resorts and lodging houses continue unabated, aided by faulty administrative policies and vested interests. Tourism must not be promoted at the cost of environmental destruction.

V. Johan Dhanakumar,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The SIR and its error margin



Nishtha Gupta

Technology policy researcher based in New Delhi

For nearly a month, Indians across the country have courted the ire and might of the state over a question no citizen in a democratic nation should have to ask. Their anger stems from the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise which has removed more than 13 crore names from the rolls since June 2025. Over a quarter were claimed dead or duplicated, while most were marked as absent or shifted. At one booth in Delhi's Bela Estate, officials cut 728 out of 729 voters, citing address proof discrepancies. Who decided that so many names should come off the rolls and on what basis?

While the political answer is being debated on the streets and in Parliament, it is clear that the SIR has changed how a voter's place on the roll is decided. In 1995, the Supreme Court held that a name already on the roll should be presumed to be there legally. The SIR replaced that presumption with a data-matching exercise. The Election Commission of India (ECI) has relied heavily on software for a public task where a single error costs a citizen their vote.

Rolls from the last intensive revision (mostly in 2002) were hastily digitised from Bengali, Kannada, and other regional languages, auto-transliterated by the machine into English, and matched against new enumeration forms. Then a second layer of "logical discrepancies," such as a parent-child age gap of less than 15 years, was applied. Among those who failed the test were twins (age gap less than nine months), voters of the Oraon tribal group whose surname Xalxo was auto-translated to Khalkho, and those whose father's name was 'Md.' in one list and 'Mohammed' in the other. To reconcile the record, little logic or reasoning was applied. According to the Internet Freedom Foundation, these rules flagged 17% of West Bengal's electors and 41% of Madhya Pradesh's. A system that suspects four in 10 voters in a State needs to come under scrutiny.

Such sweeping pattern-matching guarantees false positives. In West Bengal, 91% of exclusion appeals decided by the tribunals were reversed; a reversal rate that high should worry whoever designed the process. And by the time their eligibility was restored, these people had already lost the opportunity to vote in the 2026 Assembly election.

Drawing the line

This is why it matters where the line is drawn for who is "suspicious". How many eligible voters are risked to remove one ineligible voter? Legally, Election Registration Officers (EROs) determine where the limit lies. Yet in the SIR, the ECI has never revealed what the acceptable margin of error is or the data itself. Two of the three Election Commissioners are on record objecting to the centralisation of the database and the restrictions imposed on local officers' authority. In Goa, officers heard 97 flagged voters and found all eligible, but couldn't restore them because the software had no option to reverse the earlier action.

The ECI claims that automation is only meant to assist human decisions. This would be true if officers actually had the chance to evaluate every flagged entry. In Delhi, each booth-level officer received about 200 notices to verify within a very tight deadline. When the queue becomes practically unmanageable, the machine's verdict on an individual case inevitably becomes the State's verdict.

The citizen then pays to undo this through hearings and lost wages, or is forced to remain disenfranchised if unable to appeal. In West Bengal, the damage went beyond voting when a June State order marked the ration cards of SIR-removed voters as inactive. The SC has since restored access to food. India has sold its digital public infrastructure to the rest of the world on the premise of inclusion at scale. Built on faulty data, the same architecture excludes at scale, and an error in one register follows a person into the next.

This doesn't mean that the rolls shouldn't be cleaned. What must change is where the risk tolerance lies. A dead voter left on the roll is a clerical error. A living voter who is struck off loses their constitutional right. The ECI should disclose the matching rules and error rates and open itself to an independent audit. No name should be struck off until an officer with actual time and authority verifies the real person behind the data.

The model is already travelling. In January, Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar offered the ECINet platform to help other countries build their own versions. In August, U.S. President Donald Trump cited India's photo ID rules to push for stricter U.S. voter laws. Whatever standard the world's largest democracy accepts for electoral error, other nations will follow.

A dead voter left on the roll is a clerical error. A living voter who is struck off loses their constitutional right

Are coronary stents necessary?



Dr. Enas A. Enas

Preventive Cardiologist and Physician-Scientist, Founding President of the CADI Research Foundation USA



Dr. Basil Varkey

Professor Emeritus of medicine

Keralam Chief Minister V. D. Satheesan's recent remarks questioning "unnecessary" angioplasty procedures have drawn objections from medical organisations concerned that it could undermine public confidence in doctors. But the Chief Minister's remarks demand more than a reflex response; it requires a thoughtful, honest response built on up-to-date evidence based on clinical and research studies.

Percutaneous Coronary Intervention (PCI), by balloon angioplasty and stent placement, has transformed cardiovascular care. During an acute heart attack caused by a suddenly blocked coronary artery, prompt angioplasty and stents can restore blood flow, save heart muscle and improve survival. There is no debate about this approach and second opinions are unnecessary as time is of essence in such an emergency. Stents also offer substantial relief to selected patients with persistent activity-limiting angina (chest pain caused by lack of oxygen-rich blood).

There is a crucial distinction between stenting as a life-saving measure in the above situations to medical treatment via stenting because a narrowing of blood vessels is seen on an angiogram. A coronary angiogram shows the anatomy of the arteries; it does not, by itself, establish that a narrowing requires intervention. The decision to intervene and how to intervene must take account of the patient's symptoms, the severity of the blockage, its effect on blood flow, the overall pattern of coronary disease and the expected benefit of intervention.

The landmark ISCHEMIA trial, published in *The New England Journal of Medicine* in 2020, enrolled 5,179 patients at 320 sites in 37 countries with stable coronary artery disease and moderate to severe ischemia (restricted blood flow to the heart). The patients were assigned either to an initial invasive strategy – angiography followed by angioplasty or coronary bypass surgery – or to a conservative strategy of optimal medical treatment, with revascularisation reserved for those who had an acute event or angina. After a median follow-up of 3.2 years, there was no significant difference between the two groups in composite outcomes (cardiac arrests, hospitalisation for unstable angina or heart failure) and all-cause and cardiovascular mortality were similar. After a follow-up of 5 years, there was still no significant difference between the two groups in composite outcome or mortality. The core lesson is that most patients with stable coronary artery disease with ischemia on optimal medical treatment would do as well as those who undergo stenting or bypass surgery.

Concerning scale

The growing scale of PCI in India deserves careful examination. National Interventional Council figures show that annual PCI procedures rose from approximately 1,13,000 in 2008 to more than 7,26,000 in 2024 – an increase of more than six-fold. In contrast, PCI procedures in the U.S. fell by about 40% between 2003 and 2016, reflecting progress in prevention and treatment.

These figures do not by themselves prove that stents are overused in India considering its large population, the substantial burden of premature coronary disease, the socio-economic progress in the past decades and the improved access to cardiac care centres. Nevertheless, the divergence in trends between the two countries raises an important question: how much of the increase in PCI is a reflection of fulfilling a genuine clinical need, and how much of it is a reflection of differences in practice patterns, financial incentives and gaps in knowledge on the efficacy of optimal medical treatment?

Optimal medical therapy, based on evidence-based guidelines, is the foundation of care for all coronary artery disease patients. The elements of optimal therapy include LDL-cholesterol lowering, appropriate anti-platelet treatment, blood-pressure control, evidence-based diabetes management and lifestyle changes. A coronary stent treats a specific narrowing; it does not cure the underlying disease of atherosclerosis or eliminate the risk of future heart attacks. Patients remain vulnerable to disease elsewhere in the coronary arteries and must continue preventive treatment.

The way forward is neither condemnation of cardiologists nor unquestioning acceptance of every recommendation for angioplasty. Most doctors strive to act in their patients' best interests, but no profession is immune to inappropriate practice. The ultimate test of healthcare is not how many procedures are performed, but how many lives are saved and whether patients receive the right treatment at the right time at an affordable cost.

There is a crucial distinction between stenting as a life-saving measure to medical treatment via stenting because a narrowing of blood vessels is seen on an angiogram

The numbers behind Lula's historic victory

Lula secured an unprecedented fourth term in Brazil due to a campaign strategy focussing on high voter mobilisation and populist labour reforms

DATA POINT

Sambavi Parthasarathy
Gandla Sneha
Sachin Swaraj

Lula da Silva's reelection as the President of Brazil on Sunday was no less than a historical feat. The 81-year-old, who defeated his far-right opponent Flavio Bolsonaro, gained at least 10 million votes in less than three weeks **(Chart 1)**.

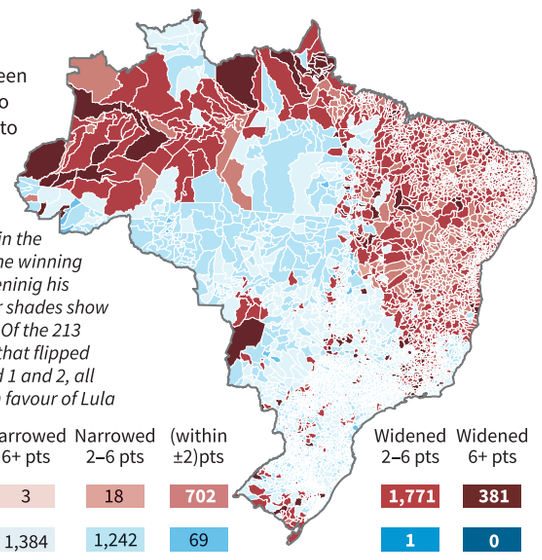
Much of his victory has been credited to a campaign strategy focussing on high voter mobilisation and populist labour reforms including cash payout schemes for the poor and a new debt relief package post the first round of elections – in which he trailed behind Bolsonaro. This was unprecedented in the country's elections as no candidate who had lost the first round in the past had emerged victorious in the second **(Table 2)**. His victory carries implications much beyond Brazil. For much of South America that has been hit by a conservative right-wing wave, Mr. Lula's victory offers a change **(Table 3)**.

Under Mr. Lula's third presidential term, Brazil saw notable economic growth, accompanied by increased labour force participation. The country's real Gross Domestic Product grew cumulatively by 9% between 2023 and 2025, the highest among nine other countries in the region. The share of Brazil's working population increased consistently since 2022. This was accompanied by a rise in average monthly earnings **(Chart 4)**.

Meanwhile, the country's unemployment rate and poverty declined to its lowest in at least a decade. As of 2024, Brazil recorded an unemployment rate of 6.8% and 23% of its population were living below poverty, that is $6.85 a day as per the country's definition **(Chart 5)**. However, the country's household and government debt have surged to new highs increasing borrowing costs **(Chart 6)**.



Chart 1: Changes in margins between Lula and Flavio from Round 1 to Round 2



Darker shades in the map indicate the winning candidate wideninig his margin. Lighter shades show the narrowing. Of the 213 municipalities that flipped between Round 1 and 2, all but one were in favour of Lula

	Narrowed 6+ pts	Narrowed 2–6 pts	(within ±2)pts	Widened 2–6 pts	Widened 6+ pts
Won by Lula	3	18	702	1,771	381
Won by Flavio	1,384	1,242	69	1	0

Chart 2: Countries with left and right leaning governments in South America



Venezuela is marked in grey since Delcy Rodriguez is in charge as interim president after the U.S. arrested former president Nicolas Maduro in January 2026

Chart 5: Poverty (left axis) and unemployment (right axis) have declined to their lowest in a decade

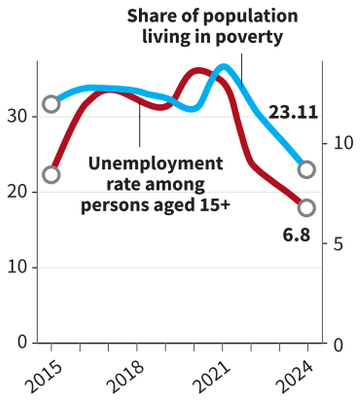


Chart 6: Brazil's household and national debt have surged to new highs in the last decade

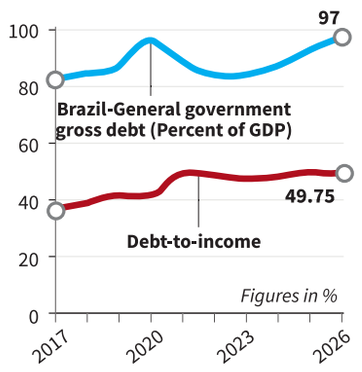


Table 3: Past results of candidates in Round 1 and Round 2 of the Brazil Presidential elections

Year	Round 1	Round 2
1989	Collor (30.48%)	Collor (53.03 %)
1994	Fernando Henrique (54.28%)	-
1998	Fernando Henrique (53.06%)	-
2002	Lula (46.44%)	Lula (61.27%)
2006	Lula (48.61%)	Lula (60.83%)
2010	Dilma (46.91%)	Dilma (56.05%)
2014	Dilma (41.59%)	Dilma (51.64%)
2018	Bolsonaro (46.03%)	Bolsonaro (55.13%)
2022	Lula (48.43%)	Lula (50.90%)
2026	Bolsonaro (47.03%)	Lula (51.79%)

** In 1994 and 1998, no runoff was held because the winning candidates had already secured a majority, receiving more than 50% of the votes*

Chart 4: The share of population employed in the labour force and their average monthly earnings (in $)



Data for 2026 till October 2026. Gandla Sneha and Sachin Swaraj are interning with The Hindu Data Team

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 28, 1976

ITDC plan to build hotels abroad

New Delhi, October 27: Indian Tourism Development Corporation, world's second biggest public sector undertaking of its kind running a chain of hotels, motels, travellers lodges, beach resorts and forest lodges in the country is planning to set up initially about half a dozen 'Indian restaurants' at 'strategic' places in the world.

According to Lt. Gen J.T. Sataravalla, Chairman and Managing Director of ITDC, now that the Corporation has already built up the necessary hotel infrastructure at important tourist centres within the country, it wants to popularise the famous Indian dishes to the foreigners at these restaurants abroad and also attract them to visit India.

The location of these Indian restaurants abroad has not yet been finalised but they will be set up at some of the important world capitals. Some of them are likely to be located in the oil-rich Gulf countries. The managers of these restaurants will be specially trained in marketing Indian tourism abroad.

The ITDC, which expects to earn Rs 7 crores of foreign exchange during 1975-76, has already entered the field in giving technical assistance abroad in running hotel industry. It is setting up an Indian restaurant at Prague with Czech collaboration.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 28, 1926

Message from Mars?

An "Englishman" correspondent cables under date London, October 25: Wireless experts are installing special apparatus on the highest peak of Mont Blanc and will attempt to communicate with Mars on Oct. 27.

[To-day Mars comes within 42,000,000 miles of the earth. An earlier message stated: The periodical "Popular Wireless" is using a 14 valve superheterodyne receiver to listen in. It is pointed out that certain Morse letters and other mysterious signals are received from time to time which are not attributable to any earthly station. Arguments for and against the feasibility of signalling are revived, but the pro-Martians say that Mars as a senior planet possesses older brains on her. In order to open up a conversation amateurs throughout the world are invited to listen in.]

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Share of SIR notices disposed of by poll officials in Delhi

94 in per cent. More than 31.26 lakh notices or 94.34 per cent of the total 33.14 lakh notices issued to voters under the ongoing SIR exercise in Delhi have been disposed of, and the names parked for inclusion in the final list to be published on December 4, the office of the Delhi Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) said on Tuesday. The notices are to be disposed of by November 30. PTI

Flights cancelled in two A.P. cities due to Cyclone Arnab

21 At least 21 flights were cancelled at Vijayawada and Visakhapatnam airports on Tuesday as a very severe cyclonic storm approached the Andhra Pradesh coast, officials said. In its latest bulletin, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said that Cyclone Arnab was over the Bay of Bengal, about 170 km south-southeast of Visakhapatnam, at 11.30 am. PTI

Station masters to be recruited nationwide by Nov 25

1,265 The recruitment process for railways station masters will provide a notification covering examination procedures and vacancy distribution for the post. The online application window will close on November 25, 2026. The Railways Ministry advised candidates to review instructions before submitting their forms. PTI

Uttarakhand govt.'s supplementary budget for 2026-27

7.8 in ₹ thousand crores. The State government said that of the total supplementary budget, ₹4,164.32 crore is earmarked for capital expenditure, and ₹3,679.86 crore for revenue expenditure. More than half of it is directed toward capital investment. With the supplementary budget of ₹1,11,703.21 crore, the total budget for 2026-27 will reach ₹1,19,547.39 crore. PTI

Number of fighters killed in fresh clashes in Yemen

97 At least 63 Houthi fighters and 34 pro-government combatants have died, mostly near the Bab al-Mandab strait, the Red Sea's strategic southern chokepoint, they said. The clashes are the fiercest since the Houthis seized swathes of territory from the Saudi-backed government in a lightning offensive last month. AFP

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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On the question of KIIFB's future

An expert panel constituted by Keralam's UDF government to review the functioning of KIIFB has recommended winding it up and absorbing its functions into the State government, prompting a closer look at the merits of off-budget borrowings by States and the need to boost public investment in Keralam

ECONOMIC NOTES

R. Nagaraj

In July, Keralam's newly elected UDF government set up an expert panel to review the functioning of Kerala Infrastructure Investment Fund Board (KIIFB). The panel, headed by a former civil servant, was tasked with recommending measures to restructure KIIFB and strengthen the government's institutional capabilities, among other things. The committee has recently submitted its report, which has been tabled in the State Assembly.

Apparently critical of KIIFB's functioning, the committee has recommended winding it up; absorbing its functions and capabilities into the State government, news reports say. The principal reason for the panel's recommendation is that with the clubbing of KIIFB's borrowing function with the State budget, the special purpose vehicle (SPV) has lost its primary purpose.



KIIFB reportedly boosted the State's infrastructure investment by raising extra-budgetary resources, including securing soft loans known as "Masala Bonds" from international agencies. FILE PHOTO

A disputed investment model

KIIFB, restructured by the LDF government, reportedly boosted the State's infrastructure investment by raising extra-budgetary resources, including securing soft loans known as "Masala Bonds" from international agencies after the disastrous floods of 2019. However, the SPV's functioning and financial performance have remained contentious. The comptroller and auditor general's (CAG) strictures against KIIFB have become a convenient beating stick for the Centre and the Opposition parties in the State. In the fog of the debate, KIIFB's original purpose and economic principles underlying it seem to have been lost sight of.

Though Keralam has sound traditional transport infrastructure such as road network and rail connectivity, it lags behind in modern facilities, such as high-speed railways or highways, especially when compared to the neighbouring States. Keralam reportedly spends a mere 1.5 per cent of the Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) on infrastructure. This was so in spite of Keralam's own-tax revenue to GSDP ratio being among the highest among major States, as per the RBI data.

KIIFB was set up in 1999 and underwent a major restructuring in 2016; the institution's record in expanding public goods is apparently well acknowledged. However, its functioning raised many queries. The CAG found that the SPV's finances flouted its procedural audits, which became a sticking point between the Centre and the State. Moreover, as KIIFB functioned outside the purview of the State budget, without generating financial profits from its lending, its borrowings being serviced out of the State's revenue became the heart of the contention.

Rationale for off-budget borrowing

In the good/bad old days of "planning", State finances broadly followed the "gap-filling" approach; meaning the Centre made up the difference between a State's projected revenue growth and its "developmental needs" as per the State plans. It was a negotiated process, part financial and part political. Evidence shows that richer and politically influential States got the lion's share of the divisible pool of the plan resources.

The Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management Act (FRBM) 2003 changed that by seemingly imposing a "hard budget constraint", with the fiscal deficit capped at 3 per cent of GSDP. The RBI now monitors the size of the State debt. The coupon (interest) rate of the State loans depends on the State's debt sustainability measures. The hard budget constraint has reportedly improved State finances, or at a minimum, made them transparent.

However, most States have devised a variety of means for securing extra-budgetary resources, or off-budget borrowings (OBBs) – as evident from the RBI's compilation of State finances. The CAG, tracking OBBs, finds that there is a bewildering variety of them. And the actual OBBs are far higher than what it is able to count, as per its own findings. Incidentally, Keralam is not among the worst offenders.

Globally, a variety of financial institutions and fiscal arrangements have existed outside of the budgetary process. Numerous kinds of para-statal organisations are a feature – not a bug – of the fiscal landscape, especially among fast-growing Asian economies. China, for instance, has a bewildering variety of financial arrangements that enable provinces to draw resources from the national development banks to sustain employment at the local level, augment production and exports and ensure political stability.

Then, realistically, what should be the rules for managing extra-budgetary resources and institutions for Keralam? Simply speaking, if extra-budgetary resources are productively used and they comply with the government expenditure principles, having such off-budget institutions/borrowings may not be undesirable. This follows the Domar rule: so long as the output growth rate exceeds the interest rate on such loans, they are being used productively. Since such investments have a public good character, individual projects may not be yielding adequate revenue or covering the full costs. However, if in the aggregate they contribute to growth in state output (GSDP) and follow the Domar rule, then such investments are in principle viable.

However, if the State-level SPVs borrow from external sources for social purposes or green financing, which usually have lower interest rates for longer maturities, they need to be assessed differently, as they involve exchange rate risk. Given Keralam's fragile ecology and need for substantial low-cost resources for protecting it, external borrowing for such purposes by creating SPVs may be desirable, as KIIFB reportedly proved to be after the floods in 2019. The expert committee's recommendation to dissolve KIIFB is the easier part. In the present political milieu, efforts to boost public investments to catch up with the neighbouring States are a harder job – with the Centre strictly monitoring Keralam. The State will have to devise newer and administratively innovative means to tap OBBs, as most States do. The task is primarily a political one.

(R. Nagaraj is an economist.)

THE GIST

- An expert panel constituted by Keralam's UDF government to review KIIFB's functioning has recommended winding it up, primarily on the grounds that the integration of KIIFB's borrowing function with the State budget has deprived the special purpose vehicle of its primary purpose
- However, if extra-budgetary resources are used productively and in compliance with the principles governing government expenditure, such off-budget institutions and borrowings may not be undesirable

What was leaked in the Censor Board data breach?

What impact could the leak have? When was the leaked data taken down? What is the status of the probe?

Aroon Deep

The story so far:

A data breach at the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC) left hundreds of applications' data exposed online, *The Hindu* found. The data comes from over 500 titles, of which dozens are feature films. The leak comes from the censor board's e-Cinepramaan portal, used by filmmakers to submit their applications. The records ranged from December 2025 to August 2026.

What were the leaked documents?

The leaked documents included shooting scripts, with detailed shot-by-shot translations and other annotations. These scripts appear to have been specifically prepared for the censor board's review of these films – one script even included labels on swear words used over the course of the film and other clarifications on dialogue.

The breached data also included a summary of cuts that were ordered by the CBFC. This is supposed to be public information anyway under Section 5A(2) of the Cinematograph Act, 1952, but the censor board put this data behind an "under maintenance" message on its website.

In what could be the most sensitive of the exposed documents, film distribution agreements – both from international filmmakers distributing into India and Indian filmmakers authorising dubbed versions in a different part of the country – were exposed. At least three such agreements had unredacted or improperly redacted information on what fees were paid to license a film for distribution in India. *The Hindu* is withholding specifics here.

"Commercial agreements in the film industry often contain carefully negotiated provisions governing creative control, casting, remuneration, profit-sharing, intellectual property rights, promotional obligations, and even specific conditions concerning a film's storyline, portrayal or production," Vasundhara S., managing partner at Verum Legal told *The Hindu*.

"When commercially sensitive or specially negotiated creative terms enter the public domain, the confidentiality underpinning these agreements is compromised," Ms. Vasundhara said. "Such disclosures can weaken negotiating positions, reveal commercially valuable information, influence future contractual negotiations and potentially expose parties to disputes arising from confidentiality obligations."

"If I am a competing party or a counterparty, I'd be in a much better position to negotiate now that I have confirmation as to what terms these guys would agree to for certain types of works, beyond what is generally known in the market," Abhinav Hansaraman, a commercial lawyer in Delhi said.

Where was the data posted?

The documents were posted as dockets that contained practically everything but a copy of the film itself, and posted on the site of the non-profit Internet Archive portal. The data dump, most of it was posted on a single day, lay on the site for days, open to anyone to review and download. It is unclear if the data dump's existence was known to anyone.

The majority of the documents were posted earlier this month, but were all taken down on October 12. The user, whose display ID was former CBFC chairman Prasoon Joshi's name in Russian, also deleted their account. *The Hindu* was unable to contact them.

How did CBFC respond to the breach?

Last week, *The Hindu* contacted the CBFC for comment on the breach. The censor board did not appear to have immediate information on the breach. A week after being provided granular details of what documents were leaked from which film application, CBFC chairperson Shashi Shekhar Vempati said in a statement that it was looking into the breach. "CBFC has reviewed the information shared regarding alleged unauthorised access to CBFC's e-Cinepramaan Portal," the CBFC said. "However, based on the information examined so far, no trace has been found of the certification-related documents that were claimed to have been accessed."

The Internet Archive told *The Hindu* in a statement that the account in question was taken down by the user themselves. "As a matter of caution, a complaint has been filed with Cybercrime, and CERT-In has also been notified of the allegations and provided with the information shared," the CBFC added in its statement to *The Hindu*. CERT-In is India's computer emergency response team, which is tasked with handling data breach and hacking incidents.

"The technical team has also conducted a thorough analysis of the servers and databases to assess whether any external attacks may have compromised their security," CBFC added. "The findings of this analysis are being considered alongside the ongoing forensic examination."

On October 4, the e-Cinepramaan portal was unavailable for hours. The user stopped uploading any further documents shortly thereafter. No individual filmmaker's account seems to have been compromised, the CBFC said in its statement, and committed to a "thorough security audit" of the e-Cinepramaan portal.

CACHE



Safety check: Dating app users should first vet the platforms they register with, making sure that they agree with how data is collected and processed. GETTY IMAGES

What did a U.S. investigation uncover about Tinder's failure to detect scams?

U.S. lawmakers shared troubling statistics about how dating app users on Tinder and Hinge were matching with scammers, due to outdated AI protections; the probe also acknowledged that Match Group had introduced new safety measures this year to detect scammers

Sahana Venugopal

Earlier in October, U.S. lawmakers revealed how users of dating apps were being exposed to serious financial and physical risks. They pinned this to the outdated AI stack in these applications.

In an investigation centred around the Match Group, the lawmakers found that the algorithm matched U.S. users of dating apps like Tinder and Hinge with scammers.

The report, titled 'Outmatched: Tinder, Scammers, and Match Group's Efforts to Catch Up', highlighted that users connected with nearly 1.5 million scammers on these two popular dating applications in the first nine months of 2025.

At the core of these disturbing findings were outdated machine learning models installed to detect bad actors. These had not been updated in years, according to the report.

This information came from internal documents that the Match Group shared with the committee, led by senator Maggie Hassan. As the accuracy of scam detection dropped, Tinder began depending on other measures that it knew were often ineffective.

"In fact, Match Group knew that Tinder was more likely to show a profile if it belonged to a scammer or other bad actor rather than a regular user," stated an official press release about the report.

However, the investigation acknowledged that the Match Group later put in place new safety measures, such as an AI model in Tinder this year that was designed to detect scammers and bad actors.

What kinds of scams were prevalent on the apps?

The report included statements from victims who described how romance scammers cheated them out of tens of thousands of dollars after building a relationship with them on the dating apps.

A common trend was to cite a major emergency in order to pressure the victim into sending over money. Using the victims' phone number and/or email ID, the scammers would proceed to harass them online until the victim sometimes paid them in the hopes of de-escalating their aggression.

Another type of scam involved the same malicious user operating as different people on the same dating app, to ensnare more victims.

The report pointed to an inconsistent dating app AI strategy, where patchy machine learning systems led to heavy caseloads and "overwhelmed" human moderators who were unable to focus on visibly risky accounts. As per a document from the Match Group itself, Tinder could have better tackled dangerous accounts by building better AI signals or reducing its reliance on manual rules.

"In practice, these moderation lapses meant that bad actors that reached moderation were not immediately banned and instead may have continued to interact with and harm legitimate users until the platform gathered additional evidence," explained the report.

What is the takeaway for Indian dating app users?

A bouquet of dating apps come under the Match Group, including Tinder, Hinge, Match (formerly Match.com), Plenty of Fish, and more such offerings, catering to users in diverse countries and cultural communities.

In other words, a security lapse in one app comes with serious implications for the users of other Match Group-owned apps. Tinder and Hinge are popular in India as well, claiming the top ranks in terms of downloads via app marketplaces.

According to the Match Group, Hinge is expected to reach $1 billion in revenue in 2027, while Tinder is expanding its in-person events that are already live in the U.S. and Europe.

Indian users often register with apps that suggest profiles and tout AI-powered matchmaking as a selling point. However, as the U.S. committee report noted, cutting-edge AI tools require constant upkeep, testing, and upgrades in order to ensure that customers remain shielded from emerging threats.

Regulators must also play a larger role in monitoring dating app services.

How can users avoid scammers on dating apps?

Dating app users should first vet the platforms they register with, making sure that they agree with how data is collected and processed.

Users should also be aware of the reporting options they have in case an online or offline interaction turns unsafe. Customers can research the apps' founders, investors, and brand ambassadors, to make sure that there is an alignment of values.

Dating app users should promptly report fraudulent user profiles and cease interacting with them. AI-generated user photos and videos, even when posted as a joke, often violate platform policies.

Another red flag is a dating app user who becomes intimate too quickly or is eager to discuss finances early on. Furthermore, scammers often pressure dating app users to contact them on external sites, so they can view the user's phone number or harvest other personal details.

Users must withhold personal phone numbers, email IDs, home addresses, private social media channels, and employer information until they meet a match in-person and feel comfortable with proceeding.

THE DAILY QUIZ

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

At the age of 81, Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva has secured an unprecedented fourth term as the President of Brazil. Here's a quiz on the veteran leader

Joan Sony Cherian

QUESTION 1
Lula is a founding member of the Workers' Party or the Partido dos Trabalhadores. When was it formed?

QUESTION 2
After Lula won his third term in 2022, an incident mirroring the 2021 January 6 Capitol hill riots happened in Brazil where Brazil's Congress and Supreme Court buildings were stormed. Why?

QUESTION 3
Brazil's top political leaders were hit by scandal when in 2017 a high-profile anti-corruption investigation exposed money laundering and corruption among the top brass. It also led to Lula's arrest on the same charges in 2018. Name the anti-corruption probe.

QUESTION 4
Campaigns and pictures routinely feature the number '13' in association with Lula. What is the significance of the number?

QUESTION 5
In 2004, a *New York Times* article on President Lula infuriated him so much that the reporter of the article had his journalist via revoked by the Brazilian government. They said the article was "offensive to the honour of the President". Name the reporter and what the article said.



Visual question: Here, Lula is seen with another global leftist leader and icon. Name the revolutionary leader. AFP

Questions and answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. Name of Pakistan's Prime Minister when martial law was proclaimed in October 1958. **Ans: Feroz Khan Noon**
2. Mirza abrogated this when he proclaimed martial law on October 7, 1958. **Ans: The Constitution of 1956**
3. The system of indirect elections, which was introduced by Ayub Khan in 1959 as the foundation of his political structure. **Ans: The Basic Democracies system**
4. Ayub Khan relinquish the presidency in this year, ending his period in power. **Ans: 1969**
5. Iskander Mirza went into exile to this country after his removal from office. **Ans: The United Kingdom**
Visual: This is a front-page report in *The Pakistan Times* dated March 10, 1951, announcing arrests in a conspiracy that preceded Ayub Khan's military coup by seven years. State the name by which the conspiracy is known. **Ans: The Rawalpindi Conspiracy Case**
Early birds: KN Viswanathan| Mohan Lal Patel| Tamal Biswas| Baburam Sapre| Arun Kumar Singh



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the meaning of "hogwash"? (Geetha Udaykumar, Mannarkudi)
This is a word, which is normally used in informal contexts. When somebody says something and you respond by saying, "hogwash", what you are implying is that as far as you are concerned what the individual has said is nonsense. Here are a few examples.

What she told me was hogwash.

I have no time to listen to your hogwash, Seema.

The word has the same meaning as "baloney".

I am not here to listen to your baloney.

His baloney didn't go down well with the boss.

Bad food and drink can also be called "hogwash".

The stuff that was served at the wedding was hogwash.

Don't go to the new restaurant. The food is hogwash.

Shouldn't it be World Trade Centre and not "Center"? (P.P. Hafeez, Kerala)
The word "Center" has been spelt correctly. That's the way the Americans spell it. A few words, which end in "re" in British English, the Americans spell it "er". Here are a few examples: meter, center, and theater.

Which of the following sentences is correct? "He walked into the apartment" or "He walked in the apartment"? (B. Abhishek, Bengaluru)
Both the sentences are grammatically acceptable, but their meaning is very different. When someone "walks into" an apartment he enters it. In other words, the individual has stepped into the apartment. He was outside all the while and now he has stepped inside.

Similarly, when you say that someone has "moved into" his new apartment, what you are implying is that he has shifted to his new apartment. He has made the new place his home. When you say that someone "walked in the apartment" what you are saying is that the individual walked around inside the apartment.

Unlike the earlier example, the individual is not entering the apartment. He is already inside and he is moving about. The action takes place within the apartment.

What is the meaning of the idiom "sink your teeth into something"? (P.K. Abu Baker, Calicut)
When you sink your teeth into something, you undertake to do something; you perform the task with a great deal of enthusiasm and interest. Here are a few examples.

His new role as a villain gave him something that he could sink his teeth into.

The new project is really interesting. Can't wait to sink my teeth into it.

It is also possible to say "get one's teeth into something". Here are a few examples.

He just couldn't get his teeth into his new role.

My wife has been telling me to get my teeth into some social work.

Published in The Hindu on May 21, 2002

Word of the day

Purveyor:
someone who supplies provisions

Synonym: supplier

Usage: *The company is a leading purveyor of gourmet food.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/purveyor

International Phonetic Alphabet: /pə(:)ˈveɪə/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

INBRIEF



TMB posts record ₹451-cr. net braces for higher provisioning

Tamilnad Mercantile Bank (TMB) reported its highest-ever quarterly net profit of ₹451.14 crore in the second quarter of FY27, registering a 42.09% year-on-year (YoY) increase on the back of strong core banking income and improved cost efficiency. However, the bank expects its provisioning requirements under the upcoming expected credit loss (ECL) framework to rise further as its balance sheet expands. Total business grew 27.25% YoY to ₹1.30 lakh crore.

AM Green to supply JERA green ammonia in Japan

JERA Co., Inc., which produces a third of Japan's power and is one of the largest global LNG buyers and AM Green Ammonia (India) have entered into a pact for long-term supply of green ammonia made in India. Under a Binding Heads of Agreement (HoA), AM Green would supply about 70,000 tonne green ammonia a year over five years with the potential to extend the term for additional supply. The green ammonia will be made at AM Green's Kakinada facility in A.P.

L&T net up 33% to ₹5,202 cr. in Q2 on higher revenue

Engineering major Larsen & Toubro (L&T) reported a 32.5% rise in consolidated net profit to ₹5,202.10 crore for the quarter ended September 2026, driven by higher revenue. The company posted a consolidated net profit of ₹3,926.09 crore in the year-ago period. L&T achieved consolidated revenue of ₹78,750 crore for the reporting quarter, up 16% year on year, driven by accelerated progress across its businesses, the company said in a statement. PTI

Coal India H1 capex up 27% to ₹7,966 cr., exceeds the set target

The mining firm's capital expenditure in the first half of the fiscal year surpassed the stipulated target of ₹7,286 crore for the period

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

State-owned Coal India Ltd (CIL) raised its capital expenditure by 27% year-on-year (YoY) to ₹7,966 crore in the first half of the current financial year, exceeding its stipulated target of ₹7,286 crore for the period.

CIL used over 48% of annual capex outlay of ₹16,500 crore, reflecting a strong investment push towards boosting mining infrastructure, expanding operational capacity and improving coal evacuation.

Mine infrastructure development, land acquisition, plant and machinery, and diversification together accounted for 79% of the expenditure during the April-September period.

"These strategic investments are expected to strengthen the company's operational capabilities and support the achievement of its production and supply targets for the ongoing financial year," Coal India said. Mine infrastructure development accounted for the largest share of capex at ₹2,152 crore.



Bigger, stronger: Strategic investments are expected to strengthen the company's operational capabilities. REUTERS

Tata Motors inches closer to acquiring Italy's Iveco Group

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Inclusive of dividend, the aggregate price for the deal rises to to €14.40 per share

Tata Motors' acquisition of Italian commercial vehicle maker Iveco Group is nearing completion, with its wholly owned subsidiary, TML CV Holdings B.V., securing 89.42% of the company's common share capital, net of treasury shares, through its voluntary totalitarian tender offer.

In an exchange filing, Tata Motors Ltd said TML CV Holdings B.V., acting through its parent, TML CV Holdings Pte. Ltd., had received 238,157,212 common shares of Iveco Group N.V. tendered in acceptance of the offer.

Condition satisfied

"Based on the provisional results of the Offer (subject to confirmation) and taking into account the acceptances of the Offer recorded as of the date hereof, the Threshold Condition has been satisfied," the company stated. The final results of the offer will be announced on October 29.

The consideration for each common share tendered comprises the initial offer price of €14.10, inclusive of dividends, plus an additional €0.30, also inclusive of dividends, taking the aggregate consideration to €14.40 per share.

The transfer of ownership of the shares tendered during the acceptance period, against payment of the consideration, is scheduled for October 30. In 2025, Tata Motors announced plans to buy Iveco, excluding its defence business, in a deal valued at around €3.8 billion.



A view shows a Microsoft logo at the company's office at Issy-les-Moulineaux, near Paris.

MS offers 27% staff voluntary buyouts on hastening AI spend

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

Microsoft has offered 60,000 employees, or about 27% of its global workforce, voluntary buyouts as the software giant spends heavily on artificial intelligence (AI).

Chief people officer Amy Coleman said in a blog post Monday that the company's voluntary exit offer was available to eligible employees in Canada, India, the United Kingdom and the United States.

"The Voluntary Exit Offer is new for us," Ms. Coleman wrote. "We'll learn from it. At the same time, we'll keep helping people focus on the work that matters most, build new skills and, where it makes sense, find new opportunities across Microsoft."

The company, which releases its quarterly financial performance Wednesday, had approximately 2,23,000 full-time employees at the end of June.

Maruti Suzuki Q2 net dips to ₹2,466.1 crore

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Car market leader Maruti Suzuki India Ltd. reported a 26.4% dip in consolidated net profit for the second quarter ended September to ₹2,466.1 crore on higher input costs resulting from the West-Asia conflict even as revenue rose sharply, driven by record quarterly vehicle sales volumes.

The auto major had posted a net profit of ₹3,349 crore in the same quarter of the previous fiscal, a regulatory filing to the exchanges showed.

During July-September, revenue from operations rose to ₹53,355.5 crore against ₹42,344.2 crore in the same period of 2025-26 fiscal, the automaker said.

'New bad loans may rise in FY27; private banks to face pressure'

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

Fresh non-performing assets (NPA) in the banking sector are likely to increase in the current fiscal, with private sector banks expected to face relatively higher pressure due to their exposure to unsecured retail and micro, small and medium enterprise loans, according to a report.

Ratings agency Icra expects the trend of relatively higher loan slippages at private sector banks to continue in the second half of FY27, even as credit costs are projected to stay favourable and significantly below historical levels.

According to the rating agency's estimates, the fresh NPA generation rate for public sector banks is projected at 0.8% in FY27, while that for private sector banks is estimated at 2.5%.

In absolute terms, fresh NPA is estimated at ₹1 lakh crore in FY27 for State-owned banks and ₹1.3 lakh crore for private banks, according to the report released on Tuesday.

InvITs look at a bigger slice of India's vast household savings

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

India's infrastructure investment trusts (InvITs) are attracting more investors, creating a potential avenue to channel domestic savings into roads, power transmission networks and other income-generating infrastructure assets.

The number of investors in listed InvITs rose to 6.53 lakh in the first quarter of FY27, while assets under management (AUM) increased to ₹7.3 lakh crore, according to the Bharat InvITs Association (BIA).

Distributions to unitholders during the quarter stood at ₹5,923 crore, taking cumulative payouts since the sector's inception beyond ₹97,000 crore.



Lower entry barriers are an attraction to invest in InvITs.

The growth comes as India faces mounting financing requirements for infrastructure expansion. While government spending and foreign investment remain important, household savings and investments held by mutual funds, insurers and pension funds could provide a larger pool of long-term capital, according to industry executives.

InvITs offer a route to connect these savings with operational infrastructure assets. Investors buy units in trusts that own such assets and receive distributions from the income generated, without directly financing or managing the underlying infrastructure.

"India's next infrastructure financing challenge is creating efficient pathways for enormous pool of local savings to reach infrastructure," said Gaurav Chandna, ED and Joint CEO, Vertis Infrastructure Trust.

The model also helps developers monetise completed, revenue-generating assets, freeing up capital for new projects.

Peek into future



Ease of living: A Medellin Metro tram travels along a street in Medellin, Colombia. Medellín ranked 10th globally in Time Out magazine's October 2026 assessment of cities with the best public transport, garnering an 83% approval rating from local residents. AFP

Wabtec bags $94 mn Vande Bharat sleeper train order

M. Soundariya Preetha
COIMBATORE

U.S.-headquartered Wabtec Corporation has secured orders worth $94 million (about ₹839 crore) from Indian Railways to supply critical onboard systems for Vande Bharat sleeper train programme.

Under the contract, Wabtec will supply braking systems, doors and gangway solutions to the Integral Coach Factory (ICF) over the next two financial years. "The Indian rail sector offers huge potential, and India is important for Wabtec," said Pascal Schweitzer, president of Wabtec Transit.

According to a company press release, ICF will manufacture 50 Vande Bharat sleeper trainsets, each comprising 24 coaches. The contract covers system delivery, integration support, testing, commissioning and long-term operational reliability support.

Ajay Mani, MD, Faiveley Transport Rail Technologies, a Wabtec firm, told *The Hindu* Wabtec's transit business in India generated almost ₹3,000 crore revenue in 2025. Revenue is may touch about ₹3,200 crore this year with the firm eyeing ₹5,000 crore/year by 2029-30.

The anticipated growth will be driven by opportunities across multiple segments of the Railways, including Metro Rail, Vande Bharat and Namo Bharat projects. India now accounts for almost 10% of Wabtec's global transit business revenue. The contribution is likely to rise to 13-14% by 2030, he said.

(This writer was at Wabtec's plant in Hosur, T.N. at the firm's invitation)

'IRDAI to implement distribution reforms only after consensus'

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

The regulator will work to expedite claims in the case of health policies, says Mr. Ajay Seth

Amid concerns over the impact of the proposed changes in insurance distribution, IRDAI Chairman Ajay Seth on Tuesday assured the industry that the regulator will implement the reforms only after reaching a consensus.

Speaking at an event here, Mr. Seth said the regulator will work to expedite claims in the case of health policies.

Mr. Seth said he has been meeting people extensively since the release of the discussion paper on distribution reforms to hear out the industry's concerns.

"I'm in the listening mode, hearing what the concerns are...," he said, adding release of the paper has generated a necessary dialogue around the insurance sector's role and the changes that are required.

"I'll attempt to build consensus for the reforms needed for the sector and for economy," he added.

'Adopt prudent borrowing strategies'

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra advised State governments to adopt prudent borrowing strategies and ensure quality spending, highlighting importance of long-term fiscal health.

Addressing the 36th Conference of State Finance Secretaries, the Governor also advised States to make effective use of the State Level Bankers' Committee (SLBC) forum.

Mr. Malhotra highlighted the importance of maintaining the quality of expenditure to ensure the long-term fiscal health of the States.

SEBI indicates more steps to curb speculative retail play in derivatives

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

Capital market regulator SEBI's whole-time member K.V.R. Murty on Tuesday signalled further regulatory measures to curb speculative retail trading in the derivatives segment.

Speaking at an event here, Mr. Murty said retail investors may need to be "chaperoned" to help protect their own interests.

"May be more guardrails are required, may be people need to be a little more chaperoned given the kind of activity we have seen and the hyperactivity which we see on expiry day especially," Mr. Murty, a career bureaucrat who joined the markets regulator recently, said.



In investor interest: The logo of Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) is seen on its headquarters in Mumbai. REUTERS

He said it is "too early" to say whether the "chaperoning" will be done by SEBI or if the regulator will rely on brokers to discipline those investors who continue to take risky bets despite a slew of warnings.

Over the last few years, SEBI started a discussion on the subject by publishing data pointing to 9 of 10 trades by retail investors in the futures and options segment turning sour.

It also initiated a series of steps to dissuade investors from taking risky bets while making clear that the derivatives market is an essential tool in markets.

Greater transparency

Mr. Murty said SEBI's job is to bring greater transparency in the market by putting out the risks of such bets in the public domain and made it clear that it will not stop people from investing in the segment.

On the controversial closing auction session (CAS) system, he said there is no standardised template available and every jurisdiction evolved such a system by tweaking it.

In U.S. swing districts, high prices dominate minds



Top priority: Living costs seem to be most pressing issue for voters ahead of November 3 polls. GETTY IMAGES VIA AFP

Reuters
NEW YORK

American consumers say the rising cost of living is a top concern – one that's changed how they shop. But that won't necessarily affect their votes in next week's Congressional elections.

More than two dozen voters in three East Coast swing districts overwhelmingly reported that high gas and grocery bills were top of mind. Reuters interviewed the voters, who largely self-described as working- or middle-class, during routine shopping trips.

Their concerns mesh with *Reuters/Ipsos* polling finding living costs to be the most pressing issue for voters ahead of November 3 elections that will determine control of the U.S. House of Representatives and Senate.

More than half of the people identified as Democratic-leaning and said they planned to vote against Republican candidates, many with a renewed sense of urgency. But of the ten who said they previously voted for incumbent congressional Republicans, eight told *Reuters* they are sticking by them this year. That is despite inflation being driven up by, among others, tariffs introduced by Republican President Donald Trump and a Iran war-related energy-cost rise.

Bond investors divert focus from the U.S. Fed to AI and broadening deficits

Recent bond-market rally may not have staying power; Fed may keep rates steady, but hike in December; U.S. midterm polls add layer of uncertainty; U.S. yield drivers to remain even with Fed pause; comments from some officials helped reset investor expectation on near-term rate hikes

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
NEW YORK

Wall Street considers it settled that the Federal Reserve will hold interest rates steady this week. Whether that spells good news for Treasuries is more complicated.

After a bruising selloff that took yields up sharply for two months starting in August, the Treasury market has rallied, reflecting concern that financing troubles in a corner of the market for AI infrastructure could slow the artificial intelligence buildout that is a central driver of the U.S. economy. Yields have come down from the highs they hit early in October.

But analysts and portfolio managers stress that many of the forces that have made bond investors miserable this year – stubborn inflation, heavy government and corporate borrowing and uncertainty over next week's midterm elections – remain in place. That makes it difficult to forecast what the rest of 2026 holds for a market where prices are still down significantly for the year.

"I don't think the Fed is entirely in the driver's seat in today's market. Increasingly, the bigger story is the AI-driven investment cycle and what happens to risk sentiment around it," said Christian Hoffmann, head of fixed income at Thornburg Investment Management.

"In recent trading, capital has moved out of some AI-related trades and into bonds in what looks like a flight to quality, and flows like that can overwhelm relatively small changes in Fed expectations."



New elements:: Traders work on the floor of the New York Stock Exchange in New York City, U.S. REUTERS

> Benchmark 10-year yield has risen 84 basis points this year, on track for its largest yearly increase since 2022. U.S. 30-year yields are up nearly 50 basis points in 2026.

Few expect rate rise

Investors expect the Fed to stay on hold but to raise rates again in December. The decision may be less important than what officials signal about inflation and the path of rates in the months ahead, investors said. Markets have repeatedly swung between expectations for policy easing and tightening on concerns that persistent price pressures could force the Fed to keep borrowing costs elevated for longer.

The benchmark 10-year yield has risen 84 basis points this year, on track for its largest yearly increase since 2022. U.S. 30-year yields are up nearly 50 basis points in 2026, their biggest yearly rise since 2024.

Of late, comments from Fed officials John Williams and Philip Jefferson helped to reset investor expectations towards fewer near-term rate hikes. Both sit on the policy-making Federal Open Market Committee. But few have forgotten that consumer and producer prices rose in August and September, with higher energy prices – which remain elevated – as one of the main culprits.

"Inflation has clearly re-accelerated so to us this isn't necessarily a pause, but just to see how some of this data changes given the recent hike," said Jack Herr, senior investment analyst at GuideStone Funds. "The Fed will probably hike again this year."

Even if the Fed stays on hold, the long end of the curve – bonds with maturities of 10 or more years – could remain under pressure. JPMorgan's latest Treasury Client Survey showed client positioning with the fewest outright longs since mid-August,reflecting reduced betting on lower yields.

Widening deficit

That outlook reflects in part the government's growing financing need, with a worsening fiscal backdrop and the $40 trillion national debt contributing to bouts of volatility.

Treasury issuance has surged alongside widening budget deficits, increasing the amount of debt that private investors must absorb. The steady increase in supply has become a key driver of longer-term yields and has at times overshadowed changes in Fed policy expectations.

"It's hard to have a lot of confidence in exactly what's going to happen from here, especially when you're looking at ongoing deficits on the order of 6% of gross domestic product," said Chris Maxey, chief market strategist at Wealthspire Advisors.

"Our net debt interest costs could actually consume more o four deficit, and that begins to squeeze out other spending that happens. That could naturally push yields higher across the curve because there's just that fiscal concern element."

Many investors took the intensity of the late summer bond rout as a shot across the bow of policy makers, but even those who believe the message was received say it will take time to change the momentum on spending in Washington. "Regardless of the election results, we should not probably expect any meaningful fiscal restraint," said Oli Shale, U.S. investment specialist at asset manager Ruffer. "More spending is the path of least resistance and this regime is not going anywhere for some time."

Crypto firms target midterm elections with $176 million splurge as they prepare to secure their political future beyond Trump

INSIGHT

Reuters
NEW YORK

The crypto industry has spent roughly $176 million across more than 100 midterm races this election cycle, as part of a years-long plan to build a bipartisan coalition of allies in Congress that can advance its interests long after U.S. President Donald Trump leaves office.

The $2.75 trillion industry, and the billionaires who built it, are aggressively spending to elect friendly candidates while targeting politicians they see as a threat, according to interviews with more than a half-dozen crypto political strategists and a *Reuters* review of the spending.

While the industry's recent spending blitz is known, its long-term plan to further its legislative agenda is less well-understood. The industry isn't just looking for allies; it is trying to pick candidates who already have a chance of winning and can help once they get to Congress, the strategists said.

Crypto's largest super political action committee, (PACs) Fairshake, which spent $196 million during the 2024 election cycle, is leading the industry's strategy again. Fairshake said 53 of the 58 candidates it supported in primaries or special elections this year won and will be on the ballot on November 3.

Super PACs can accept and spend unlimited sums of money, but cannot coordinate directly with campaigns. They are flooding several races with tens of millions of dollars in ads.

Voters have little way of knowing who pays for these ads, which barely mention crypto. Most of Fairshake's are sponsored by its affiliate PACs with innocuous names like "Defend American Jobs" and "Protect Progress." The ads often focus on hot-button issues like taxes or immigration.

Single biggest spender

Perceived enemies, such as longtime skeptic Sherrod Brown, vying to return to the Senate in Ohio, can be subjected to an onslaught of often-personal attacks. Advocacy group Public Citizen said crypto was the single-biggest corporate spender in federal races in 2026, after saying in 2024 that its spending was "akin to a corporate Death Star hovering over elections."

The PACs' primary financiers, led by Coinbase, Ripple and venture capital firm Andreessen Horowitz, aren't trying to convince voters to support digital currencies. The money is a calling card to help forge long-term relationships with elected officials, said industry strategists, campaign staff, watchdog groups and political finance managers.

It underscores how the industry is behaving as other businesses do in Washington – using funds to open doors and buffer itself against regulation. The strategy reflects the reality that come 2029, the occupant of the White House is unlikely to be as personally invested in crypto as Trump, whose family made around $2.3 billion from crypto ventures between mid-2024 and April, a *Reuters* investigation found.

"It's an investment in the future," said Colin McLaren, head of government relations at crypto industry advocacy group the Solana Policy Institute, which has given $4.9 million to the midterms this year, according to campaign finance records.



Vested interests: Donald Trump at White House Crypto Summit in Washington, D.C., U.S. REUTERS

The effort is designed to "ensure that over the next 100 years, the crypto industry has clear rules of the road, and that we know what our regulators are expecting from us," he said.

Through October 20, Fairshake and its affiliate PACs have spent about $150.8 million on the midterms this year, while other crypto groups have spent around $25 million, according to campaign finance filings.

"We back pro-crypto candidates who support American innovation in both parties, and look forward to continuing to build on the largest pro-crypto caucus in American history,"said Geoff Vetter, spokesperson for Fairshake.

Come a long way

In 2018, lawmakers couldn't even get a room in the House or Senate office buildings to hold the first Congressional bipartisan roundtable discussion on crypto, instead meeting across the street from the U.S. Capitol in the Library of Congress, said Kristin Smith, president of the Solana Policy Institute, who helped establish the Blockchain Association that year.

The Biden administration heavily scrutinised the industry following the collapse of FTX and an industry-wide meltdown in 2022, with the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) eventually levying more than $6 billion in penalties in 98 cases, according to a Georgetown University Law study.

"It was an all-out assault on the technology," said Smith, the Blockchain Association's interim CEO.

"The industry was in a corner, and the only way out was to show political force."

Executives decided they needed a political strategy to combat what they called then-SEC chair Gary Gensler's "regulation by enforcement," lobbyists, advocacy groups and campaign strategists said.

Coinbase Chief Policy Officer Faryar Shirzad was the architect behind non-profit political advocacy group Stand WithCrypto – which isn't required to disclose its donors – and Fairshake, which both launched in 2023. The number of Congress people with an "A" rating from Stand With Crypto is up to 332 compared with 96 when the group launched.

Market value vaults

As the industry has won more legal clarity in Washington, its market value has nearly tripled from around $1 trillion in 2023 to about $2.75 trillion now, according to CoinGecko.

The combination of Trump, a growing bipartisan Congressional coalition and a neutered opposition allowed the industry to advance its legislative agenda more in the last two years than some industries have done in decades, other industry lobbyists say.

That includes 2025's Genius Act legislation establishing the first-ever U.S. federal regulatory framework for stablecoins, enacted with overwhelming bipartisan support. That followed a White House meeting earlier in the year when industry leaders, including Coinbase CEO Brian Armstrong and Ripple CEO Brad Garlinghouse, sat with Trump when the president declared an end to the "war on crypto."

"Moving that quickly in Washington is like light speed in space," said Ron Bonjean, partner at bipartisan public affair sfirm Rokk Solutions, and a former senior Senate aide.

The industry's real goal is passing the Clarity Act, which would put crypto oversight under the Commodity Futures Trading Commission. That bill stalled in this Congressional session and faces an uphill battle next year if Democrats win control of one or more chambers of Congress.

Without it, agency-level regulations undertaken during Trump's term can be reversed by a subsequent administration,analysts at JPMorgan said.

Fairshake is financing House candidates from both parties, but it decided to only back Republicans in Senate races after Democrats in that chamber blocked the Clarity Act from advancing to a final vote. Their opposition centered around an ethics provision that would have forced the Trump family to sell their crypto holdings.

Gary Kalman, of anti-corruption nonprofit Transparency International, criticised the bill for shifting regulation to the less-stringent CFTC, and for preempting states from enacting tougher laws.

Coinbase and Andrees sen Horowitz declined to comment. Ripple didn't return requests for comment.

Prime target

Fairshake's highest-profile win in 2024 was defeating Brown, an industry foe who chaired the Senate Banking Committee from 2021 to 2024.

Spending millions attacking the sitting chairman of the industry's oversight committee was unprecedented in Washington, corporate watchdogs and political strategists say. But the gamble paid off. Now, Brown is running again, with public opinion polls showing him with a narrow lead over his opponent, Republican Jon Husted. The industry has spent more than $68 million on the race, helping to make it one of the most expensive on record, according to AdImpact.

Fairshake's ads opposing Brown, which it did not comment on, don't mention crypto. One charges him with voting to raise gas taxes in Ohio and raises a *Reuters*-debunked claim that he voted to "unleash 87,000 IRS agents on you while voting to give social security benefits to illegals." "Of course, the special interests are panicking, they know Sherrod will fight the rigged system they're feasting on to stand up for working Ohioans," said Patrick Eisenhauer, Brown's campaign manager.

Crypto money bomb

In some races, crypto spending dwarfed candidatefund raising. The industry spent $5.3 million in a Maryland House Democratic primary to support state Delegate Adrian Boafo, who raised $1.9 million on his own, records show. Other non-crypto groups spent $6.8 million to support Boafo's campaign, which declined to comment.

"There were so many ads ... that it makes other candidates suffocate," said Quincy Bareebe, a healthcare entrepreneur who came in second of 24 candidates in that primary despite spending $6.6 million of her own money. "Adrian was everywhere."

The industry was less successful in Illinois. Fairshake spent over $10.1 million on ads attacking Lieutenant Governor Juliana Stratton, who is running for U.S. Senate, and another $2.5 million against Illinois state Representative La Shawn Ford, whois running for a Chicago-area congressional district. Both are expected to win on November 3.

Ford defeated a dozen primary challengers despite raising just $5,00,000 and lending his campaign $1,75,000 to fight offindustry-funded ads that brought up a 14-year-old federal indictment that was later dropped. His campaign issued a cease-and-desist letter to Fairshake, accusing it of making defamatory statements about him in its ads.

Fairshake did not comment on its ads or Ford's response. Ford thinks Fairshake targeted him because he supported state legislation to require crypto exchanges and related companies to register with Illinois.

"They were relentless, on every outlet, radio, TV, social media, mailers," Ford said. "It was personal and it was hurtful,and unnecessary for my family to have to go through."

NAIROBI

‘Attacks kill at least 60 Orthodox Christians in Ethiopia in a week’



AP

At least 60 people were killed in two attacks in Ethiopia’s conflict-hit Oromiya region in the past week, the Ethiopian Orthodox Church said. Church authorities said the dead were all Christians. The regional government blamed the Oromo Liberation Army group fighting government forces in Tigray region for the attacks. REUTERS

MOSCOW

Iran President tells Putin West Asia can solve problems without the U.S.



REUTERS

Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian told his Russian counterpart Vladimir Putin on Tuesday that West Asia can solve its problems without the involvement of the U.S. “I believe we are capable of resolving our problems in the region without relying on the U.S.,” Mr. Pezeshkian said on the sidelines of a gas exporters’ summit. AFP

RIYADH

Yemen’s Houthis claim attack on Saudi refinery, blasts shake Riyadh



REUTERS

Yemen’s Houthis said they targeted Saudi Arabia’s biggest oil refinery in Ras Tanura with a ballistic missile on Tuesday, as blasts shook the capital, Riyadh. The Saudi-led coalition fighting the Iran-aligned group said it had intercepted three missiles towards the Eastern Province and two ballistic missiles fired at Riyadh. AFP

CARACAS

Venezuelan leader slams Machado over dramatic return from exile



AFP

Venezuelan interim President Delcy Rodriguez on Monday derided the dramatic return from exile of Maria Corina Machado, signalling immediate tensions. The Nobel peace laureate arrived back in the country on Sunday after nearly a year, drawing jubilant crowds in a direct challenge to Ms. Rodriguez’s U.S.-backed government. AFP

Jordan says it killed 20 ‘jihadists’ in air strikes; Syria slams attacks

Aerial raid carried out in retaliation for a gun attack that killed nine people at an Orthodox church in Jordan last week; Damascus denies claim of a coordinated operation, says seven civilians killed in Jordan’s ‘violation of Syrian airspace’

Agence France-Presse
DAMASCUS



Dire straits: Mourners attend the funeral of four of the same family killed in a Jordanian strike in Syria's Al-Mismiyah. REUTERS

Syria on Tuesday condemned deadly air strikes on the country’s south a day earlier that Jordan said killed more than 20 ‘jihadists’ as retaliation for a gun attack on a church.

The Monday night strikes came after gunmen last week killed nine people and wounded 25 others during a funeral service at a Greek Orthodox church in the village of Hammoud in southern Jordan’s Karak governorate, an attack that sparked shock across the country.

While Jordan has insisted it coordinated its air strikes with Syria, Damascus has denied the claim and said the strike killed seven people including three children.

Jordan said it had “great respect” for Syria and expressed regret for civilian casualties. Jordan’s government spokesman Mohammad al-Momani said the strikes “killed more than 20 fighters of Daesh, referring to the an Arabic acronym for the Islamic State jihadist group”. He also said “a large weapons depot belonging to the organisation” had been destroyed.

‘Blatant violation’

Syria’s Foreign Ministry issued a “condemnation and rejection” of the strikes, calling them “an unacceptable violation and breach of Syrian airspace without any prior coordination”.

Syria said five people including a woman and three children were killed in the village of Al-Taf in Daraa province, which borders Jordan, with two other people killed elsewhere in the south.

“We were asleep when the missile hit us. My mother, my older brother and his three children – two boys and a girl – were killed,” said Nassouh al-Salim in Al-Taf.

After the strikes, Syria closed its main Nassib border crossing with Jordan, known as Jaber on the Jordanian side, suspending all passenger and commercial traffic in both directions.

On Monday, Amman said authorities had arrested three Jordanians accused of the church killings, two of them brothers and the other related by marriage.

IS was territorially defeated in Syria in 2019, after it seized swathes of territory during the country’s more than 13-year civil war.

Two charged for assisting Iran over U.K. airbase plot

Sriram Lakshman
LONDON



Launch pad: A U.S. B-1 bomber on the tarmac at the RAF Fairford base. Washington had used the facility to launch strikes on Iran. AFP

Two British nationals have been charged under the United Kingdom’s National Security Act in connection with an incident last month at Royal Air Force (RAF) Fairford, a military airbase used by the United States.

Nouman Essghir, 24, and Mohmed Ahmad Abdulkarim, 24, from London, were charged and scheduled to appear in court this week.

Mr. Abdulkarim was arrested for allegedly assisting a foreign intelligence service.

The country was believed to be Iran, according to Laurence Taylor, the Head of the U.K.’s National Counterterrorism Policing unit.

Tehran has denied involvement with the incident.

Five men were arrested as they approached the airbase in three vans on September 27. This resulted in the evacuation of residents in the airbase area in Gloucestershire.

The suspects were subsequently released on police bail, which led to criticism from U.S. President Donald Trump.

An Iranian-British dual national was later arrested and released on police bail in early October.

Following the incident, Washington had removed its 12 B-1 bombers, used in its strikes on Iran, from the airbase.

China is waging cognitive warfare: Taiwan Minister

Reuters
TAIPEI

Remarks came after China put out poster to mark anniversary of Japan’s 1945 handover of Taiwan

Taiwan’s Defence Minister on Tuesday said China was waging “cognitive warfare” after Beijing marked the anniversary of Japan’s handover of the island to Chinese rule with satellite images of Taipei and a military propaganda poster.

Japan took over Taiwan from China’s Qing Dynasty in 1895 and ruled it until 1945, when it transferred the island to the Republic of China government. Both Beijing and Taipei commemorate the event, now in its 81st year.

On Sunday’s anniversary of the handover, China released high-resolution satellite pictures of Taipei, including the train station and the National Palace Museum. The museum holds a vast collection of treasures brought to Taiwan in 1949, when the Republic of China government fled there after losing a civil war to the communists.

The Chinese military’s Eastern Theatre Command also published a poster with a map of Taiwan superimposed on images of fighter jets and warships, with the title “Remember the history of the restoration”.

Speaking to reporters at parliament in Taipei, Taiwan Defence Minister Wellington Koo said China was using the anniversary to carry out “cognitive warfare”.

“We must stress that the People’s Republic of China was established in 1949. The War of Resistance has absolutely nothing to do with the People’s Republic of China – this is a clear, objective fact,” he added, referring to World War Two and the Japanese invasion of China which began in 1931.

Call for vigilance

Taiwan’s military marked a different anniversary, the start of an unsuccessful late-October 1949 attempt by the People’s Liberation Army to invade Kinmen, the islands that sit next to the Chinese coast and remain under Taiwan control to this day.

“This reminds us once again that China’s determination to annex Taiwan by force has never changed. We should be even more vigilant,” he added.

Fiery horizon



Village on fire: A resident sprays water to contain the fire that broke out in the shanty village of Guryong on the outskirts of Gangnam district in Seoul on Tuesday. Over 100 residents have been evacuated from the area. AFP

Over 10,000 cases of Ebola recorded in Africa

Agence France-Presse
KINSHASA

Africa’s latest outbreak of Ebola has passed 10,000 confirmed cases, the vast majority of them in the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC), the Congolese health authorities said on Tuesday, with almost 5,000 fatalities.

According to the DRC’s figures, 10,060 people have been infected and 4,887 have died since the virus was first detected in May.

Cases have been detected in Kenya, Nigeria and Uganda.

Among the many challenges facing the response is the lack of any approved vaccines or treatments for the rare Bundibugyo species of Ebola behind the epidemic.

Serbia’s students seek resignation of media chiefs after poll win

Agence France-Presse
BELGRADE

Serbia’s student movement on Tuesday demanded the bosses of the national broadcaster resign over alleged bias during the 14-year rule of Aleksandar Vucic’s right-wing nationalist party, which was defeated in weekend elections.

Sunday’s historic victory by the student-backed list came after two years of protests sparked by the 2024 collapse of a railway station canopy in Novi Sad that killed 16 people. Widely blamed on corruption, the disaster triggered some of Serbia’s largest protests since the fall of strongman Slobodan Milosevic in 2000. But throughout the protests, students regularly accused the publicly funded Radio Television of Serbia (RTS) of deliberately ignoring and denigrating demonstrators.

“We demand the resignations of the RTS director general, his deputy, the editors-in-chief responsible for news coverage and all news editors,” the students said in a letter on Tuesday.

Flavio Bolsonaro’s passports cancelled; whereabouts unclear after poll defeat

Agence France-Presse
BRASILIA



Flavio Bolsonaro

Brazil’s Flavio Bolsonaro, politically isolated after refusing to accept election defeat, had his passports cancelled on Tuesday as speculation swirled over his whereabouts.

Mr. Bolsonaro, 45, was defeated by incumbent Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva, 81, on Sunday and is set to lose his parliamentary immunity as his legal woes pile up.

Mr. Bolsonaro last spoke publicly on Monday afternoon in a video on social media saying he had been banned from leaving the country and ordered to surrender his passports.

However, while he said he would comply with the order, he had failed to do so by Tuesday afternoon.

“Flavio Bolsonaro’s passports have been cancelled,” a police source said, adding that “there is no formal record of him leaving the country.”

Argentina’s Security Ministry denied media reports that Mr. Bolsonaro had entered the country.

“I never had any intention of leaving the country. I will surrender my passports and defend myself against this travesty,” Mr. Bolsonaro said.

‘Headed to U.S.’

Citing two sources, Reuters reported that the Brazilian Senator had left the country for the United States. A spokesperson for Mr. Bolsonaro did not respond to a request for comment.

Mr. Bolsonaro’s brother, Eduardo Bolsonaro, who lives in Texas, U.S., had publicly encouraged him to leave Brazil if he lost the election.

Flavio Bolsonaro is under legal scrutiny in several cases, including a corruption probe over the financing of the biopic “Dark Horse” about his father, former President Jair Bolsonaro, who is under house arrest for plotting a coup.

(With inputs from Reuters)

Truce brokered by Melania Trump takes effect in Ukraine city

Agence France-Presse
KYIV

A local truce between Ukraine and Russia aimed at allowing humanitarian aid into the Russian-occupied city of Oleshky appears to be holding, hours after Russia fired missiles on a university campus in Kyiv.

Both sides said the ceasefire brokered by U.S. First Lady Melania Trump had begun at 3:00 a.m. local time.

The war-ravaged city in Ukraine’s Kherson region has been caught in middle of the fighting since 2022. Former residents said that those remaining in the city were starving, lacked medicine and could not easily leave.

Russia continued to pummel the rest of Ukraine with air barrages. Missiles struck a university campus in Kyiv on Monday wounding 12 people, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said. In Russia, two people were killed “as a result of explosive devices being dropped” on the city of Bryansk, local authorities said.



Kobayashi, left, says adoption of former royals, who are commoners, discriminates against other commoners. AP

Cartoonist contests Japan's 'male heir only' imperial law

Associated Press
TOKYO

A popular Japanese cartoonist who has written books on history and monarchy has sued the government over a revised imperial succession law allowing royals to adopt male relatives from former branch families to father future heirs.

The revised law took effect on Saturday despite criticism over the male-only succession rules in Japan's 1,500-year-old monarchy. Next in line after Emperor Naruhito is his younger brother Akishino, followed by the emperor's 20-year-old nephew, Prince Hisahito. There are no other eligible heirs in his generation.

The revised law allows adoption of unmarried male descendants, aged 15 or older, of distant imperial relatives, but only through an unbroken male line, into a branch of the royal family. They would not be able to inherit the throne themselves, but their heirs would be eligible.

Four of the 11 former branch families who renounced their royal status in 1947 remain. Officials say they are at least 36 generations removed from Naruhito after splitting from a common male-line ancestor 600 years ago.

In his lawsuit, Yoshinori Kobayashi says the adoption of former royals, who are commoners, discriminates against other commoners in violation of Article 14 of the constitution, which guarantees equality regardless of "race, creed, sex, social status or family origin."

The law lets princesses retain their royal status and continue with their official duties after marrying commoners, but does not confer royal status on their husbands and children. It effectively eliminates a chance for Japan's beloved Princess Aiko to succeed her father Naruhito.

Lula's win gives Brazil chance to cement climate leadership, but issues remain

In his fourth term, the President can potentially negotiate across the divides that currently frustrate climate agreements, given his country's status as Latin America's largest economy, host to most of the Amazon, and its diplomatic relationships with the EU, the U.S., China, and the BRICS countries

NEWS ANALYSIS

Vasudevan Mukunth

Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva winning his fourth term as Brazil's President has also interrupted a series of right-wing electoral wins in Latin America. That said, Brazil and Mexico are now the sole left-wing governments among the region's largest economies. And while it would be reductive to believe the left is more welcoming of climate action and the right is more disdainful, Lula also faces significant challenges in his role on the issue both in Brazil and beyond.

His foremost opportunity will be to have Brazil cement its mantle of leadership. Brazil is somewhat unique: it is Latin America's largest economy, the world's fifth-largest by area, host to most of the Amazon, and, crucially, has diplomatic relationships with the European Union, the U.S., China, the BRICS countries, and many other developing economies – potentially allowing Lula to negotiate across the divides that currently frustrate climate agreements.

In fact, China has made tariffs on clean energy technologies a priority for the COP31 summit, set to commence in under a fortnight in Türkiye, with Beijing arguing against protectionist trade measures while the EU and the U.S. have raised concerns about dependence on Chinese manufacturers.

On the regional level, Brazil straddles several problems, including deforestation in the Amazon, illegal mining, forest fires, and a degrading river basin, that demand region-wide cooperation, including the representation of Indigenous groups. Lula revived such cooperation to a commendable degree through the Amazon Cooperation Treaty Organisation (ACTO), by hosting the Belém summit in 2023, and by making further commitments at the Bogotá summit in 2025.



Forging ties: Brazilian President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva (2nd from right) with other world leaders at the Leaders Summit ahead of the COP30 UN climate conference in Belem in November 2025. AFP

ACTO's significance

However, the optimism Lula warrants is tempered by the Belém Declaration in 2023 failing to establish a binding collective deadline to end deforestation in the Amazon rainforest and to prohibit the development of new oil projects in the region. Both the dependence of the Amazonian countries on agriculture, petroleum, and mining and the powers and the resources available to their regulators are markedly different, and political changes are not conducive to sustaining regional cooperation.

Lula's fourth term could thus keep ACTO going, especially on cross-border enforcement and in preserving a forum for governments to negotiate on conflicting political priorities. But given the divergent economic incentives and weak national institutions, lasting change means ACTO also developing common monitoring and financing arrangements.

On a more global level, Brazil has come to play a major role in climate negotiations because of its simultaneous status as a major oil producer and, especially under Lula, a strong advocate of international climate cooperation.

In fact, the day after Lula's election win, the Netherlands announced that it intends to contribute up to $500 million over a decade, on certain conditions, to Brazil's 'Tropical Forest Forever Facility' (TFFF). The pledge brings the sum of commitments announced thus far to $7.8 billion, against the target of $10 billion by the end of 2026. Lula's continuing government will help establish the TFFF in its formative years and steady its hand as a potentially new international financial institution.

In the same spirit, Colombia and the Netherlands convened the first international conference dedicated to transitioning away from fossil fuels in April. Fifty-seven countries, including Brazil, participated to develop proposals for financial cooperation, among other matters, and planned for a second meeting in 2027.

As well, at the COP30 climate talks that Brazil presided over last year, Lula supported proposals to develop an international roadmap to transition away from fossil fuels, drawing support from more than 80 countries, but which the summit could not see through due to opposition from Russia and Saudi Arabia, among others. The April conference has thus emerged as a parallel mechanism to effect action.

EU-Mercosur trade ties

Yet another avenue in the same vein is the EU-Mercosur relationship. The EU and the South American trade bloc signed their interim trade and partnership agreements in January. The latter's ratification will be significant because they require governments to comply with the Paris Agreement – and could allow Lula's climate diplomacy to work through UN negotiations as well as trade and investment relationships to create longer-lasting economic commitments. On the flip side, it may also create greater incentives to convert forestland for other use, so Lula and his peers will have to institute more effective protections.

All this said, while preserving cooperation is essential to effective climate action, it will amount to little if it does not also cut emissions. In fact, continuity in international climate diplomacy could prevent regression without also yielding the acceleration required to meet climate goals. The UN Environment Programme has already found that even if all countries deliver on their pledges vis-à-vis the Paris Agreement, the world is on course to warming by 2.6°C by the end of the century.

Brazil's incoming conservative Congress is also likely to constrain the Lula government's ability to sustain expenditure – even if his term provides continuity through 2030, an important year that numerous climate-related commitments use as a deadline or milestone year. That Lula's win is a record also raises the prospect of policy whiplash, especially against programmes that depend on his personal political authority, when his last term ends.

Ceasefire has not stopped Israel's genocide in Gaza, says experts panel

Associated Press
JERUSALEM

A ceasefire agreement in Gaza has not stopped what a group of independent experts commissioned by the U.N. say is genocide carried out by Israel in the territory, the team said in a new report on Monday. They also accused Israeli forces of crimes against humanity, including torture and rape, in the West Bank.

In response, Israel's mission in Geneva called for the commission's dissolution and said on X the report marked an example of the body's "misinformation campaign to demonize the state of Israel and portray its very existence as criminal".



Rubble in Gaza. AP

The Associated Press could not independently corroborate multiple graphic accounts described in the report of sexual assaults by prison guards and soldiers on Palestinian detainees since October 2023. In one, female guards strip-searched a pregnant Palestinian, touching inside her anus and vagina. In another, guards beat a detainee and hurled sexist slurs while denying her access to the toilet and sanitary pads. She bled onto her clothes and interrogation chair.

The findings by the Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory, which seeks to document in minute detail the allegations and evidence of crimes to bolster accountability for perpetrators, could be used by prosecutors at the International Criminal Court or in other jurisdictions to try to bring justice to victims and their relatives.

The report on Monday said Israel was "continuing to commit genocidal acts with the genocidal intent to destroy, in whole or in part, the Palestinians in Gaza."

Much of the harm has come from Israel's expansion deeper into Gaza during the ceasefire period, the report says. Since October 2025, when the ceasefire was signed, Israeli forces have gone from controlling 53% of Gaza to at least 60%, the commission said.

In that time, Israeli fire across the advancing front has killed at least 196 Palestinians – including 18 women, 32 boys and 11 girls, the commission said.

Delicious mantis



Earthy flavour: Samuel Fremaux, from France, competes with his chocolate creation depicting a praying mantis during the World Chocolate Masters event in Antwerp, Belgium, on Monday. AP

How Trump's 'little detour' to Iran became a roadblock in midterm elections

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

Noor Dubow says he regularly votes for Republican candidates who he believes align with his economic views – even though he has never been a fan of Donald Trump, finding himself repelled by some of the President's dehumanising rhetoric toward immigrants.

But this year, when Mr. Dubow cast his early ballot in the midterm election, he found himself tipping more toward Democrats because of his frustration with Mr. Trump's decision to go to war with Iran.

"Where are the Republicans in Congress?" asked Mr. Dubow, 44, a dispatcher at a trucking logistics firm in Columbus, Ohio, where he has a bird's eye view of the disruption that surging fuel prices are having on the economy. "Why aren't the Republicans holding Trump accountable?"

The Iran war, which Mr. Trump often describes as a "little detour", has emerged as an unforced liability for the President, who once promised to keep the U.S. out of foreign wars. Republican strategists privately acknowledge that the war is severely damaging the party's push to retain control of Congress for the final two years of Mr. Trump's presidency as rising petrol prices drive up costs across nearly every sector and new hostilities emerge.

High energy costs and voter fatigue over the nearly eight-month-old war – one that Mr. Trump predicted at the onset would last a matter of weeks – are weighing heavily on Republican candidates.

Regardless of the outcome of the November 3 elections, an AP-NORC poll published last week found that voters from both major political parties want the next Congress to focus on making life more affordable and end the war in Iran that has had enormous ramifications for the global economy.

High diesel prices

Diesel prices continue to hover near all-time highs in the U.S., creating trouble for Republicans in typically conservative states such as Iowa, Kansas, Ohio and Texas who find themselves knotted in competitive races with Democrats.

Yet, Mr. Trump has consistently downplayed the conflict's economic impact as he rallies his supporters to try to keep the GOP's grip on both chambers of Congress.



Against the wind: U.S. President Donald Trump raises his fist during a campaign rally in Corinth, Mississippi, on Monday. AP

Mr. Trump repeatedly insists that the war's end is near, only to threaten that a new, intensive round of bombing could very well be in the offing once the election passes – often within the same campaign speech or a single exchange with reporters.

He also argues that elevated gas prices are a temporary inconvenience worth paying to defang Iran. Mr. Trump at a weekend rally in Michigan said that he has no regrets about launching the war and even argued that its economic impact has been less severe than he had expected.

"Somebody said, 'If you had it to do again...'" Mr. Trump told the friendly audience. "I said, 'Are you kidding?' I thought gas would be double or triple. And it's a small price to pay for taking a nuclear weapon away from maniacs."

The President's mixed message on Iran has left Republican candidates in a difficult, if not untenable, position, said Christopher Borick, director of the Lehigh University Opinion Observatory.

"Trump's messaging on the war is resonating with a shrinking portion of the electorate," Mr. Borick said. "For voters disappointed with the direction of the conflict, there's little by way of the President's claims that would change their negative outlook."

Only a few elected Republicans have parted ways with Mr. Trump over the Iran conflict. Mr. Trump, for his part, has insisted that the midterm elections would have no bearing on how he approached the conflict.

Warning signs

But some party strategists have been sounding the alarm for months.

Early in the summer, five Republican strategists involved in key races or advising campaign leadership told The Associated Press that they had begun seeing warning signs that the war could hurt their candidates if the conflict did not wind down soon.

In June, after Mr. Trump forged an interim ceasefire agreement with Tehran, Mr. Trump and White House officials appeared more confident. But the deal unraveled within weeks.

At that point, campaign officials in some battleground races became more forceful during internal conversations that House districts Mr. Trump won easily in 2024 looked like they were becoming competitive, said the Republican strategists, who were not authorised to comment publicly on the internal party data and spoke on the condition of anonymity.

Oil prices peaked in May, fell in June and surged again in September as Mr. Trump threatened to escalate the conflict before backing off and suggesting a deal could be around the corner. The national average has hovered above $4 per gallon since the middle of June.

RACING AWAY

Abhishek overtakes Kohli for the most T20 centuries by an Indian



CREIMAS/BCCI

Abhishek Sharma overtook Virat Kohli to become the Indian batter with the most T20 centuries. His 38-ball 113 against the Kiwis on Tuesday was his 11th. Only Chris Gayle (22) and Babar Azam (13) are above him. Abhishek also tied with Suryakumar Yadav for the second-most T20I tons for India (four) behind Rohit Sharma (five).

GOING HAMMER AND TONGS

India shatters record for most runs scored in PowerPlay of a T20I



AP

India broke the record for the most runs scored in the PowerPlay of a T20I against New Zealand in Wellington on Tuesday. The opening combination of Abhishek Sharma and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi plundered 118 off the first six overs. India bettered Romania's 116 for no loss in 5.4 overs against Serbia in a 10-wicket win in 2021.

SENSATIONAL PERFORMANCE

Skipper Shreyas heaps praise on Abhishek and Sooryavanshi



AFP

Absolutely stunning. Even when I went out to bat it was seaming, Sanju (Samson) and me were like, how did they manage to score so much! The way they played was exceptional. It was amazing the way the lads rose to the occasion, mind boggling — India captain Shreyas Iyer praising Abhishek Sharma and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi.

DIFFICULT TASK

Pretty tough to defend against India, admits Kiwi captain Santner



AFP

New Zealand captain Matt Santner acknowledged the difficulty of containing India's aggressive batting. "We've seen it in the IPL and obviously we are seeing it here in New Zealand. To get 200 on a wicket like that was nice. They showed how to bat. Guys who have gone in have kicked on, it's tough to defend against these guys".

Abhishek annihilates Kiwis as India wraps up series

The southpaw smashes a 38-ball 113 and amasses 133 for the opening wicket off just 7.1 overs with Sooryavanshi; Mitchell's efforts go in vain; pacer Arshdeep pick of the bowlers for the Men in Blue



Carnage: Abhishek flayed the Kiwi bowlers to all parts of the ground. CREIMAS/BCCI

INDIA IN NZ

Agence France-Presse
WELLINGTON

An aggressive partnership by Abhishek Sharma and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi propelled India to a six-wicket win and a series victory over New Zealand in the third T20I here on Tuesday.

India sewed up the five-match series with two games to spare, chasing down New Zealand's total of 198 in just 13.2 overs, Abhishek blasting 113 and Sooryavanshi 45.

The opening pair combined for a 133-run partnership off just 7.1 overs, obliterating the New Zealand bowling attack with one of the most destructive partnerships in T20I history.

The first Jacob Duffy over went for 26 runs, and the openers never let up.

Abhishek hit nine fours and 11 sixes in his 38-ball knock, receiving a standing ovation when he eventually fell to Kyle Jamieson.

By that stage, India had reached 178 for two after just 10 overs.

SCOREBOARD

NEW ZEALAND
Tim Seifert c Axar b Arshdeep 2 *(6b)*, Finn Allen c Dhir b Nitish 40 *(25b, 5x6)*, Daryl Mitchell (not out) 89 *(52b, 5x4, 5x6)*, Glenn Phillips c & b Axar 17 *(14b, 3x4)*, Bevon Jacobs (not out) 39 *(23b, 4x4, 1x6)*; Extras (lb-7, w-4): 11; Total (for three wkts. in 20 overs): 198.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-4 (Seifert, 1.2 overs), 2-90 (Allen, 8.3), 3-123 (Phillips, 11.6).

INDIA BOWLING
Bhuvneshwar 4-0-40-0, Arshdeep 4-0-33-1, Prince 4-0-44-0, Axar 4-0-36-1, Nitish 4-0-38-1.

INDIA
Vaibhav Sooryavanshi c Mitchell b Fisher 45 *(19b, 4x4, 4x6)*, Abhishek Sharma c Phillips b Jamieson 113 *(38b, 9x4, 11x6)*, Sanju Samson b Jamieson 18 *(13b, 2x4)*, Shreyas Iyer c Phillips b Santner 5 *(10b)*, Tilak Varma (not out) 1 *(1b)*, Naman Dhir (not out) 4 *(1b, 1x4)*; Extras (lb-1, nb-2, w-10): 13; Total (for four wkts. in 13.2 overs): 199.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-133 (Sooryavanshi, 7.1), 2-178 (Abhishek, 9.6), 3-193 (Shreyas, 12.4), 4-195 (Samson, 13.1).

NEW ZEALAND BOWLING
Duffy 2-0-44-0, Milne 2-0-33-0, Bracewell 2-0-36-0, Jamieson 3.2-0-45-2, Fisher 1-0-23-1, Santner 3-0-17-1.

Toss: India; **PoM:** Abhishek.
India won by six wickets with 40 balls to spare and took an unassailable 3-0 lead in the five-match series.
Fourth T20I: October 30, Auckland, 12.30 p.m. IST.

Sooryavanshi was promoted to open alongside Abhishek after batting at No.3 in the second T20, hitting four fours and as many sixes in his 19-ball innings.

India won the toss for the third time in three matches and again elected to bowl. Bhuvneshwar Kumar and Arshdeep Singh extracted prodigious seam from the pitch, beating the outside edge of New Zealand openers Tim Seifert and Finn Allen. Seifert top-edged Arshdeep for two, before Daryl Mitchell joined Allen and combined for an 86-run partnership.

Mitchell was quick to assess the conditions and moved around the crease in order to counteract the seam movement. He seized on shorter bowling with powerful strikes to the short square boundaries, hitting five fours and the same number of sixes in his 89 from 52 balls.

The fourth T20I is at Auckland on Friday.

Stat Attack



1 India has recorded the fastest team 100 in T20Is (5 overs)

4 Abhishek Sharma pulls level with Suryakumar Yadav and Phil Salt for most centuries in men's T20Is. Only Glenn Maxwell and Rohit Sharma (5 each) have scored more

8 The number of times Abhishek has smashed his first ball for a six in T20Is, a record

11 Abhishek is third in the century list in T20s. Only Chris Gayle (22) and Babar Azam (13) are ahead

11 Abhishek has hit 11 sixes in a T20I innings for the second time, the previous one coming against Afghanistan (New Delhi, 2026)

18.13 Abhishek and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's run rate in a 100-plus opening stand is the best in T20Is

40 India has bettered its own record of most balls remaining in a successful chase of 190 or more (28 vs. New Zealand, Raipur, 2026)

149 Arshdeep Singh has the third-most wickets among seamers in T20Is after Tim Southee (164) and Mustafizur Rahman (163)

Compiled by **ANIRUDH VELAMURI**

Not easy to emulate Yuvraj's feat: Abhishek

Press Trust of India
WELLINGTON

Abhishek Sharma may have idolised Yuvraj Singh growing up but the India opener is not ready to take up his mentor's challenge of smashing a half-century off 12 balls, saying such feats are "not that easy" despite his sensational century against New Zealand in the third T20 here on Tuesday.

Responding to Yuvraj's playful social media message that he still could not score a fifty off 12 balls, Abhishek said batters do not chase such milestones.

"I don't know what cricket he was playing back at that time, but it's not that easy at all," Abhishek said in the presentation ceremony. Yuvraj holds the record for the fastest T20I fifty among Full Member nations which he achieved against England in 2007.

Starc leads Australian fightback

Agence France-Presse
CAPE TOWN

Mitchell Starc took four wickets in six balls to cap an Australian fightback on the first day of the third Test against South Africa at Newlands on Tuesday.

Starc finished with six for 72 as South Africa was bowled out for 329 shortly before the close.

The scores: South Africa 329 in 82.3 overs (Markram 78, Ackerman 95, Bedingham 50, Rickelton 42, Jansen 52, Starc 6/72) vs. Australia.
Toss: Australia.

Bad light denies India-A a victory

Press Trust of India
LINCOLN

Pacer Auqib Nabi bowled an incisive opening spell but bad light prevented India-A from recording a sensational come-from-behindwin over New Zealand-A in the first 'Test', which ended n a draw on Tuesday.

The scores:
India-A 113 & 516 in 123.1 overs (Padikkal 199, Sai Sudharsan 91, Rathod 66, Washington 52) drew with NZ-A 317 and 187/9 in 65 overs (Heaphy 90 n.o., Foxcroft 42).

All-rounder Sneh among biggest names in the fray





Stars: Sneh and Harris are likely to generate fair bit of interest. FILE PHOTOS: K.R. DEEPAK & EMMANUAL YOGINI

WPL AUCTION

P.K. Ajith Kumar
KOCHI

By the time the first name comes up at the WPL's mini-auction on Wednesday, the third ODI between India and Zimbabwe would have reached somewhere around the halfway mark in Vadodara. India's middle-order batter Tejal Hasabnis is likely to be curious about what is happening at Grand Hyatt here.

She is one of the 146 players who will go under the hammer. In the only chance she got in the Zimbabwe series, she may have lasted only five balls, but last month she had done really well for India-A against the touring Australia-A. So Tejal should interest some of the franchises. There could be even more interest in Sneh Rana, the off-spinning all-rounder released by Delhi Capitals.

Sneh is, in fact, among the biggest names at this auction. Others include Australia's T20 World Cup-winning captain Sophie Molineux, her compatriots Grace Harris and Jess Jonassen, Sri Lanka captain Chamari Athapaththu and England opener Sophia Dunkley.

Among the capped Indian players are G. Kamalini, Kiran Navgire, Uma Chetry, Taniya Bhatiya, Saika Ishaque, Asha Sobhana, Priya Mishra, Titas Sadhu and Saima Thakor.

There are some interesting names among the uncapped Indians, too. Like the 16-year-old Ira Jadhav, who last year smashed an unbeaten 346 off 157 balls for Mumbai against Meghalaya in the Women's Under-19 One-Day tournament. There are only 27 available slots – including 20 reserved for the Indians.

Biggest purse

Going into the auction, UP Warriorz could well be a bit more excited, and anxious, than the other four franchises. Warriorz have the biggest purse of ₹3.75 crore.

That is a lot more than Gujarat Giants (1.25 crore), Royal Challengers Bengaluru (1.15 crore), Delhi Capitals (1.1 crore) or Mumbai Indians (90 lakh).

It would be fascinating to see how Warriorz try to turn the auction into a mega opportunity.

India slams 13 past hapless Bangladesh

ACT HOCKEY

Uthra Ganesan
JALANDHAR

For a city hosting its first-ever international hockey tournament, the result of India's opening match in the Asian Champions Trophy (ACT) against Bangladesh was the perfect initiation. But less so for coach Craig Fulton and the team's long-term plans.

With local boys among the scorers and India stamping its authority in the 13-0 win on Tuesday, the result ensured the full house had enough reasons to celebrate. Mandeep Singh – among the five players who began on this very ground of the Olympian Surjit Singh Stadium – struck three of those and created as many.

Captain Harmanpreet Singh, another local hero, started the rampage in the second minute and India was up by four in the first 15 minutes and six at half-time. Jarmanpreet Singh and Amit Rohidas, in defence, and Nilakanta Sharma, in the middle, were also impressive. Nilakanta even scored against an opponent that barely challenged the Indian might.

Nilakanta, later, announced that he will retire at the end of the tournament.

The highlight of the day was the drone show featuring the state, its culture, sporting history and legacy and sparkling under the night sky.

The results:
India 13 (Harmanpreet Singh 2-pc, 44-pc, Mandeep Singh 3, 10, 54, Shilanand Lakra 15, Abhishek 18, Nilakanta Sharma 26, Dilpreet Singh 43-pc, 44, Jugraj Singh 46-pc, Hardik Singh 60, 60) bt Bangladesh 0.
Malaysia 5 (Abu Kamal Azrai 4, 14, Akhimullah Anuar 14, Faizal Saari 34-ps, Azimuddin Kamaruddin 35-pc) bt China 4 (Yaqi Wang 11, Moda Ne 12, Benhai Chen 27-pc, 44-pc).
Japan 3 (Kentaro Fukuda 14, Ryoma Ooka 36, Kazumasa Matsumoto 52) bt Korea 2 (Han Sangjun 15, Jeong Junseong 59).



Goals galore: India sounded the boards at will. X@THEHOCKEYINDIA



Take that! Talvinder lines up to fire in IOCL's first goal. R. RAGU

Last-gasp strike keeps IOCL in semifinal race

S. Prasanna Venkatesan
CHENNAI

Indian Oil Corporation Ltd (IOCL) snatched a dramatic 2-2 draw against Hockey Karnataka in a Pool-A match of the 97th all-India MCC-Murugappa Gold Cup hockey tournament at the SDAT Mayor Radhakrishnan Stadium here on Tuesday, scoring off a last-gasp penalty corner to keep its semifinal hopes alive.

Karnataka, which needed a win in its final league match to stay in contention, was left to rue the late equaliser as it bowed out.

Talvinder Singh opened the scoring for IOCL in the ninth minute, converting a rebound after Gurjinder Singh's drag-flick from a penalty corner was blocked by the goalkeeper.

Karnataka fought back through B. Abharan Sudev, who finished a superb move in the 28th minute, before C.J. Rahul put it ahead in the 32nd.

IOCL struggled to make its penalty corners count and missed a one-on-one chance through Affan Yousuf in the 55th minute.

It failed to convert a penalty corner at the very end.

After a review, another penalty corner was awarded, and Roshan Minz found the net to earn his team a crucial point.

The result:
Pool-A: IOCL 2 (Talvinder Singh 9-pc, Roshan Minz 60-pc) drew with Hockey Karnataka 2 (B. Abharan Sudev 28, C.J. Rahul 32).

Salil takes Punjab to 431; Hyderabad solid in reply

The wicketkeeper-batter smashes his third successive ton and puts on 116 for the last wicket with Umesh after Milind reduces the visitor to 315 for nine; Abhirath and Rahul lead the host's response

RANJI TROPHY

Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

Hyderabad held what looked like a winning hand: a bouncer that did its work, a sharp catch at slip and nine Punjab wickets in the bag. Salil Arora then held his nerve and Umesh Yadav offered a straight bat.

By the time the cards were turned, Salil recorded his highest First Class score (151, 268b, 11x4, 4x6) and Punjab finished on 431 in a Ranji Trophy clash at the Gymkhana Ground on Tuesday.

Hyderabad, anchored by Abhirath Reddy and Raul Radesh's 259-ball 154-run stand, ended the day on 193 for two.

Earlier, the home side began with a flourish, courtesy C.V. Milind. Emanjot Singh fell first and Harjas Singh followed, undone by a bouncer. Harpreet Brar was then trapped leg-before and by the 45th minute into day two, Punjab was 315 for nine.

A century for Salil, batting on 73, looked a far cry when Umesh joined him. What followed was a last-wicket resistance.

Umesh dug in, content to defend, while Salil inched towards the 90s.

Then, Salil cut loose, launching the ball over long-off. He brought up his third consecutive century this season with a maximum over extra cover.



On the charge: Salil came up with a career-best show to take Punjab past the 400-run mark. G. RAMAKRISHNA

Umesh, playing second fiddle until then, smashed a six and two fours off Varun Goud, announcing a change of gears.

Salil went past 150 before Rakshann Readdi breached his defences to end the 154-ball 116-run stand heading into lunch. Umesh remained unbeaten on 37 (56b, 3x4, 3x6).

Hyderabad was pegged back before it could settle, Tanmay Agarwal's flick flying straight to Jashanpreet Singh Sidhu at short-leg. Abhirath and Rahul, understandably, batted with some caution.

Their patient approach was rewarded with fifties: Abhirath getting to the milestone off 75 balls while Rahul got there in 105.

Abhirath, however, fell agonisingly short of a century when Salil produced a low, diving catch. By stumps, Hyderabad trailed Punjab by 238 runs.

The scores:

Punjab — 1st innings: Vihaan Malhotra c Ruthik b Rakshann 12, Harnoor Singh c Pragnay b Tanay 17, Prabhsimran Singh b Rakshann 81, Uday Saharan c Rahul Singh b Aniketh 16, Jashanpreet Singh Sidhu run out 45, Salil Arora b Rakshann 151, Ramandeep Singh b Milind 52, Emanjot Singh c Himateja b Milind 9, Harjas Singh c Pragnay b Milind 0, Harpreet Brar lbw Milind 2, Umesh Yadav (batting) 37; Extras (b-7, nb-1, w-1): 9; Total (in 124.5 overs): 431.

Fall of wickets: 1-14, 2-62, 3-105, 4-139, 5-182, 6-275, 7-303, 8-309, 9-315.

Hyderabad bowling: Milind 20-3-79-4, Rakshann 20.5-1-80-3, Ruthik 6-1-18-0, Tanany 41-2-115-1, Aniketh 32-1-112-1, Varun 5-0-20-0.

Hyderabad — 1st innings: Tanmay Agarwal c Jashanpreet b Harpreet 2, Abhirath Reddy c Salil b Umesh 97, Rahul Radesh (batting) 72, K. Himateja (batting) 8; Extras (b-9, lb-5): 14; Total (for two wkts. in 54 overs): 193.

Fall of wickets: 1-15, 2-169.

Punjab bowling: Umesh 12-3-29-1, Harpreet 18-2-59-1, Emanjot 15-0-53-0, Harjas 8-1-36-0, Uday 1-0-2-0.

RANJI TROPHY SCORES – ROUND THREE, DAY TWO

Elite

Group A: At Vadodara: Baroda 616 in 169 overs (Priyanshu Moliya 321 n.o., Deepak Hooda 45, Mahesh Pithiya 102, Rasikh Dar 47, Sahil Lotra 4/160) vs. J&K 6/0 in 4 overs.

At Indore: Bihar 99 & 134 in 34 overs (Ayush Loharuka 76 n.o., Saransh Jain 6/49) lost to Madhya Pradesh 407/8 decl. in 92.2 overs (Yash Dubey 84, Saksham Purohit 132, Rajat Patidar 109). **Points:** Bihar 0 (0), MP 7 (13).

At Nagpur: Goa 220 in 93.5 overs (Yash Kasvankar 63 n.o., Darshan Misal 51, Nachiket Bhute 5/48) vs. Vidarbha 217/3 in 74 overs (R. Samarth 53, Dhruv Shorey 63 batting, Danish Malewar 51 batting).

At Puducherry: Uttar Pradesh 328/9 in 121 overs (Karan Sharma 162 batting, Shivam Mavi 50, Sagar Udeshi 4/62) vs. Pondicherry.

Group B: At Vijayawada: Andhra 231 vs. Chhattisgarh 216/8 in 95 overs (Amandeep Khare 74 batting).

At Hyderabad: Punjab 431 in 124.5 overs (Prabhsimran Singh 81, Jashanpreet Singh Sidhu 45, Salil Arora 151, Ramandeep Singh 52, C.V. Milind 4/79) vs. Hyderabad 193/2 in 54 overs (Abhirath Reddy 97, Rahul Radesh 72 batting).

At Mysuru: Tripura 194 vs. Karnataka 297/7 in 95 overs (Rohan Patil 72, K.V. Aneesh 68, Karun Nair 63).

At Rajkot: Assam 281 in 112.3 overs (Denish Das 90, Sibsankar Roy 100) vs. Saurashtra 156/4 in 68 overs (Hetvik Kotak 65 batting).

Group C: At Ranchi: Delhi 515/5 decl. in 130 overs (Ayush Badoni 210 n.o., Sumit Mathur 150 n.o.) vs. Jharkhand 131/4 in 47 overs (Utkarsh Singh 53 batting).

At Bhubaneswar: Odisha 194 vs. Services 13/0 in 5 overs. No play on second day.

At Pune: Gujarat 223 vs. Maharashtra 278/9 in 100 overs (Digvijay Patil 43, Harshal Kate 84, Saurabh Nawale 95).

At Thiruvananthapuram: Bengal 350 in 102.2 overs (Ankur Paul 66, Shahbaz Ahmed 121, Sumanta Gupta 49, Aditya Sarwate 4/95) vs. Kerala 101/6 in 35 overs (Vishnu Vinod 41).

Group D: At Dehradun: Rajasthan 272 & 39/1 in 23 overs vs. Uttarakhand 194 in 72 overs (Tejasvi Jaiswal 45, Kukna Ajay Singh 5/66).

At Chennai: Railways 184 & 107/9 in 51 overs (S. Yuvraj Singh 42, Sai Kishore 4/38) vs. Tamil Nadu 165 in 63.1 overs (B. Indrajith 59, Raj Choudhury 5/41, Toufik Mondal 4/48).

At Chandigarh: Chandigarh 685/5 decl. in 161 overs (Nehal Pajni 222, Arjun Azad 147, Manan Vohra 61, Arslan Khan 99, Akshit Rana 74, Bhagmender Lather 50 n.o.) vs. Himachal Pradesh 49/0 in 14 overs.

At Mumbai: Mumbai 430 in130.3 overs (Angkrish Raghuvanshi 114, Musheer Khan 109, Sarfaraz Khan 40, Tanush Kotian 52 n.o.) vs. Haryana 108/2 in 39 overs.

Plate

At Rangpo: Nagaland 187 & 46/4 in 34 overs vs. Sikkim 184 in 71 overs (Leeyong Lepcha 43, Imliwati Lemtur 5/40).

At Ahmedabad: Arunachal Pradesh 111 & 95/2 in 36 overs (Techi Doria 44 batting) vs. Manipur 364 in 101.2 overs (Karnajit Yumnam 56, Jotin Pheiroijam 166, Al Bashid Muhammad 69, Likha Sonia 4/56).

At Nadiad: Meghalaya 562 in 137.2 overs (Ajay Duhan 239, Kishan Lyngdoh 198, Kuldip Yadav 4/62) vs. Mizoram 99/2 in 37 overs (Lalhruaizela 51).

Dharanidharan eyes breaching 80m mark

ATHLETICS

Tarun Shastry
CHENNAI

An unusually large crowd – cheering, clapping and whistling – greeted the finalists in the under-20 men's javelin as the curtain came down on the 41st National junior athletics championships at the Nehru Stadium here on Tuesday.

Among them – a youngster from Thanjavur.

A purposeful sprint down the runway, followed by a clean release, saw Dharanidharan open with a throw of 75.34m.

However, second time's the charm. A huge roar just before his run-up, followed by a powerful sprint and a clean release, saw the spear sail through the air before landing at 76.18m.



Dharanidharan. SIVA SANKAR A

The crowd erupted, for Dharanidharan had just produced the throw that would fetch him gold.

He followed it with another effort of 75.37m, making it three successive throws beyond 75m.

Despite winning gold, Dharanidharan had hoped for more. He had come with a target of 80m and was disappointed at not being able to achieve it.

"My aim and goal were different. I really thought I would breach 80m," said the second-year student at Loyola College, who hails from Papanadu in Thanjavur district.

Valuable experience

Having finished sixth at the World U-20 Championships in Eugene, USA, in August, the youngster said the experience of competing against some of the best athletes had helped him improve.

"There were world-class athletes there, and I learned a lot from them," he said.

Interestingly, Dharanidharan began his journey with pole vault in Class IX before financial difficulties forced him to switch to javelin the following year.

Coach pleased

His coach Manikandan, who trains him in Thanjavur, was pleased with his progress.

"We were aiming for 78 to 80 metres. I was confident he could throw 78m at least. He has improved by around three metres in two months, and that is purely because of his hard work and changes to his technique," said Manikandan.

The coach also felt that improving his strength and power would be crucial as Dharanidharan looks to take the next step.

For Dharanidharan, though, the focus is on the upcoming season, when he hopes to breach the 80m mark and perhaps even rewrite the record books.

Salil credits coaches Rajan, Yuvraj for his purple patch

Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

Two men, one franchise, one mentor. Both don Sunrisers Hyderabad colours, and carry Yuvraj Singh's lessons to the crease.

Both scored centuries on Tuesday, but in different languages: one in the staccato verse of international cricket's shortest format, the other in the slow, unhurried prose of the longest on the domestic circuit.

While Abhishek Sharma's blitzkrieg set New Zealand ablaze, about 11,800 kilometres away at the Gymkhana, Salil Arora laid his knock stone by stone - his fourth and highest First-Class ton - to help Punjab rise above Hyderabad. Salil's crucial 93-run stand with Ramandeep Singh on day one and his 116-run 10th-wicket partnership with Umesh Yadav on Tuesday took the wind out of Hyderabad's sails.

The 23-year-old credited his coach, Rajan Gill, and Yuvraj for a Ranji purple patch that has seen him register three centuries on the trot to sit fourth on the runs table.

"After the IPL, I played district matches back home. I then got a few months to work with the red ball. I practised with my coach in Amritsar for almost a month and a half. After that, I got a call from Yuvraj Singh and batted with him for a week," he told *The Hindu*.

"I had problems with my technique last year. Making tweaks to that in Amritsar has given me a lot of benefit."

Salil is no stranger to the City of Pearls.

At home

"Hyderabad feels like home. I'm here for three to four months (during IPL). So it feels good to get 150 here.

"The team needed it. I thought if I play till the end, we'll be able to score 400. I was just playing according to the merit of the ball and to the situation."

Flat track

"Yes, it's a flat wicket. The batters did their job, and now it's the bowlers' turn to take responsibility," he concluded.



Making it a habit: Salil brought up his third hundred on the trot. G. RAMAKRISHNA

Neelam, Kajal assure medals for India

WRESTLING WORLDS

Sports Bureau

After the Indian Greco-Roman wrestlers' dismal performance, Neelam Sirohi (50kg) and Kajal Dhochak (76kg) brought cheer to the country by entering the women's finals and securing medals at the World wrestling championships in Astana on Tuesday.

The 26-year-old Neelam got past Belarusian Natalia Varakina 6-0, defeated the top-seeded Elizaveta Sirnova (due to an injury to the Russian) and beat Kazakhstan's Asian Games bronze medallist Zeinep Bayanova 7-3.

She set up a title clash with Japanese star Yui Susaki, a former World and Olympic champion and the reigning Asian Games champion.

After Neelam's show in the lightest weight class, two-time World junior champion Kajal stamped her authority in the heaviest weight category. She pinned Lithuanian Kamile Gaucaite before defeating Mongolian Davaanasan Enkh Amar 9-2 and Kyrgyzstan's Aiperi Medet Kyzy 10-7. She will take on Ukraine's Anastasiya Alpyeyeva in the gold-medal match. Rajnita (65kg) reached the repechage round to remain in the hunt for a bronze medal.

Bangladesh seeks Test c'ship boost



Key men: Shanto and Mushfiqur's experience will be vital as Bangladesh takes on the West Indies challenge. AP

WI IN BANGLADESH

Agence France-Presse
DHAKA

Bangladesh skipper Najmul Hossain Shanto said on Tuesday that the prospect of making the World Test Championship final inspired his team heading into a two-match series against the West Indies.

Currently fourth in the WTC standings, Bangladesh has six Tests remaining in the cycle, including the West Indies opener in Mirpur starting on Wednesday.

Bangladesh will need to win at least four and draw one of its six Tests to have a chance of making the final, scheduled between June 9 and 13 at the Oval in London. And Shanto stressed that there is no pressure.

"I find it inspiring rather than pressurising," Shanto told reporters.

"We do not want to do anything extra. We want to follow our process and give 100% to the things we know how to do."

The host enters the Test series after failing to take the final seven wickets against Afghanistan in its most recent Test in the United Arab Emirates.

An opportunity

Meanwhile, West Indies captain Roston Chase said his team wanted to climb up the WTC standings from the No. 8 position. "This is the last series...if we want to make any strides in terms of going up the table, it has to be in this series," he said.

"We're in some good form coming into this series, so we want to take two wins and try to take ourselves up the ladder".

BFI told to keep the no-confidence meeting in abeyance

Sports Bureau
KOLKATA

The Punjab and Haryana High Court on Tuesday directed Boxing Federation of India (BFI) secretary-general Pramod Kumar to keep the General Body meeting called on Oct. 28, to move a no-confidence motion against president Ajay Singh, in abeyance until the next hearing on Nov. 13. Following a petition filed by Ajay Singh, Justice Tribhuvan Dahiya issued the direction. On Oct. 23, World Boxing had emphasised that a General Meeting of the federation must be convened and conducted in accordance with the BFI constitution.

Navdeep seeks javelin's inclusion in LA28

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

India's Paralympic champion Navdeep Singh has appealed for the inclusion of men's F41 javelin throw in the Los Angeles 2028 Paralympics programme and taken up shot put as a back-up, refusing to let uncertainty over his primary event derail his preparations for the next Games.

The 25-year-old, who won bronze in men's F41 javelin at the Asian Para Games in Aichi-Nagoya recently, said he had started training for shot put after learning that javelin would not feature in his category at LA28.

The athlete said he had approached members of the national federation and urged them to appeal to the International Paralympic Committee (IPC), the global governing body of the Paralympic Movement, seeking javelin's inclusion in the Games. "If athletes in our category have to participate in LA, they will only be able to compete in shot put. The athletes should have the option to choose between events. That is why we have made this appeal. The positive thing is we have an event at next year's World championships. So we will try to get it included at LA28".



Navdeep... staying positive. FILE PHOTO: SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Snapping ties abruptly with a match made in heaven



GETTY IMAGES

When he dismissed Kent's Zimbabwean batter Tawanda Muyeye for his third scalp of the innings and his 50th of the season on September 15, James Anderson would hardly have imagined that it would be his final wicket for Lancashire

R. Kaushik

In one fell swoop, without warning or indication, without even a hint of what was coming, a 26-year-old association was snapped in a jiffy. Inarguably the greatest son of the soil was let go without so much as a thank you, a decision that has so infuriated members and supporters that the 'offending' party is now contemplating a formal farewell to celebrate the life and times of Test cricket's most prolific wicket-taker among fast bowlers.

When he dismissed Kent's Zimbabwean batter Tawanda Muyeye for his third wicket of the innings and his 50th of the season on September 15, James Anderson would hardly have imagined that it would be his final wicket-taking contribution to Lancashire. Having taken over the captaincy of the embattled county towards the middle of the 2025 season, he was appointed full-time skipper in the season gone by.



Fabulous campaign

Personally, it was another fabulous campaign for the 44-year-old king of swing, whose 50 wickets came at the fantastic average of 17.68. But the team spiralled from one disaster to another, finishing second from last in Division Two, its worst-ever Championship finish.

Incoming director of cricket Paul Farbrace, who has ambitiously charted out a four-year time-frame to return the county to its glory days, and recently appointed chief executive Richard Kenyon have held forth on the need to rebuild the stuttering outfit and clearly, they feel that despite plenty of fight still left in Anderson, he doesn't exactly figure in their immediate long-term plans.

Anderson became superfluous to England's scheme of things under Ben Stokes and Brendon McCullum in July 2024 when he was ushered into retirement after the Lord's Test against West Indies. At the time, he had expressed the desire to play on for another three years, assuming blithely – and justifiably – that he would wind down his First Class career with the team he had served outstandingly for so long. Unfortunately, that was not to be after the county decided to sever ties with the champion who took 443 First Class wickets, 83 List A scalps and 50 T20 wickets in 213 matches across formats.

Even in the short interlude since Lancashire's dramatic and largely unpopular call, several counties have started weighing up their options because they believe that even when he is 45, which he will turn midway through next season, Anderson still is far from a spent force or a liability. But while Anderson hasn't yet invoked the R (retirement) word, it's hard to see him switching allegiance at this late stage of his career. Anderson made his displeasure at the call apparent without launching into an all-out attack, saying in a statement, "If it was up to me, it wouldn't have ended like this, but I wish the players and fans all the best for the future." But sadly, it wasn't up to him, and so this is how it has ended.

One hopes that when the emotions settle down, both parties concerned will be able to look back at the long-standing relationship with fondness and nostalgia. Anderson cut his teeth with Lancashire as a 17-year-old in 2000, made his First Class debut in 2002 and was playing One-Day International cricket that same year. His Test debut came in May 2003, also at Lord's where he made his final appearance for his country, and from then on, he became one of the most valued members of the five-day squad, striking up an excellent relationship with that other great England pacer of his generation, Stuart Broad.

Easy, repeatable action

A master of swing who went on and on because of his easy, repeatable action that seemingly put very little strain on his body, Anderson was at his most prolific at home, of course, but it wasn't as if he struggled to adapt to the challenges of the subcontinent where, more than anywhere else, overseas quicks have struggled to make an impact. Towards the later stages of his career, he developed the scrambled-seam delivery that brought him great success, but for the large part, especially but not only with the new ball, he was the master of having the ball on a string and making it go this way and that with a gentle tug here, a little pull there.

An overwhelming majority of his 704 Test wickets came on home turf - 438, which accounted for 62.22% of all his successes in the five-day game - but that's also because he played 106 of his 188 Tests in England. For a fast bowler to continue on for 21 years at the highest level and average nearly nine Tests a year is little short of staggering; it speaks to not just his fitness levels and his propensity to take excellent care of his body, but also to his commitment and hunger and fire and passion, traits that aren't necessarily the most prominent in an era where shelf-lives are getting increasingly shorter and the lure of the 20-over shootout is almost impossible to resist.

Anderson was at his most comfortable with the Duke's ball in his right hand, a ball he practically grew up with, though he showed his felicity with the Kookaburra used in most other parts of the world. Across Australia, New Zealand and South Africa, he snaffled 138 wickets in 40 matches, not in the out-of-the-world category but definitely numbers that exploded the myth that he was a home bully. He also had decent success in India with the SG Test which he isn't all that familiar with - 17 Tests across 18 years fetched him 44 wickets. On his last tour of India in February-March 2024, he grabbed 10 wickets in four outings, gatecrashing into the hitherto exclusive 700-club of Muttiah Muralitharan and Shane Warne in the scenic surrounds of Dharamshala in the final Test of a five-match series that the hosts bossed 4-1.

In perfect harmony

Anderson in action wasn't unlike poetry in motion, with his unhurried and visibly inexplosive run-up and perfect harmony between the operative body parts as he slotted into his delivery stride. It wasn't as if he didn't have bad days, but they were so few and far between as to fall in the 'hen's teeth' section. When the conditions favoured him, he got the ball to whoop around corners, but even when there wasn't much help on offer, he was still a perennial threat because he was always at the batters, giving them not a moment's respite.

That he didn't lose his swing even for a short period over such an extended timeframe at the top level is tribute to his perseverance and humility. Sometimes, it is easy to get carried away with what might appear to be a God-given gift but which needs to be honed and polished and worked on assiduously, day after day, practice session after training stint. Anderson knew he was special, but he also knew that to take that for granted would come with terrible repercussions. Hence the constant quest to keep improving, to keep becoming a better version of himself, to keep plugging away at the nets and in game situations, so that he did not remain static while the world moved ahead of him.

In so many ways, England's decision to disassociate themselves from Anderson after the disastrous 2015 50-over World Cup campaign proved to be a masterstroke. After their first-round elimination – defeat to Bangladesh pulled the rug from under their feet and ensured that they didn't even make it to the quarterfinals despite eight teams advancing to the knockouts – England's bosses got together and arrived at the conclusion that they needed to be smart about how they went about their business. There was a distinct slant towards all-rounders (not just utility players like Mark Ealham and Ronnie Irani and their likes in the mid-1990s), which meant alongside Broad, Anderson was put out to pasture.

Collateral damage

Anderson's ODI numbers at the stage were anything but ordinary – 269 wickets in 194 matches, economy 4.92, a wicket every six overs – but he was collateral damage as a new-age mentality took deep root under Eoin Morgan's captaincy. Who's to say that the Morgan philosophy was flawed, given that England, finally, clinched the World Cup on home patch in 2019 even though they didn't actually beat New Zealand on the field in the final, either in regulation time or in the Super Over, both of which ended with scores level.

Anderson had bowled close to 1,600 overs in ODIs by March 2015, and though he pulled the plug on his List A career in 2019, the T20 challenge was something he was willing to take on head-on. In what has since become his final season with Lancashire, he figured in the domestic T20 blast, mostly fastidiously parsimonious even if, in his final 20-over outing for the county, he ended up conceding 50 runs in his four overs in the 22-run defeat of bitter rivals Yorkshire in the War of the Roses.

Because the next county season isn't until another six months from now, one might get the impression that Anderson has some time before deciding on his next course of action. Only he can say with certainty if he is contemplating a change of counties, if only for one final hurrah; the most dramatic script will entail him taking a bagful of wickets against his old home and bowling his new side to the most comprehensive of victories, but such fairytale scripts seldom play out in real life.

The big call ahead of him is whether he is game to give it one more shot from an unfamiliar dressing room after having spent all his professional career with Lancs since his maiden appearance as a teenager. Whether he swings in that direction remains to be seen. What is beyond question is the magnificence of his craft, the joy he brought so many with his command and control, his prime position in the pantheon of cricketing greats and the almost iron-clad certainty that he will remain the only fast bowler in the 700-wicket club in Test cricket for a long, long time to come.



THE GIST

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- He knew he was special, but he also knew that to take that for granted would come with terrible repercussions
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